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4-8 NOVEMBER 2026
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WELCOME

Welcome to the 16th edition of the Aesthetica Film Festival. It is with great excitement that I introduce you to this year's event, which has so much on offer. The 2026 programme brings together world-class independent film, with immersive VR experiences, innovative games and the return of our Podcast Lounge and New Music Stage, creating multiple ways to engage with culture and storytelling.

At its heart, Aesthetica champions exceptional creative work whilst sparking conversations about the power of screen and media. They have a unique ability to illuminate untold stories, foster empathy and inspire change. Alongside it, XR and emerging technologies continue to expand the possibilities of narrative, inviting audiences into new worlds and perspectives. Together, these art forms encourage curiosity, imagination and connection. Our 2026 programme spans an extraordinarily wide range of genres. The VR Lab returns with 25 immersive projects that push the boundaries of storytelling, whilst the Games Lab showcases 55 new titles to play, from independent creators. Aesthetica remains the only UK film festival to integrate games into its public programme, reflecting our commitment to celebrating the full spectrum of screen culture. The Podcasting Lounge also returns, offering space to discover powerful narratives told through audio.

One of the most rewarding aspects of the festival is seeing a vibrant community of makers, audiences and industry leaders come together in York. The city becomes a hub for innovation and exchange, welcoming visitors from across the country and around the world. We are also hosting the UK Production Summit, bringing together 150 leading companies with a keynote from Farhana Bhula, Director, Film4. As the festival continues to evolve, we are expanding beyond a traditional model into a wider celebration of screen culture and live

performance. For example, the New Music Stage welcomes BBC Radio 1's Jess Iszatt and showcases 10 breakthrough artists spanning indie, hip-hop and pop. Running alongside the festival is the UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO, featuring 40 creative businesses. The EXPO celebrates York's position as the UK's only UNESCO City of Media Arts and one of just 28 worldwide. Open to both festival audiences and the general public, it highlights the innovation taking place in the city and beyond. New for this year is a programme of talks at the EXPO, focusing on the business of the creative industries.

Our film screenings are curated by genre – from Animation and Comedy to Drama, Documentary, Thriller, Family Friendly and more. These collections reflect the richness of the human experience. There are guest programmes from our partners, including the BBC and *Guardian*, which demonstrate the rich global reach of contemporary storytelling. Industry masterclasses welcome experts from Aardman, BBC Film, Film4 and Ridley Scott Associates alongside award-winning directors, costume designers, sound mixers, editors, producers and VFX supervisors.

Workshops explore AI, VR, careers in gaming and adaptation, whilst younger audiences can discover filmmaking, acting, coding and the magic of stop-motion animation. Visitors are invited to explore the Film Poster Exhibition, the Radical Listening Media Arts Trail, 13 world premieres presented in partnership with Audible and our experimental composing event with six brand new commissions.

I encourage you to take a leap into something new – watch a film outside your comfort zone, play an independent game or step into an XR experience. There is a universe of discovery waiting at Aesthetica, and your participation makes this festival so special.

Cherie Federico, Festival Director

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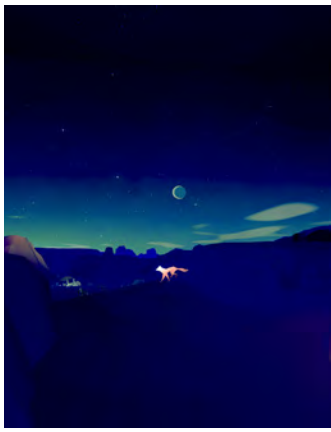

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ACCESSIBILITY

A SAFE AND ALL-INCLUSIVE ENVIRONMENT FOR EVERY ATTENDEE

- **Carers, Personal Assistants & Interpreters**
  Complimentary passes are available to all Carers, Personal Assistants and Sign-Language Interpreters, but these must be booked in advance. A proof of DLA or a valid CEA card will be required for booking. For more information, please email office@asff.co.uk.

- **Venue Access**
  Although some of the venues at the festival are located in York's historic buildings, the majority of this year's locations are fully or partially wheelchair accessible – please check our venues over on **p. 31** for further details. Wheelchair spaces are subject to availability.

- **Hearing Loops & Subtitled Screenings**
  Hearing Loops and headphones are available at City Screen and at York St John Creative Centre. Fully subtitled reels are available across all genres. These screenings are specially curated for anyone with hearing difficulties. Look out for the SUB symbol in the film schedule. Foreign language films are also with English subtitles and are clearly marked.

- **Parent & Guardian Screenings**
  As part of our commitment to engage with younger audiences, we present a selection of Family Friendly screenings. Please see **p. 125** to learn more about this year's offerings.

FURTHER INFORMATION

For all accessibility enquiries and adjustments, please email office@asff.co.uk.
Alternatively, the Hub staff will be able to answer any questions during the festival (9:30-18:00)

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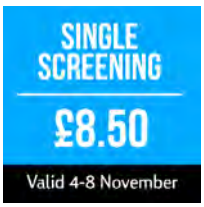
TICKETS & PASSES



- Valid for one screening at any venue from 4-8 November
- Seating is arranged on a first-come, first-served basis

ADULT: **£8.50** | SENIOR: **£7** | STUDENT: **£7** | 5-14 YEARS: **£7** | 4 & UNDER: **FREE**

- One day in-venue access to screenings and events
- Attend masterclasses, workshops, labs and more (pre-register online)
- Ticket is valid for one day within 4-8 November
- A Saturday Day ticket includes entry to the New Music Stage

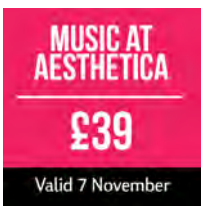
ADULT: **£39** | SENIOR: **£33** | STUDENT: **£33** | 5-14 YEARS: **£30** | YORK RESIDENT: **25% OFF**

- Two days in-venue access to screenings and events
- Attend masterclasses, workshops, labs and more (pre-register online)
- Ticket is valid for two days within 4-8 November
- A Saturday ticket includes entry to the New Music Stage

ADULT: **£65** | SENIOR: **£55** | STUDENT: **£55** | 5-14 YEARS: **£50**

- Five days in-venue access to screenings and events
- Attend masterclasses, workshops, labs and more (pre-register online)
- Ticket is valid 4-8 November
- Includes entry to the New Music Stage on Saturday 7 November

ADULT: **£120** | SENIOR: **£100** | STUDENT: **£100**



- Access to the New Music Stage at York Theatre Royal
- See **pg. 66** for more information
- Access to all festival events happening on Saturday 7 November

TICKET PRICE: **£39**

WEDNESDAY 4 NOVEMBER

For ratings and more information on films, see detailed listings from pg. 73

TIME	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 1	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 2	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 3	FRIARGATE	YORKSHIRE MUSEUM	YORK THEATRE ROYAL STUDIO	YORK THEATRE ROYAL MAIN HOUSE
10:00 - 10:30 - 11:00 - 11:30	Drama 15	Comedy 1 SUB	Experimental 4	Documentary 2	VFX with Academy Award-winning Framestore	Finding Your Directorial Voice: Filmmaker Conversation	Pick & Mix 1 Animation
12:00 - 12:30 - 13:00	Animation 1	New Wave: York St John	Drama 7	Family Friendly 1 (U) SUB	The Role of the Camera Operator	In Other Worlds: Film and Future World-Building	Legacy on Film: The Story Behind Ridley Scott Associates
13:30 - 14:00 - 14:30 - 15:00	Drama 9	Thriller 2		Drama 14	From Broadcast to Streaming: Producing TV in the UK Today	Storytelling in Games: Crafting Narrative	Film4: Shorts to Features
15:30 - 16:00 - 16:30 - 17:00	Documentary 1 SUB	Drama 17		Comedy 3	Meet Commissioners from BBC, ITV, Channel 5 & Sky	Driving Inclusion at ITV: Diversity, Equity & Representation	Drama 8
17:30 - 18:00 - 18:30 - 19:00	Experimental 5	Comedy 6		Music Video 1	Drama 6	Making Puffin Crafting Animation for Young Audiences	Animation 5
19:30 - 20:00 - 20:30 - 21:00	Opening Night Ceremony (Arrival from 18:00 pre-booked tickets only)	Drama 2		Thriller 3	Documentary 3	Drama 3	Aesthetica & York Theatre Royal: New Voices, New Stories
21:30 - 22:00 - 22:30 - 23:00	Drama 5	Comedy 5		Documentary 5	Dance 1 SUB	Artist's Film 3	
					Animation 2	Music Video 2	

	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	CITY SCREEN BASEMENT	MALMAISON	CITY SCREEN	SPARK	YORK THEATRE ROYAL UPPER FOYER	YORK THEATRE ROYAL COLONNADE
10:00 - 10:30	VR Lab	Games Lab	Podcast Lounge	Pitching & 1:1s Stak (12:00-14:00) Channel 5 (12:00-14:00) Ridley Scott Associates (15:00-17:00) Dartmouth Films (15:00-17:00) Film4 (15:30-17:30 (Application Only)	Film Poster Exhibition	Workshop: Scottish Games Network Filmmakers' World Cafe Workshop: The Pitch: Learn About Adaptation Workshop: Film Hub North Roundtable	Networking: VFX for Independent Filmmakers Chaucer £20,000 Film Grant Launch	Makers' Forum: Spotlight Sessions with Our Official Selection
11:00 - 11:30								
11:30 - 12:00	VR Lab	Games Lab						
12:00 - 12:30								
12:30 - 13:00								
13:00 - 13:30	VR Lab	Games Lab						
13:30 - 14:00								
14:00 - 14:30								
14:30 - 15:00	VR Lab	Games Lab						
15:00 - 15:30								
15:30 - 16:00								
16:00 - 16:30	VR Lab	Games Lab	Masterclass: Inside Podcasting					
16:30 - 17:00								
17:00 - 17:30								
17:30 - 18:00	VR Lab	Games Lab						
18:00 - 18:30								
18:30 - 19:00								
19:00 - 19:30	VR Lab	Games Lab						
19:30 - 20:00								
20:00 - 20:30								
20:30 - 21:00	VR Lab	Games Lab						
21:00 - 21:30								
21:30 - 22:00								
22:00 - 22:30								
22:30 - 23:00								

DAILY EVENTS

WEDNESDAY 4 NOVEMBER

MASTERCLASSES & WORKSHOPS	VENUE	TIME
VFX with Academy Award-winning Framestore	Yorkshire Museum	10:30-11:30
Finding Your Directorial Voice: Filmmakers in Conversation	York Theatre Royal Studio	10:30-11:30
Workshop: The Power of Playful Thinking with Scottish Games Network	Spark	10:30-11:30
In Other Worlds: Film and Future World-Building	York Theatre Royal Studio	12:00-13:00
The Role of the Camera Operator	Yorkshire Museum	12:00-13:00
A Legacy on Film: The Story Behind Ridley Scott Associates	York Theatre Royal Main House	12:00-13:00
Workshop: Filmmakers' World Cafe: With the Visionaries of Our Official Selection	Spark	12:00-13:30
From Broadcast to Streaming: Producing TV in the UK Today	Yorkshire Museum	13:30-14:30
Storytelling in Games: Crafting Narrative Across Platforms	York Theatre Royal Studio	13:30-14:30
Film4: From Shorts to Features	York Theatre Royal Main House	13:30-14:30
Workshop: The Pitch: Learn about Adaptation	Spark	14:00-15:00
Meet Commissioners from BBC, Channel 5, ITV and Sky	Yorkshire Museum	15:00-16:00
Driving Inclusion at ITV: Diversity, Equity and Representation	York Theatre Royal Studio	15:00-16:00
Workshop: Roundtable: Film Hub North	Spark	16:00-17:00
Making Puffin Rock: Crafting Animation for Young Audiences	York Theatre Royal Studio	16:30-17:30
Inside Podcasting: Cutting through the Noise	City Screen Basement	16:30-17:30

EVENTS & NETWORKING	VENUE	TIME
Official Selection: Games Lab	**NCEM**	10.00-21.30
Official Selection: VR Lab	**NCEM**	10.00-21.30
Official Selection: Podcasting Lounge	**City Screen Basement**	10.00-21.30
Film Poster Exhibition	**City Screen**	9:30-22:30
Makers' Forum	**York Theatre Royal Colonnade Cafe**	10:00-18:00
Networking: VFX for Indie Filmmakers: Making the Impossible Work	**York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer**	12:00-13:30
York: A Creative Hub Stakeholder Lunch (Invitation Only)	**The Ivy**	12:00-14:00
Radical Listening Media Arts Trail	**City Centre**	9:00-22:00
1:1 Feedback Session: Stak (Application only)	**Malmaison**	12:00-14:00
Pitching: Channel 5 (Application only)	**Malmaison**	12:00-14:00
Chaucer £20,000 Film Grant Launch Event	**York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer**	14:00-15:00
Pitching: Dartmouth Films (Application only)	**Malmaison**	15:00-17:00
Pitching: Ridley Scott Associates (Application only)	**Malmaison**	15:00-17:00
Pitching: Film 4 (Application only)	**Malmaison**	15:30-17:30
Opening Night Ceremony (Separate ticket required)	**City Screen**	18:00-Late

THURSDAY 5 NOVEMBER

For ratings and more information on films, see detailed listings from pg. 73

	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 1	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 2	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 3	FRIARGATE	YORKSHIRE MUSEUM	YORK THEATRE ROYAL STUDIO	YORK THEATRE ROYAL MAIN HOUSE	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC
09:00									
09:30									
10:00	Drama 12	Documentary 1 (SUB)	Drama 17	Thriller 1	Neal Street Productions: Award Winning Stories	Truth on Screen How to Make a Standout Documentary	Classics from Aardman	VR Lab	Games Lab
10:30									
11:00									
11:30					Ideas to Greenlight: Bringing Your Story to Life	A Shared Vision: The Craft of Collaboration	Pick & Mix 2 Docs, Drama and Dance	VR Lab	Games Lab
12:00	Animation 3	New Wave: Regents University	Comedy 6	Family Friendly 2 (U)					
12:30									
13:00					The Producer's Role: Stories Behind Cameras	Games in Focus: Inside an Evolving Industry	BBC Film: The Next Generation	VR Lab	Games Lab
13:30	Documentary 4	Drama 8		Artists' Film 1					
14:00									
14:30					The Future of XR: Entertainment and Beyond	Sync Licensing A Practical Guide with Beggar's Group	A Directing Masterclass: In Conversation w/ Mark Jenkin	VR Lab	Games Lab
15:00	Drama 11 (SUB)	Comedy 5		Experimental 4					
15:30									
16:00					The Art of the Short: Writing for Screen with Justine Hart	Introducing The New Wave of British Cinema	Animation 1	VR Lab	Games Lab
16:30									
17:00	Experimental 2			Drama 4 (SUB)					
17:30					Animation 4	AI is Here: What Happens Next?		VR Lab	Games Lab
18:00		Reignite XVII (Pre-Booking Required)							
18:30									
19:00	Comedy 1 (SUB)			Documentary 6	Thriller 4 (SUB)	Drama 15	Beyond the Frame: Nosferatu with Live Score Separate Ticket Required	VR Lab	Games Lab
19:30		Animation 5							
20:00									
20:30								VR Lab	Games Lab
21:00	Drama 3 (End 22:30)	Documentary 5 (End 22:30)		Drama 1 (End 22:30)	Comedy 4 (End 22:30)	Thriller 3 (End 22:30)			
21:30									
22:00									

	CITY SCREEN BASEMENT	MALMAISON	CITY SCREEN	DE GREY ROOMS	SPARK	YORK THEATRE ROYAL COLONNADE	SOCIALS / NETWORKING	THE GRAND
09:00 - 09:30 - 10:00	Podcast Lounge	Pitching & 1:1s Ridley Scott Associates (10:00-12:00) Dog Ears (10:00-12:00) BBC Film (10:00-12:00) Cinesite (11:00-13:00) ITV (12:00-14:00) The Pitch (12:00-14:00)	Film Poster Exhibition	UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO (09:00-12:00 Booked Educational Groups Only) 12:00-21:00 Open to All	Virtual Imperative 2 Conference (9:00-11:00) How to Attract top Actors to Your Short BBC Writers Pilot Scheme Breaking into Screenwriting Roundtable: Careers in Interactive Media Virtual Imperative 2 Conference (16:00-18:00)	Makers' Forum: Spotlight Sessions with Our Official Selection	YORK THEATRE ROYAL UPPER FOYER Story Exchange Ideas in Motion THOR'S TIPI VR & Gaming Happy Hour	UK Production Company Summit (Invitation Only) TREMBLING MADNESS Meet the Music Industry
10:30 - 11:00 - 11:30 - 12:00 - 12:30 - 13:00 - 13:30 - 14:00 - 14:30 - 15:00 - 15:30 - 16:00 - 16:30 - 17:00 - 17:30 - 18:00 - 18:30 - 19:00 - 19:30 - 20:00 - 20:30 - 21:00 - 21:30 - 22:00 -								

DAILY EVENTS

THURSDAY 5 NOVEMBER

MASTERCLASSES & WORKSHOPS	VENUE	TIME
Truth on Screen: How to Make a Standout Documentary	York Theatre Royal Studio	10:00-11:00
Neal Street Productions: The Making of Award-Winning Stories	Yorkshire Museum	10:00-11:00
Idea to Greenlight: Bringing Your Story to Life	Yorkshire Museum	11:30-12:30
A Shared Vision: The Craft of Collaborative Filmmaking	York Theatre Royal Studio	11:30-12:30
Workshop: How to Attract Top Actors to Your Short or Feature Project	Spark	11:30-12:30
The Producer's Role: Shaping Stories Behind the Camera	Yorkshire Museum	13:00-14:00
Games in Focus: Inside a Rapidly Evolving Industry	York Theatre Royal Studio	13:00-14:00
BBC Film: The Next Generation	York Theatre Royal Main House	13:00-14:00
Workshop: BBC Writers Pilot Scheme: Breaking into Screenwriting	Spark	13:00-14:00
The Future of XR: Entertainment and Beyond	Yorkshire Museum	14:30-15:30
A Directing Masterclass: In Conversation with Mark Jenkin	York Theatre Royal Main House	14:30-15:30
Sync Licensing: A Creative and Practical Guide	York Theatre Royal Studio	14:30-15:30
Workshop: Roundtable: Careers in Interactive Media	Spark	14:30-15:30
The Art of the Short: Writing for Screen with Justine Hart	Yorkshire Museum	16:00-17:00
Introducing the New Wave of British Cinema	York Theatre Royal Studio	16:00-17:00
AI is Here: What Happens Next	York Theatre Royal Studio	17:30-18:30
Reignite XVII: Culture as Infrastructure, Stories as Power	City Screen 2	18:00-19:30

EVENTS & NETWORKING	VENUE	TIME
UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO	**De Grey Rooms**	9:00-21:00
Radical Listening Media Arts Trail	**Exhibition Square, York Theatre Royal, King's Square**	9:00-22:00
UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO Workshops	**De Grey Rooms**	10:00-15:00
Virtual Imperative 2: Conference (Separate Ticket Required)	**Spark**	09:00-18:00
Official Selection: Games Lab	**NCEM**	10.00-21.30
Official Selection: VR Lab	**NCEM**	10.00-21.30
Official Selection: Podcasting Lounge	**City Screen Basement**	10.00-21.30
Film Poster Exhibition	**City Screen**	10:00-22:30
Pitching: Ridley Scott Associates (Application only)	**Malmaison**	10:00-12:00
Pitching: BBC Film (Application only)	**Malmaison**	10:00-12:00
1:1 Feedback Session: Dog Ears & Cinesite (Application only)	**Malmaison**	10:00-12:00
Pitching: ITV (Application only)	**Malmaison**	12:00-14:00
Pitching: The Pitch (Application only)	**Malmaison**	12:00-14:00
Story Exchange: Ideas in Motion with Film Hub North	**York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer**	12:00-13:30
UK Production Company Summit (Invitation only)	**The Grand**	15:00-20:00
VR & Gaming Happy Hour	**Thor's Tipi**	17:00-18:00
Meet the Music Industry	**House of Trembling Madness**	20:00-21:00

FRIDAY 6 NOVEMBER

For ratings and more information on films, see detailed listings from pg. 73

	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 1	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 2	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 3	FRIARGATE	YORKSHIRE MUSEUM	YORK THEATRE ROYAL STUDIO	YORK THEATRE ROYAL MAIN HOUSE	CITY SCREEN BASEMENT
10:00	Drama 6	Animation 6	Dance 3	Family Friendly 3 (PG)	Bohemian Rhapsody to Wuthering Heights	Hear from Derry Girls Producer Brian J. Falconer	Pick & Mix 3 Docs, Drama, Dance	Podcast Lounge
11:30	Documentary 1 (SUB)	Drama 11	Thriller 1	Drama 17	A Look Inside the Actor-Director Relationship	Writing the Future: Inside The Pitch's £2.5k Commission	50 Years of Aardman Animation	
13:00	Experimental 5	Writing for Television: Neil Forsyth in Conversation		Animation 2	The Final Cut: What Happens in the Edit	From Brief to Screen: Working with Brands	Celebrating 50 Years: with Aardman Animation	
15:00	Drama 2	Comedy 2 (SUB)		Drama 1	Making UK TV: In Conversation with Scott Free	Radical Listening: New Scores to Silent Cinema	Drama 10	
16:30					Comedy 6	Icons of Television: Meet BBC Comedy	Animation 3	
17:30	Documentary 3	Drama 13		Experimental 1 (SUB)	BBC Writers What Makes a Great Script	Music Supervision How to Craft a Film Soundtrack		
19:00	Comedy 4	Listening Pitch Audible & Aesthetica Film Premiere Launch Party		Advertising	Fashion	Artists' Film 2		
21:00	Drama 16 (Until 22:30) (SUB)	Dance 2 (Until 22:30)		Drama 4 (SUB)	Documentary 6	Experimental 3	Beyond the Frame: Seann Walsh: This is Torture	

	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	MALMAISON	DE GREY ROOMS	SPARK	YORK THEATRE ROYAL	VARIOUS VENUES	THE IVY	YTR COLONNADE
9:00 - 9:30				UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO (09:00-12:00 Booked Educational Groups Only) 12:00-21:00 Open to All					
9:30 - 10:00									
10:00 - 10:30	VR Lab	Games Lab	Pitching Ridley Scott Associates (10:00-12:00)		Workshop Finding Adaptable IP				Makers' Forum: Spotlight Sessions with Our Official Selection
10:30 - 11:00									
11:00 - 11:30									
11:30 - 12:00	VR Lab	Games Lab	BFI Doc Society (10:00-12:00)		Roundtable: Voices from the Official VR Selection				
12:00 - 12:30									
12:30 - 13:00			BBC Comedy (11:00-13:30)						
13:00 - 13:30	VR Lab	Games Lab			Workshop: Directing / Working with Actors for Screen	Networking: Bring Your Ideas: Meet The Pitch Commissions Team			
13:30 - 14:00			Neal Street Productions (14:30-16:30)				MASTERCLASS: Calling the Shots YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre		
14:00 - 14:30									
14:30 - 15:00	VR Lab	Games Lab	BBC Writers (15:00-17:00)		Games 1:1s Ubisoft Reflections				
15:00 - 15:30									
15:30 - 16:00			(Application Only)						
16:00 - 16:30	VR Lab	Games Lab				Networking: Powering Creativity (De Grey Rooms then YTR at 17:00)			
16:30 - 17:00									
17:00 - 17:30							MASTERCLASS: Making a Short YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre	In Focus: Women Shaping the Screen Industries	
17:30 - 18:00	VR Lab	Games Lab							
18:00 - 18:30									
18:30 - 19:00							Boat Party: Celebrate with The Pitch (King's Staith Landing)		
19:00 - 19:30	VR Lab	Games Lab							
19:30 - 20:00									
20:00 - 20:30							Friday Night Party (Dusk & Drawing Board)		
20:30 - 21:00	VR Lab	Games Lab							
21:00 - 21:30									
21:30 - 22:00									

DAILY EVENTS

FRIDAY 6 NOVEMBER

MASTERCLASSES & WORKSHOPS	VENUE	TIME
Global TV, Regional Context: Hear from Derry Girls Producer Brian J Falconer	York Theatre Royal Studio	10:00-11:00
Workshop: Finding Adaptable IP: From Idea to Screen	Spark	10:00-11:00
Bohemian Rhapsody to Wuthering Heights A Masterclass in Sound Design	Yorkshire Museum	10:00-11:00
Writing the Future: Inside The Pitch's £2,500 Writing Commission	York Theatre Royal Studio	11:30-12:30
A Look Inside the Actor-Director Dynamic	Yorkshire Museum	11:30-12:30
Workshop: Inside the Virtual Studio: Voices from the Creators of our Official VR Selection	Spark	11:30-12:30
Workshop: Directing/Working with Actors for Screen	Spark	13:00-14:30
The Final Cut: What Happens in the Edit	Yorkshire Museum	13:00-14:00
Celebrating 50 Years: Behind the Scenes at Aardman	York Theatre Royal Main House	13:00-14:00
Brief to Screen: Working with Brands from Nike to Sky	York Theatre Royal Studio	13:00-14:00
Calling the Shots: Women Driving Production	YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre	14:00-15:00
Making UK TV: In Conversation with Head of Development at Scott Free	Yorkshire Museum	14:30-15:30
Writing for Television: Neil Forsyth in Conversation	City Screen 2	15:00-16:00
Icons of Television: Meet the BBC Comedy Team	York Theatre Royal Studio	16:15-17:15
How to Make a Short: Insights from Filmmakers	YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre	17:00-18:00
BBC Writers: What Makes a Great Script	Yorkshire Museum	17:30-18:30
Music Supervision - How to Craft a Film Soundtrack	York Theatre Royal Studio	17:30-18:30

EVENTS & NETWORKING	VENUE	TIME
UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO	**De Grey Rooms**	9:00-21:00
UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO Workshops	**De Grey Rooms**	10:00-15:00
Official Selection: Games Lab	**NCEM**	10:00-21:30
Official Selection: VR Lab	**NCEM**	10:00-21:30
1:1 Feedback Sessions: Dartmouth Films **BBC Comedy, Cinesite & Ubisoft** (Application only)	**Malmaison**	Various times
Official Selection: Podcasting Lounge	**City Screen Basement**	10.00-21:30
Pitching: Ridley Scott Associates (Application only)	**Malmaison**	10:00-12:00
Pitching: Doc Society (Application only)	**Malmaison**	10:00-12:00
Networking: Bring Your Ideas **Meet The Pitch Commissioning Team**	**York Theatre** **Royal Upper Foyer**	13:00-14:30
Pitching: Neal Street Productions (Application only)	**Malmaison**	14:30-16:30
Radical Listening: New Scores to Silent Cinema	**York Theatre Royal Studio**	14:30-16:00
Pitching: BBC (Application only)	**Malmaison**	15:00-17:00
Powering Creativity: Pushing the Creative Industries Further	**York Theatre** **Royal Upper Foyer**	16:00-18:00
In Focus: Women Shaping the Screen Industries	**The Ivy**	17:00-19:30
Listening Pitch: Film Premiere	**City Screen 2**	19:00-23:00
The Pitch Launch Boat Party (Invitation only)	**King's Staith Landing,** **River Ouse**	18:45-20:00
Friday Night Party	**Dusk & Drawing Board**	20:00-Late

SATURDAY 7 NOVEMBER

For ratings and more information on films, see detailed listings from pg. 73

	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 1	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 2	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 3	FRIARGATE	YORKSHIRE MUSEUM	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE AUDITORIUM	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE LISTENING ROOM	YSJU DE GREY LECTURE THEATRE	YORK THEATRE ROYAL STUDIO
09:30 - 10:00									
10:00 - 10:30	Drama 1	Comedy 2 SUB	Thriller 3	Drama 5	Experimental 4	Documentary 3	Drama 3		
10:30 - 11:00								Telling Someone's Story	Scoring to Picture in Conversation with Anna Rice
11:00 - 11:30									
11:30 - 12:00			Drama 6						
12:00 - 12:30	Animation 4	Music Video 2		Artists' Film 1	Dance 2	Family Friendly 3 (PG)	Family Friendly 1 (U) SUB	How to Market Your Film: Publicity for Film and TV	Meet Anne Rudd: Costumer Designer
12:30 - 13:00									
13:00 - 13:30									
13:30 - 14:00	Documentary 2	The Guardian Guest Screening		Experimental 2	Drama 16 SUB	Family Friendly 2 (12)	Animation 6	Funding Your Film: How to Finance a Project	The Future of VFX: Technologies Shaping Industry
14:00 - 14:30									
14:30 - 15:00									
15:00 - 15:30								Secrets from Programmers How to Get Your Film in Festivals	Comedy 1 SUB
15:30 - 16:00	Drama 10	Artists' Film 2		Fashion	Animation 5	Drama 8	Dance 3		
16:00 - 16:30									
16:30 - 17:00									
17:00 - 17:30	Comedy 5	Drama 12		Thriller 4 SUB	Drama 13	Documentary 5	Experimental 3		Drama 2
17:30 - 18:00									
18:00 - 18:30									
18:30 - 19:00									
19:00 - 19:30	Thriller 1	Documentary 6		Dance 1 SUB	Documentary 4	Advertising	Music Video 1		Artists' Film 3
19:30 - 20:00									
20:00 - 20:30									
20:30 - 21:00				Drama 14	Thriller 2	Drama 7	Experimental 1 SUB		Drama 9
21:00 - 21:30	Drama 15	Comedy 3							
21:30 - 22:00									
22:00 - 22:30									

	YORK THEATRE ROYAL MAIN HOUSE	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	CITY SCREEN BASEMENT	SOCIALS	YTR COLONNADE	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE CC/103	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE CC/011	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE CC/007	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE RECITAL ROOM
09:30 - 10:00									
10:00 - 10:30						Kids Workshop How to Make a Game (7-10yrs) (10:00-12:00)	Kids Workshop Do You Want to be a Filmmaker? (7-10yrs) (10:00-12:00)	Kids Workshop Screen Acting for Kids (11-14yrs) (10:00-12:00)	Kids Workshop How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation (11-14yrs) (10:00-12:00
10:30 - 11:00		VR Lab & Games Lab							
11:00 - 11:30									
11:30 - 12:00									
12:00 - 12:30	Meet the Music Jury	VR Lab & Games Lab			Makers' Forum: Spotlight Sessions with Our Official Selection				
12:30 - 13:00									
13:00 - 13:30	Aesthetica New Music Stage								
13:30 - 14:00		VR Lab & Games Lab							
14:00 - 14:30						Kids Workshop How to Make a Game (11-14yrs) (14:00-16:00)	Kids Workshop Do You Want to be a Filmmaker? (11-14yrs) (14:00-16:00)	Kids Workshop Screen Acting for Kids (7-10yrs) (14:00-16:00)	Kids Workshop How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation (7-10yrs) (14:00-16:00
14:30 - 15:00									
15:00 - 15:30		VR Lab & Games Lab	Podcast Lounge						
15:30 - 16:00									
16:00 - 16:30				Sync in Focus: Music and Moving Image YTR (Upper Foyer)					
16:30 - 17:00		VR Lab & Games Lab							
17:00 - 17:30	Keynote: BBC Introducing Radio 1's Jess Iszatt								
17:30 - 18:00									
18:00 - 18:30		VR Lab & Games Lab							
18:30 - 19:00									
19:00 - 19:30									
19:30 - 20:00		VR Lab & Games Lab							
20:00 - 20:30									
20:30 - 21:00									
21:00 - 21:30	(21:00-21:45) New Music Headliner Dilettante	VR Lab & Games Lab		ROSE WITHIN THE WALLS Sticks & Glass Presents Meet the Makers					
21:30 - 22:00									
22:00 - 22:30									

DAILY EVENTS

SATURDAY 7 NOVEMBER

MASTERCLASSES & WORKSHOPS	VENUE	TIME
Kids Workshop: Do You Want to Be A Filmmaker? (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Game? (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Kids Workshop: Screen Acting for Kids (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Telling Someone's Story: Documentary Producers in Conversation	YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre	10:30-11:30
Scoring to Picture: In Conversation with Anna Rice	York Theatre Royal Studio	10:30-11:30
How to Market Your Film: Publicity for Film and TV	YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre	12:00-13:00
Meet Anne Rudd: Costume Designer for Screen	York Theatre Royal Studio	12:00-13:00
Meet the Aesthetica New Music Stage Jury	York Theatre Royal Main House	12:00-13:00
Funding Your Film: How to Finance a Project	YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre	13:30-14:30
The Future of VFX: Technologies Shaping the Industry	York Theatre Royal Studio	13:30-14:30
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Stop-Motion (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Game (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00
Kids Workshop: Do You Want to Be a Filmmaker? (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00
Kids Workshop: Screen Acting for Kids (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00
Secrets from Programmers: How to Get Your Film into Festivals	YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre	15:00-16:00
BBC Introducing: Championing Breakthrough Artists	York Theatre Royal Main House	17:00-18:00

EVENTS & NETWORKING	VENUE	TIME
Radical Listening: Media Arts Trail	**City Centre**	09:00-22:00
Official Selection: Games Lab	**NCEM**	10.00-21.30
Official Selection: VR Lab	**NCEM**	10.00-21.30
Film Poster Exhibition	**City Screen**	10:00-22:30
Official Selection: Podcasting Lounge	**City Screen Basement**	10.00-21.30
Makers' Forum	**York Theatre Royal Colonnade Cafe**	10:00-18:00
Pitching: Out of Orbit (Application only)	**Malmaison**	11:00-13:00
Pitching: Ink Factory Films (Application only)	**Malmaison**	11:00-13:00
Aesthetica New Music Stage	**York Theatre Royal Main House**	12:00-21:45
Pitching: Guardian Documentaries (Application only)	**Malmaison**	15:30-17:30
Pitching: Goldfinch (Application only)	**Malmaison**	15:30-17:30
Networking Sync in Focus: Connecting Music and Moving Image	**York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer**	15:45-16:45
Sticks & Glass Presents: Meet the Makers	**Rose Within the Walls**	21:00-Late

SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER

For ratings and more information on films, see detailed listings from pg. 73

TIME	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 1	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 2	CITY SCREEN SCREEN 3	FRIARGATE	YORKSHIRE MUSEUM	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE AUDITORIUM	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE LISTENING ROOM	CITY SCREEN BASEMENT
10:00 - 10:30	Drama 5	Comedy 2 (SUB)	Documentary 2	Drama 12	Thriller 2	Experimental 1 (SUB)	Drama 14	
10:30 - 11:00								Last Chance Encounters: Sunday Networking
11:00 - 11:30								
11:30 - 12:00			Comedy 6					
12:00 - 12:30	Animation 1	Drama 6		Dance 1 (SUB)	Filmmaking in Schools Premiere (12:15)	Family Friendly 2 (12)	Music Video 1	Podcast Lounge
12:30 - 13:00								
13:00 - 13:30								
13:30 - 14:00	Drama 7	Animation 2		Advertising	Artists' Film 1	Family Friendly 3 (PG)	Family Friendly 1 (U) (SUB)	
14:00 - 14:30								
14:30 - 15:00								
15:00 - 15:30	Thriller 4 (SUB)	Drama 9		Experimental 3	Drama 10	Comedy 4	Drama 4 (SUB)	
15:30 - 16:00								
16:00 - 16:30								
16:30 - 17:00					Awards Ceremony (16:30-19:00)			
17:00 - 17:30	Drama 13	Comedy 3		Drama 11 (SUB)		Drama 16 (SUB)	Experimental 2	
17:30 - 18:00								
18:00 - 18:30								
18:30 - 19:00								
19:00 - 19:30	Artists' Film 3	Animation 4		Music Video 2	Animation 6	Experimental 5	Dance 2	
19:30 - 20:00								
20:00 - 20:30								
20:30 - 21:00	Animation 5	Documentary 4		Dance 3	Drama 8	Artists' Film 2	Fashion	
21:00 - 21:30								
21:30 - 22:00								
22:00 - 22:30	Drama 10 (Until 23:00)	Animation 3 (Until 23:00)						

	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC	CITY SCREEN	THORS	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE CC/103	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE CC/011	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE CC/007	YSJU CREATIVE CENTRE RECITAL ROOM
10:00 - 10:30	VR Lab	Games Lab	Film Poster Exhibition		Kids Workshop How to Make a Game (11-14yrs) (10:00-12:00)	Kids Workshop Do You Want to be a Filmmaker? (11-14yrs) (10:00-12:00)	Kids Workshop Screen Acting for Kids (7-10yrs) (10:00-12:00)	Kids Workshop How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation (7-10yrs) (10:00-14:00
11:00 - 11:30								
11:30 - 12:00	VR Lab	Games Lab						
12:00 - 12:30								
13:00 - 13:30	VR Lab	Games Lab		Filmmaking in Schools Project Reception				
14:00 - 14:30					Kids Workshop How to Make a Game (7-10yrs) (14:00-16:00)	Kids Workshop Do You Want to be a Filmmaker? (7-10yrs) (14:00-16:00)	Kids Workshop Screen Acting for Kids (11-14yrs) (14:00-16:00)	Kids Workshop How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation (11-14yrs) (14:00-16:00
14:30 - 15:00	VR Lab	Games Lab						
15:00 - 15:30								
16:00 - 16:30	VR Lab	Games Lab						
16:30 - 17:00								
17:30 - 18:00	VR Lab	Games Lab						
18:00 - 18:30								
19:00 - 19:30				Awards After Party (19:00-Late)				
20:00 - 20:30								
21:00 - 21:30								
22:00 - 22:30								

DAILY EVENTS

SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER

MASTERCLASSES & WORKSHOPS	VENUE	TIME
Kids Workshop: Do You Want to be a Filmmaker? (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Kids Workshop: Acting for Screen (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Game (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	10:00-12:00
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Game (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00
Kids Workshop: How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00
Kids Workshop: Screen Acting for Kids (11-14yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00
Kids Workshop: Do You Want to be a Filmmaker (7-10yrs)	YSJU Creative Centre	14:00-16:00

EVENTS & NETWORKING	VENUE	TIME
Official Selection: Games Lab	NCEM	10:00-18:30
Official Selection: VR Lab	NCEM	10:00-18:30
Film Poster Exhibition	City Screen Basement	10:00-22:30
Official Selection: Podcasting Lounge	City Screen Basement	10.00-18.30
Networking: Last Chance Encounters	City Screen Basement	11:00-12:00
Awards Ceremony	Yorkshire Museum	16:30-19:00
Awards After Party	Thors Tipi	19:00-23:00

VENUES

The Festival Hub is located in the foyer of the Picturehouse City Screen, where our team will be ready to greet you when you collect your tickets and passes. Enjoy the riverside cafe for a light bite in between screenings. Elsewhere, our expansive range of venues is a cinematic playground. From purpose-built theatres and cinemas to hidden bars, our screenings and events take place in a mix of historic and contemporary buildings. Venue accessibility and capacity information is listed next to each location across the following pages, as well as on the accompanying map.

CITY SCREEN & BASEMENT (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Seating Capacity: Screen 1 206 | Screen 2 120 | Screen 3 137

The Aesthetica Film Festival Hub, City Screen, is at the heart of independent film in York. It is also the venue for our Opening Night Ceremony. This is the place to network and experience indie film on the big screen.

DE GREY ROOMS (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 200

The De Grey Rooms, built 1841-1842, is an important example of Early Victorian public architecture. During the festival, the venue is home to the UNESCO City of Media Arts Expo, celebrating the creative industries.

DUSK (PARTIALLY ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 130

Cafe by day; bar by night. Situated in York's New Street, Dusk is the perfect place to touch base and meet fellow festival-goers. This ever-lively spot is the home of our networking events and the popular Friday Night Party.

THE GRAND (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 120

A peaceful haven in York's city centre, The Grand Hotel is the host of this year's UK Film Production Company Summit, which brings together 150+ leading producers and directors to shape the future of screen and media.

FRIARGATE THEATRE (NON-ACCESSIBLE)
Seating Capacity: 100

Hidden in between the River Ouse and Clifford's Tower, Friargate Theatre is home to the Riding Lights Theatre Company. It has a 100-seat studio theatre and a café-style performance space. A fantastic venue on the river.

MALMAISON (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 10

Malmaison is six minutes from the Festival Hub at City Screen. Pitching sessions with industry representatives, including BBC Film, Film4, Goldfinch and *Guardian* Documentaries, will be hosted in this central venue.

NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC (NCEM) (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Seating Capacity: 60

An award-winning medieval church, this is the home to the VR and Games Lab for the duration of the festival. National Centre for Early Music is close to the city centre and only a 12-minute walk away from the festival Hub.

SPARK (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Seating Capacity: 60

Spark is located in the very centre of the city. It is a hugely popular landmark and a catalyst for change. This year, the venue is host to our insightful and engaging workshops, as well as the Virtual Imperative Conference, new for this year.

ROSE WITHIN THE WALLS (UPSTAIRS BAR ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 120

Get away from the busy city streets and take a moment to relax in Rose Within The Walls, a recently renovated bar. This is the setting for our Meet the Makers social, hosted by the Leeds based post house, Sticks & Glass.

YORK THEATRE ROYAL (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Seating Capacity: Studio 70 | Main House 700

York Theatre Royal dates back to the early 18th century. The theatre will host masterclasses and screenings in the Studio and Main House, as well as a wide range of networking events to help you to connect with others.

HOUSE OF TREMBLING MADNESS (NON-ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 120

Situated inside a historic Georgian mansion, House of Trembling Madness is an independent pub serving up local beers and killer sandwiches. It's the perfect place for a post-festival pint or a quick stop for a bite to eat.

THOR'S TIPI (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 150

Thor's Tipi returns to the stunning Museum Gardens this autumn. It's a cosy yet lively space for attendees to socialise and enjoy live music. Plus, sample their array of drinks during our VR & Games Happy Hour event.

YORK ART GALLERY (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Capacity: 120

York Art Gallery is a vibrant cultural venue, home to striking art collections and contemporary exhibitions. During the course of the festival, the gallery is hosting the 2026 edition of the Aesthetica Art Prize exhibition.

YSJU AUDITORIUM / LISTENING ROOM / DE GREY LECTURE THEATRE
Seating Capacity: 129 / 50 / 180 (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)

The York St John Creative Centre is an impressive purpose-built, three-storey creative space where bold architecture meets innovative facilities. The centrepiece is the fantastic theatre, complete with a state-of-the-art sound system.

YORKSHIRE MUSEUM (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Seating Capacity: 300

The Yorkshire Museum hosts screenings, masterclasses and the Awards Ceremony. Founded in 1830 by the Yorkshire Philosophical Society, the museum is located on the grounds of the beautiful York Museum Gardens.

THE IVY (FULLY ACCESSIBLE)
Seating Capacity: 50

Located in St Helens Square, The Ivy is known as one of the finest restaurants in York for timeless British classics. This year it will host our invite only, *In Focus: Women Shaping the Screen* Industries networking event.

VENUES

1 **CITY SCREEN & FESTIVAL HUB**
13-17 Coney Street, YO1 9QL

2 **FRIARGATE THEATRE**
Lower Friargate, YO1 9SL

3 **NATIONAL CENTRE FOR EARLY MUSIC**
Walmgate, YO1 9TL

4 **YORK ST. JOHN UNIVERSITY**
Lord Mayor's Walk, YO31 7EX

5 **YORK THEATRE ROYAL**
St Leonard's Place, YO1 7HD

6 **YORKSHIRE MUSEUM**
Museum Street, YO1

7 **YORK ART GALLERY**
Exhibition Square, YO1 7EW

8 **DUSK** (PARTIAL ACCESS)
New Street, YO1 8RA

9 **ROSE WITHIN THE WALLS** (PARTIAL ACCESS)
1 Tower St, YO1 9WD

10 **SPARK**
17-21 Piccadilly, YO1 9PB

11 **HOUSE OF TREMBLING MADNESS** (PARTIAL ACCESS)
14 Lendal, YO1 8AA

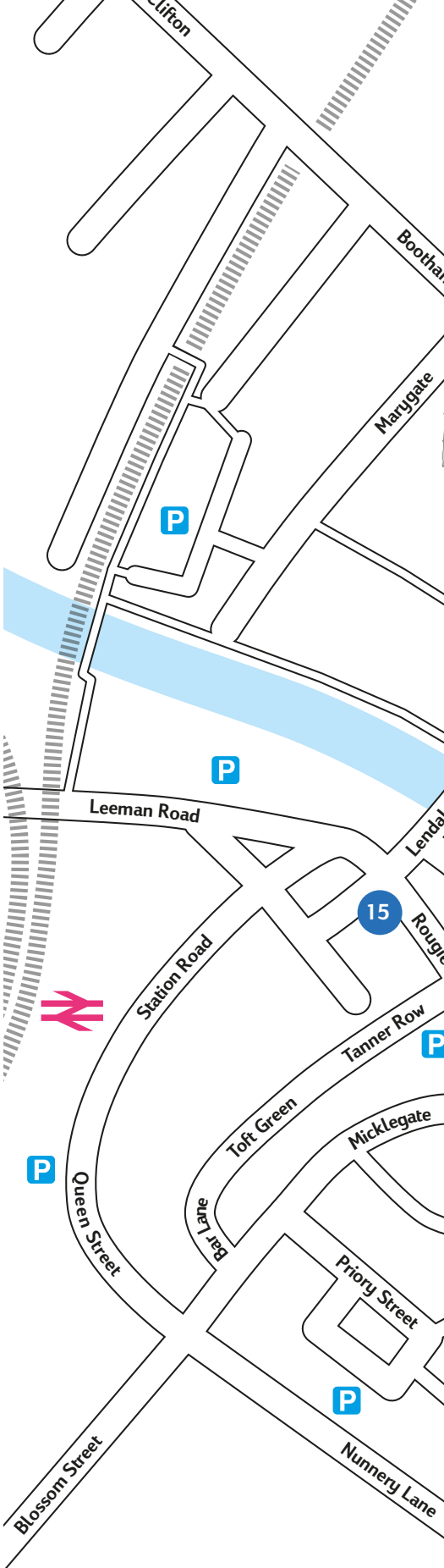
12 **THOR'S TIPI**
Museum Gardens, YO1 7FR

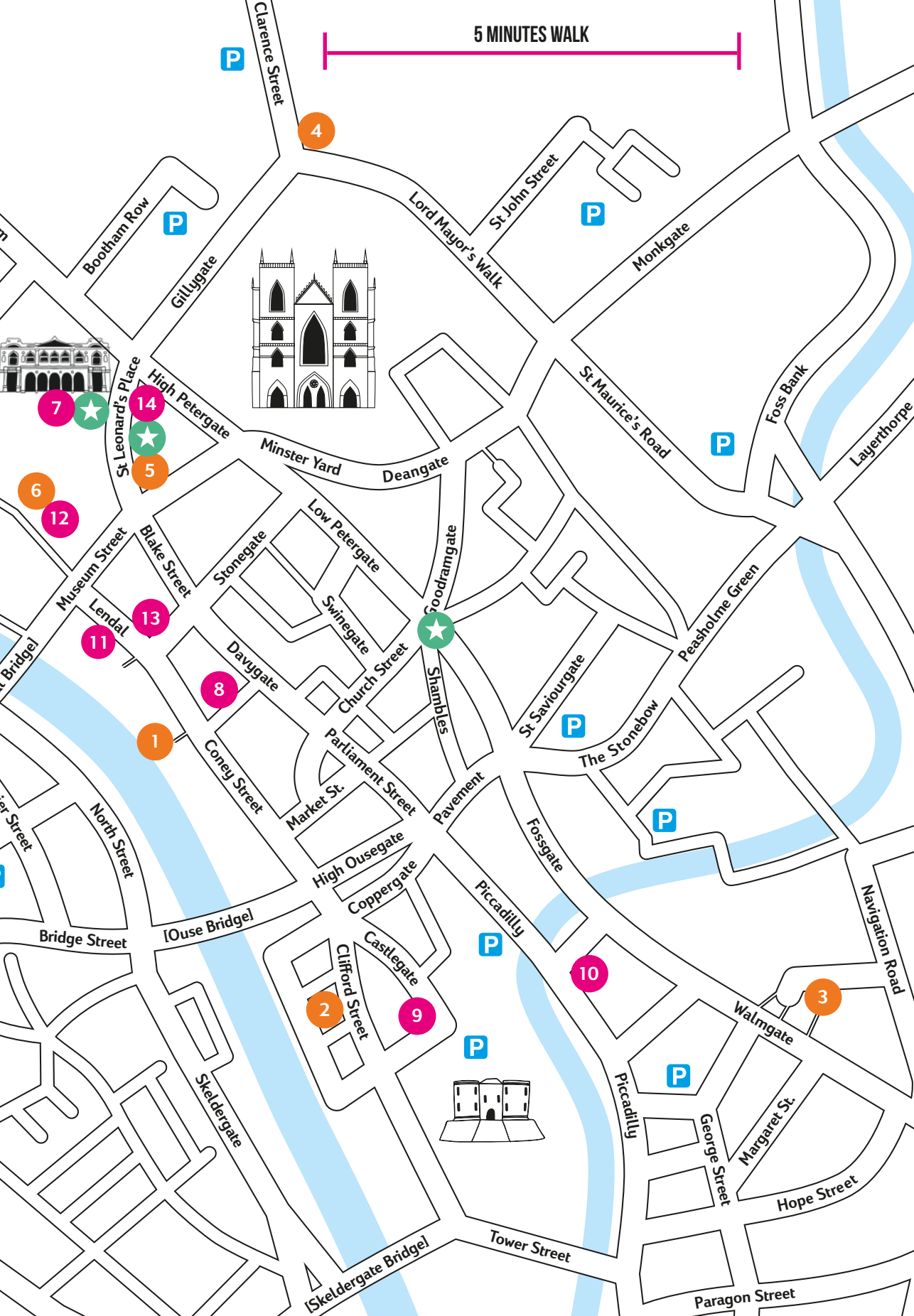
13 **THE IVY**
2 St. Helen's Square, York YO1 8QP

14 **DE GREY ROOMS**
St Leonard's Pl, York YO1 7HE

15 **MALMAISON**
St Rougier St., YO90 1UU

★ **RADICAL LISTENING IMMERSIVE MEDIA ARTS TRAIL**
Various Locations




5 MINUTES WALK
Clarence Street
Bootham Row
Gillygate
Lord Mayor's Walk
St John Street
Monkgate
St Leonard's Place
High Petergate
Minster Yard
Deangate
St Maurice's Road
Foss Bank
Layerthorpe
Museum Street
Blake Street
Stonegate
Low Petergate
Goodramgate
Lendal
Swinegate
Davygate
Church Street
Shambles
Peasholme Green
St Saviourgate
The Stonebow
Parliament Street
Pavement
Market St.
Coney Street
North Street
Fossgate
High Ousegate
Coppergate
Piccadilly
Navigation Road
Bridge Street
[Ouse Bridge]
Castlegate
Clifford Street
Walmgate
Skeldergate
George Street
Margaret St.
Hope Street
Tower Street
[Skeldergate Bridge]
Paragon Street
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10
11
12
13
14

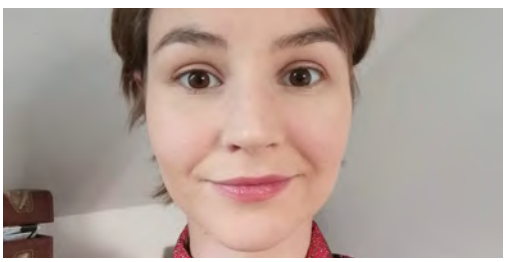
MEET THE AESTHETICA TEAM

CHERIE FEDERICO
Director

DALE DONLEY
Director

ANNA GALLON
Operations Manager

ELEANOR SUTHERLAND
Creative Producer



MEGAN HOBSON
Media Sales & Partnerships Manager

PHOEBE CAWLEY
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ALICE BUTTERFIELD
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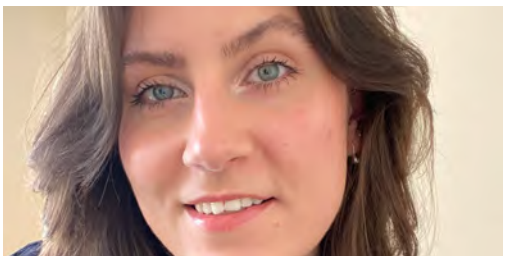
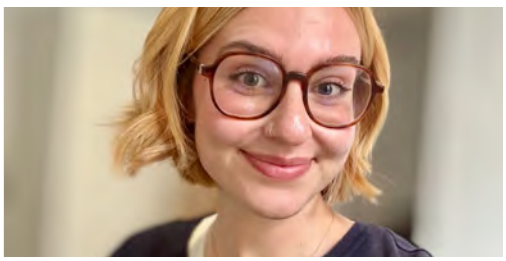
HANNAH SHORT
Education Coordinator



FRUZSINA VIDA
Projects and Events Coordinator

EMMA JACOB
Content Creator



SARAH PERCIVAL
Media Sales & Partnerships Manager

ETHAN MARUVA
Marketing Assistant

AMELIE BROWN
Festival Assistant

EUAN NOBLE
Festival Assistant

MEET OUR PROGRAMMERS

Discover more about the industry professionals behind this year's Official Selection. Across all 14 genres, our programmers have years of experience in commissioning, curation, direction, events, film programming, production and publishing, they have worked on huge projects and been part of teams at major companies including Audible, BBC, BFI London Film Festival, MUBI and Tribeca.

ANGEL CASTLE

Angel Castle is director of Edinburgh Artists' Moving Image Festival and Pollyanna queer arts and cabaret company. Angel has worked for BFI Flare LGBTQIA+ Film Festival and BFI Film Audience Network. In 2016, Angel won the Creative Edinburgh Leadership Award.

ABI MITCHELL

Abi is a cultural programmer and producer who works broadly across contemporary culture at large. Abi has previously worked on developing film programmes for Liverpool Biennial 2021, Huddersfield Contemporary Music Festival and Yorkshire Sculpture International.

ALICE BUTTERFIELD

Alice Butterfield is Aesthetica Film Festival's Technical Coordinator. She is part of the programming team for the Artists' Film and Experimental category. Alongside this, she also helps programme the Artists' Film entries selected for the annual Aesthetica Art Prize Exhibition.

DAN CRAWFORTH

Dan Crawforth is a Lecturer of Media Production at York St. John University. In 2012 he formed his own media production company where he has collaborated with many creatives and has made content for companies such as Nike, The Rugby World Cup and Jack Wills.

CHERIE FEDERICO

Cherie is Director of Aesthetica, the internationally acclaimed British media organisation that first started with Aesthetica Magazine in 2003. Today, it is multi-platform with a reach of over 850,000, including the BAFTA-Qualifying ASFF and the Aesthetica Art Prize.

DALE DONLEY

Dale Donley is Production Director and co-founder of Aesthetica Magazine and Aesthetica Film Festival. He spent his early career in teaching, before moving into graphic design projects. Dale is passionate about new cinema and is particularly interested in animation.

DES GAYLE

Des is a BAFTA-winning video game producer with over 23 years' experience bringing digital worlds to life. He has worked on some of the industry's most iconic projects, such as the launch of Xbox, and has garnered a rare blend of publishing and development expertise.

MATT COWARD-GIBBS

Matt is a Senior Lecturer in Social Sciences at York St John University. He is also the Technical Director of Investigate.Games. Much of his work focuses on collaborations with organisations, championing the influential power of play and knowledge exchange.

DR EVI KARATHANASOPOULOU

Dr Evi is a media researcher, educator and practitioner who works as an Associate Professor and Associate Head of Production at York St John University. Her research and practice focuses on podcasting and radio but often collaborates on VR projects with colleagues.

JACK DENHAM

Jack Denham is an Associate Professor of Social Sciences at York St. John University. He also leads the research group Investigate.Games with Matt Spokes which focuses on interactive games in the context of their history, production and socio-cultural value.

MARBELLE

MarBelle is the Co-Founder and Editor-in-Chief of independent film curation and interview platform Directors Notes. Since its formation in 2006, Directors Notes has expanded to become one of the leading online curatorial platforms for independent cinema.

HEATHER MCINTOSH

Heather McIntosh has over 12 years experience in the film industry, which includes curating Curzon Home Cinema and co-programming Borderlines Film Festival. Now, working as a full-time freelancer, Heather works with prestigious companies such as the BFI and MUBI.

MARTHA CATTELL

Martha is an artist, creative producer and researcher interested in artist films that engage with the countless intersections of nature and culture. She is the Co-Director of the annual Scarborough Film Festival and has worked in the Yorkshire and North East Film Archives.

MIKEY MURRAY

Mikey is an award-winning filmmaker who, in 2007, was the recipient of the Scottish BAFTA award for Best First Time Writer. He has a PhD in Film Practice. Currently, Mikey works as the programme leader for the BA Film Production programme at the University of Lincoln.

MATT SPOKES

Spokes is currently an Associate Professor in Social Sciences at York St. John University. He also leads the research group Investigate.Games with Jack Denham, which focuses on interactive games in the context of their history, production and socio-cultural value.

ROB SPERANZA

Rob is a producer, director and line producer from New York, who currently resides in the north of England. His feature film credits include *Arthur and Merlin, Entity, Inbred* as well as *Small Creatures* (nominated for Best Film at EIFF 2013). He has directed over 15 short films.

TOSIN ALAPAFUJA

Tosin is a film curator and movement artist with a deep love of storytelling. She draws from her rich Nigerian (Yoruba) heritage and finds grounding in celebrating Black storytellers, honouring those who came before her in order to uplift and inspire generations to come.

NATALIE GEE

Natalie Gee is a filmmaker and festival programmer who has worked for Oscar-Qualifying HollyShorts and Brooklyn Film Festival. She has also curated feminist film nights for Brooklyn Museum and organised events focusing on mental health for UnLonely Film Festival.

WARREN FEARNE

Warren Fearne is an Associate Professor in Design at York St John University and co-leads the York Virtual and Augmented Reality Research Group. He has previously worked on several projects VR projects for the BBC, Match of the Day, Harry Potter and the Olympics.

HOLLY NEWSON

Holly is an award-winning presenter and executive producer with an impressive career across podcasts, video, broadcast and digital. She has covered many different stages of development and production, with companies including Audible and JamPot Productions.

YASMINA FADEL

Yasmina is the co-director of Maximalist Ltd. She is a games producer with a proven track record in fostering connectivity and focus within remote teams. She has successfully worked in diverse interdisciplinary roles, delivering high-quality VR and 3D media projects.

MEET OUR JURY

Our Jury brings together individuals with a range of backgrounds and expertise, from academia and commissioning, to production, programming and direction. Our dedicated team represents a number of organisations such as Aardman, Audible, BBC, BFI, Channel 4, ITV and Ridley Scott Associates, as well as those who have won awards at Aesthetica Film Festival in previous years.

ALIA SHEIKH
Creative Director

Alia was previously part of BBC R&D's Immersive and Interactive content division, and is passionate about telling stories in novel and innovative content formats. She is working on developing new immersive museum experiences and often lectures about virtual worlds.

AMOS ERETUSI
Founder & Managing Director, The Kusp

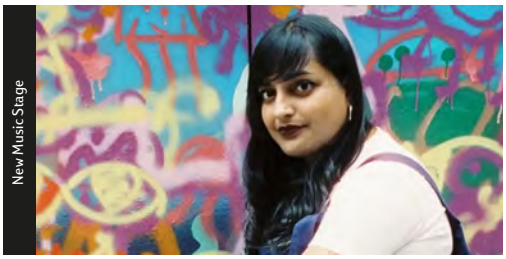
Amos Eretusi is the Founder of The Kusp, a non-profit social enterprise dedicated to improving access to the creative industries. He curates meaningful experiences through industry panels, talks and workshops, which generate discussion and support diverse creatives.

AUBREY CLARKE
Commissioning Executive, BBC Children

Aubrey is BBC Children's Commissioning Executive for live action scripted drama and animation programmes targeted towards children aged between 7 and 12. He is the executive producer of popular brands, such as *The Next Step*, *Tee & Mo*, *My Perfect Landing* and *Digi Girl*.

ADONIS EMMANUEL
Games Designer, Rocksteady Games

Emmanuel is a Games Designer at Rocksteady Games. Previously, he worked as a Software Test Analyst at Sparta Global and a Games Developer at Digital Influx. He has contributed to many projects at Rocksteady Games, including *Suicide Squad Kill The Justice League*.



ARUSA QURESHI
Author

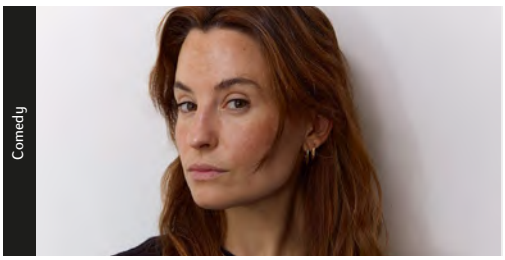
Arusa is an award-winning writer, editor, programmer and speaker with a passion for music, diversity and accessibility within arts and culture. She has previously worked as the music programme manager curating the in house music programme at Edinburgh's Summerhall.

ALRISSA SIA
Producer, Lucid Games

Alrissa Sia is a video game producer who currently works at the studio Lucid Games. Before joining the company, she previously worked as an Associate Producer at Ubisoft where she helped develop many notable titles including *Assissin's Creed Nexus VR*.

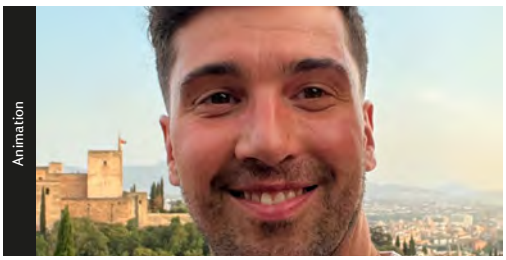
BAZ SELLS
Director & Co-Founder, One6th Animation Studio

Baz Sells is a BAFTA Award-winning director who's film Black Boys in Paradise won Best Animation as part of the Aesthetica 2025. He also co-founded the One6th Animation Studio where he works as a director creating stop-motion animation for both film and television.



BEC EVANS
Director, Writer and Producer

Bec Evans is a film director, writer and producer whose hybrid documentary *Does that make me a woman*? won Best Screenplay at the Aesthetica Film Festival in 2024. Her short fiction *Own Home?* won Best Sci-Fi & Fantasy at the BIFA-Qualifying Sunderland Short Film Festival.



BEN JACKSON
Producer & Co-Founder, One6th Animation Studio

Ben Jackson is the producer of the BAFTA Award-winning film *Two Black Boys in Paradise* that screened at Aesthetica in 2025. In 2018 he co-founded One6th Animation Studio alongside Baz Sells where they work creating stop-motion animation for film and television.

CAITLIN BEAVAN
Associate Producer, Genesius Pictures

Caitlin set up her own theatre production company called Moya Productions, working with luminary actors and directors including Dame Harriet Walter, George MacKay and Simon Callow. After co-producing her own short film, she started work at Genesius Pictures.

CHRISTINE OSAZUWA
Founder, Measure of Music

Christine is the founder of Measure of Music, a global community, conference and hackathon introducing music and data to industry enthuisiasts, now in its sixth year. She has previously worked with big names such as Universal Music Sweden and Warner Music Group.

DANYELE SEIGNORET
Development Executive, Channel 4

Danyele is the Drama Development and Production Executive at Channel 4. She has 15 years' experience in the UK TV industry, working in both production finance and commissioning. Productions she has been across include *Brian and Maggie*, *Get Millie Black* and *Queenie*.

DANIELLA MANCA
Executive Producer, Somesuch

Daniella is an award-winning Executive Producer with a strong background in the film and music industry. Skilled in various areas including video production, digital strategy and production management they currently work as an executive producer at Somesuch.

ERIN GRAHAM
Partnership and Brand Strategist

Erin Graham is a strategist who started her career at the BBC, she helped build franchise development at Warner Brothers (*Harry Potter*) then lead brand and partnerships at MARV, working on well known projects including *Kingsman, Tetris, Rocketman and Argylle*.

EM WHALLEY
Senior Producer, Chalk and Blade

Emily Whalley is a senior producer at Chalk and Blade, an award-winning podcast production company where she has worked on world-class productions such as Understood: *The Making of Musk, The Madman's Hotel* and the long-running series *When Science Finds a Way*.

FRANCESCA PIDGEON
Aesthetica New Music Stage 2025 Winner

Francesca Pidgeon, otherwise known as 'Dilettante', is a multi-disciplinary art-pop musician based in the North of England. She was the winner of the inaugural edition of the Aesthetica New Music Stage in 2025 and will join us for a musical performance at this year's 2026 event.

HANNAH BAILEY
Film and Production Executive, BFI Doc Society

Working across the slate of films supported through the BFI Doc Society Fund, Hannah Bush Bailey aims to develop storytellers from all parts of the UK. Prior to this role, she worked as a short form producer creating work for companies including Universal and Disney.

JIM CAMPBELL
Head of PR & Communications, RSA

Jim is Head of PR and Communications at the Ridley Scott Creative Group (RSCG), which was founded by directors Ridley and Tony Scott. He oversees the department across the production companies: Scott Free, Black Dog, Ridley Scott Associates and Darling.

JAMES MATTHEWS
Senior Director, Universal Music Group

James Matthews is Senior Director at Universal Music Group. It is the world's leading music company, and represents a vast roster of artists. Universal is home to Polydor, Island, Interscope Geffen A&M, Def Jam Recordings, Republic Records, Decca, Verve and more.

JESS ISZATT
Radio Presenter, BBC Radio 1

Jess Iszatt is a radio presenter best known for hosting BBC Radio 1's Dance Party Starters and its flagship BBC Introducing Show, where she champions the UK's emerging music talent. The show covers all genres and styles, and continues to follow the journey of its alumni.

JOHN MCDAID
Creative Director & Co-Founder, Dog Ears

John is the Creative Director and Co-Founder of Dog Ears, an award winning animation company from Ferry. Throughout his career he has worked on many projects including children's shows and digital content such as *Puffin Rock, Saturday Club* and *My Brother the Minotaur*.

JOSIE JUNEAU
Managing Director, RSA

Josie is the Managing Director of Ridley Scott Creative Group, founded by directors Ridley and Tony Scott. With a 12 year career in commercial and advertising, she started off as Head of Advertising for the company and was recently appointed Managing Director in 2026.

LOLA OLIYIDE
Head of Development, Neal Street Productions

Lola is Head of Development at Neal Street Productions and has worked as a script executive on *Britannia* (Sky & Amazon) and *Informer* (BBC & Amazon). Previously, she worked at various production companies in roles like Head of Development and Story Producer.

MAX DENNISON
VFX Supervisor, Cinesite

Emmy award-winning and BAFTA-nominated visual effects supervisor Max has spent nearly 30 years honing his skills in the visual effects industry, from *Lord of the Rings* to *Star Wars*, Hogwarts' magic ceiling and recreating the nuclear disaster of Chernobyl.

MEERA KUMAR
Podcast Producer

Meera Kumar (Producer of the Year 2024) is a freelance storyteller who has created shows for the BBC, Sony Music and Universal amongst others. Recently, Meera produced *Afghan Star*, hosted by John Legend, which was selected as one of the Best Podcasts of last year.

MILLIE CHU
Podcast Executive Producer, Mindhouse

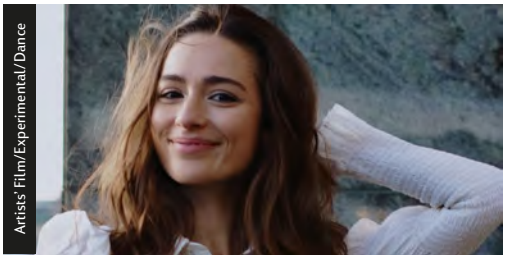
Millie joined Mindhouse in 2023 as a podcast producer on *The Louis Theroux Podcast*. She has since worked across many Mindhouse projects. With her background in radio, Millie has also produced shows for companies such as Sony Music Entertainment, BBC and Spotify.

NETTI MARTIN
Video Producer & Creative Marketer, Audible

Netti Martin is a video producer and creative marketer at Audible. Having previously worked in the music and video production industry, her current work explores many forms of storytelling through promotional films, creative campaigns and documentary-led content.

NICOLAS-TYRELL SCOTT
Award-Winning Music Journalist

Nicolas-Tyrell Scott is an award-winning music and cultural journalist with work printed/published in *GQ*, *Pitchfork*, *Dazed*, Apple Music and more. As a speaker, he has been featured across BBC, Channel 4, Wray and Nephew, The Grapevine TV and also at Soho House.



NORMA LORIA
Film Producer, Fight Gravity Films

Norma is a film producer with a background in assistant directing and a love for bold, distinctive filmmaking. She is drawn to strong authorial voices and films that are unafraid to take risks, she believes the best cinema remains with an audience long after the credits finish.

PABLO ETTINGER
Co-Founder, Caffè Nero

Pablo has enjoyed a highly successful career and is best known as a founding partner of Caffè Nero. He dedicates much of his time to supporting start-ups as both an investor and mentor. He has also co-founded Talentbanq, and, more recently, he set up MusicGurus.

PAMELA JIKIEMI
Creative Artist

Pamela Jikiemi is an award-winning creative artist who works extensively as an actor. She has produced over 25 short films and directed four, winning the IRIS Prize for Education for a short film in 2023. She is currently a PhD candidate at the University of Arts, Chelsea.

PATRCIK CRAIG
Executive Producer in Commercials, Blink

Patrick Craig is the Executive Producer in Commercials at Blink. He has previously worked on several award-winning projects, from music videos to bold advertising campaigns, producing work for companies including Nike, Google, John Lewis, Barclaycard, Mini and Fosters.

PAUL MIDDLETON
Senior Creative Producer, Film Nova

Paul Middleton is the senior creative producer at Film Mova. The company creates multi-award winning sports TV content, with clients including FIFA, Red Bull, BBC Sport and Royal Ascot. Paul has worked on *Great North: A Run. A River. A Region.* and *UK's Strongest Man.*

RICHARD NOCKLES
Creative Director, Sky GenEx

As Creative Director at Sky's GenEx team and Creative Technologist at *Comcast Global Produc*t, Richard works to redefine immersive content across sports, news and entertainment. He has directed content for global giants, Google, the UN, BBC and National Geographic.

RACHEL CROFT
Musician/Artist

Rachel is an internationally acclaimed musician and artist. Her work has featured on Netflix, BBC Two, and premiered on global platforms including CMT (USA) and the BBC. Rachel's distinctive sound has filled iconic venues such as The Bitter End and Camden Assembly.

ROB CANNELL
Head of Promotions, Beggars Group

Rob Cannell is the Head of Promotions at Beggars Group, a record company that owns several labels, including 4AD, Matador Records and XL Recordings. Cannell started his career in marketing at Sony Music before moving to Beggars to work in radio promotions.

SALLY BRYANT
Label Director & Artist Manager, Futuresound

Sally is an A&R / Artist Manager at the Futuresound Group. For the past five years she has worked across their independent label Dance To The Radio. Based in Leeds, Futuresound Group is one of the longest running independent live music promoters in the UK.

SIMON NELSON
Development Executive, BBC Writers

Simon is the Development Executive for BBC Writers. He leads on the development of new writers and writing for BBC drama, comedy and children's drama, covering a range of television, radio and online content. Before joining the BBC, Simon worked at ITV for several years.

STEVE MELIA
Filmmaker & Editor

Steve is a filmmaker and video editor working across short documentaries, social content and podcasts. In 2020, he created the Aesthetica x Audible Listening Pitch film grant, which celebrates the innovative use of sound in documentary and supports new filmmakers.

STUART BURNSIDE
Video Game Manager, BFI

Stuart Burndisde is the Video Game Manager in the Certification Unit at the BFI. Working closely alongside developers from around the country, Stuart offers advice on the certification process and also provides additional information on the overall creative sector.

SYDNEY OBERFELD
Freelance Producer, Good Chaos

In her role as Freelance Producer at Good Chaos, Sydney Oberfeld works across the company's slate from development to production. Originally from Montreal, she's worked on Isabel Sandoval's *Lingua Franca,* as well as shorts funded by the BFI and Film4.

TONY BADU
Development Producer, Joi Productions

Tony Badu is a writer, director and producer working in scripted and unscripted TV & Film. In his role at Joi Productions, he is committed to driving lasting equity in film and is passionate about stories from the Global South, especially genre works of nonfiction and sci-fi.

WILL BECHER
Academy Award-Nominated Animator & Director, Aardman

Will is an animator and film director who is best known for his directorial debut of *A Shaun the Sheep Movie: Farmageddon*. During his 20 year career, he has worked as a writer, director and as stop-motion lead animator, after first joining the company for a summer placement.

LEARN FROM INDUSTRY PROFESSIONALS BOOK ONTO MASTERCLASSES AT ASFF.CO.UK

This year, we are thrilled to welcome BAFTA, Oscar and BIFA-winning directors, actors and producers, representing organisations like Aardman, BBC, BFI, Channel 4, Film4, Frame-store, Guardian Documentaries, Ridley Scott Associates and many others. See page 180.

EVENTS & NETWORKING

MAKE THE MOST OF YOUR PASS.

Aesthetica is more than a film festival – it's a space for lifelong learning and meaningful connection. We bring together creative minds, and community is at the heart of what we do. Our parties, panels, workshops and talks are shaped by this idea.

Expect a mix of industry expertise and creative exchange across our events. From masterclasses and networking, to the New Wave Programme spotlighting emerging talent, this is your opportunity to meet collaborators and gain new insights.

This year, we're excited to offer hands-on workshops exploring cutting-edge tools and immersive technologies. Our pitching, social events and expert-led sessions create the perfect environment to exchange ideas and develop lasting connections.

Most Special Events are included with your pass, but advance registration is required at **asff.co.uk/events** to reserve your spot. Visitors should register for masterclasses, VR and Games Labs, workshops and networking sessions. There is no need to pre-register for parties. Please note: the Opening Night Ceremony and Beyond the Frame programme are separate ticketed events. Visit **asff.co.uk** to learn more.

WEDNESDAY

CHAUCER £20,000 FILM GRANT LAUNCH EVENT

Celebrate the launch of a new initiative from the Chaucer Heritage Trust and Aesthetica Film Festival, supporting filmmakers to bring the world of Geoffrey Chaucer to life through contemporary cinema. The successful filmmaker will receive £20,000 to make their short, alongside production support. The completed film will premiere at Aesthetica Film Festival 2027. Join us to learn about the opportunity.

Date & Time: 4 November | 14:00-15:00
Venue: York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer, YO1 7HD

WEDNESDAY

OPENING NIGHT CEREMONY

We launch our 16th edition with a special screening of five spectacular, thought-provoking and inspiring works by filmmakers from the 2026 Official Selection. Curated by Festival Director, Cherie Federico, our Opening Night introduces audiences to the breadth of this year's film programme with a special screening, offering a taste of what's to come. Pick up your goodie bag and welcome drink on arrival at the cinema.

Date & Time: 4 November | 18:00 - Late. **Screening starts at 19:00**
Venue: City Screen, YO1 9QL | **Separate ticket required (£15)**

THURSDAY

VIRTUAL IMPERATIVE 2: CONFERENCE

From York St John University, this unique and exciting event brings together academics, researchers, postgraduate students and creative practitioners to discuss how extended reality is reshaping knowledge, storytelling, audience experience, pedagogy, digital culture and interdisciplinary practice. It offers an intimate academic setting for critical dialogue, knowledge exchange, networking and future collaboration.

Date & Time: 5 November | 9:00-18:00
Venue: Spark, YO1 9PB | **Separate ticket required**

THURSDAY

UK PRODUCTION SUMMIT: TRENDS IN STORYTELLING

This November, York will host one of the most significant screen industry gatherings of the year. The UK Production Summit brings together more than 150 of the UK's leading production companies, development executives and commissioners under one roof. The country's most influential decision-makers converge to define and debate the future of screen content, with a keynote talk from the Director of Film4. **p. 58.**

Date & Time: 5 November | 15:00-20:00
Venue: The Grand, YO1 6GD | **Invitation Only**

THURSDAY

VR & GAMES HAPPY HOUR

A destination for those working in new technologies, the VR & Games Happy Hour brings industry guests together to contemplate the future of games development, virtual reality and immersive filmmaking. This is the ideal place to generate ideas about what's coming next for interactive storytelling and meet others interested in entertainment at the cutting edge. This event includes a free welcome drink upon arrival at the venue.

Date & Time: 5 November | 17:00 - 18:00
Venue: Thor's Tipi, Museum Gardens, YO1 7FR

THURSDAY

MEET THE MUSIC INDUSTRY

The worlds of film, games, XR and music increasingly intersect, and exciting opportunities emerge when we connect the dots. Beggars Group invites you to be part of a Meet the Music Industry takeover for drinks and collaboration, to explore shared opportunities and spark new creative partnerships across sectors. Meet people from major labels like Matador and Rough Trade to discover where music can open up new possibilities.

Date & Time: 5 November | 20:00-21:00
Venue: House of Trembling Madness, YO1 8AA

FRIDAY

RADICAL LISTENING: NEW SCORES TO SILENT CINEMA

Early film screenings were often accompanied by live music, improvised sound and audience participation. With this new commission, Aesthetica and Audible invite composers and sound designers to rediscover that tradition, asking them to create inventive scores for pre-1925 silent films. The selected artists respond to iconic works by Marcel Duchamp, Edwin S. Porter and more. Live performances are followed by a panel and Q&A.

Date & Time: 6 November | 14:30 - 16:00
Venue: York Theatre Royal Studio, YO1 7HD

FRIDAY

IN FOCUS: WOMEN SHAPING THE SCREEN INDUSTRIES

In Focus: Women Shaping the Screen Industries is a vibrant networking event uniting women across different sectors of the industry, including film, gaming and XR. This is a place to connect, collaborate and be inspired by our keynote speaker, producer Suzanne Mackie (*Mad Dogs, The Crown)*. This is an ideal opportunity to build up visibility, support and leadership amongst the women shaping the screen industries today.

Date & Time: 6 November | 17:00 - 19:30
Venue: The Ivy, YO1 8QP | **Invitation Only**

FRIDAY

BOAT PARTY: CELEBRATE WITH THE PITCH

Join The Pitch for a boat party on the River Ouse! They're marking the relaunch of their annual commissioning programme, financing films about technological solutionism. An exciting moment to let your hair down, meet other filmmakers and network with industry as we set sail. Take in scenic views of the historic city of York from the water and enjoy drinks and networking. Hosted by City Cruises York and The Pitch.

Date & Time: 6 November | Boarding 18:45 | Disembark 20:00
Venue: King's Staith Landing, YO1 7DP | **Invitation Only**

FRIDAY

LISTENING PITCH: FILM PREMIERE

Aesthetica and Audible have teamed up for the sixth year to bring together stories that show how listening helps us to understand the world. Join us for the premiere of new documentary work from Duncan Cowles, Hermione Spriggs and Sofia Cisse Akel & Tobi Kyerematen, who respond to the theme of radical listening. Drinks served upon arrival with a Q&A, live DJ set and networking session post-screening.

Date & Time: 6 November | 19:00-23:00
Venue: City Screen, YO1 9QL

FRIDAY

FRIDAY NIGHT PARTY

Dusk and Drawing Board host the renowned Friday Night Party, helping to carry Aesthetica Film Festival into a weekend of fun social events, insightful masterclasses and inspiring cinema screenings. Located in York's New Street, the party is the perfect location to join the festivities and re-group with brand new friends made throughout the week. Grab a drink, connect with industry and prepare for a great weekend ahead.

Date & Time: 6 November | 20:00-Late
Venue: Dusk & Drawing Board YO1 8RA

SATURDAY

STICKS AND GLASS PRESENTS: MEET THE MAKERS

Meet the Makers is your opportunity to get to know the creatives at the heart of Aesthetica 2026. Catch up with the friends you've already made or make some new connections. This event is for everyone, whether you're a filmmaker, developer, podcaster or cinema-lover. Join us with a complimentary glass of wine upon arrival for drinks and networking. Sponsored by Sticks and Glass, a new post production space.

Date & Time: 7 November | 21:00-Late
Venue: Rose Within the Walls, YO1 9WD

STICKS GLASS

SUNDAY

AWARDS CEREMONY

To bring our 16th edition to a close, we welcome filmmakers, delegates and audiences to join our Awards Ceremony. Prizes are awarded for the best film in each of our genre categories, as well as our Best of Fest and Special Guest Awards. Join us for a celebration of this year's impressive achievements, followed by a drinks reception and After Party, taking place at Thor's. Without doubt, this is the best way to end the festival.

Date & Time: 8 November | 16:30-19:00
Venue: Yorkshire Museum, YO1 7FR

VARIOUS DAYS

DAILY NETWORKING

Whether you're looking to connect with industry representatives, uncover exciting opportunities or learn a new approach to filmmaking, our daily Networking Sessions **(p. 215)** are opportunities to converse with leading professionals in film and music, and spark new collaborations. Every day is focused on a different theme, from VFX to pitching. Hosted by: The Pitch Film Fund, Viridian FX, Film Hub North & York St John University.

Date & Time: 4-8 November | Various times
Venue: York Theatre Royal, Thor's Tipi, City Screen

DAILY

VR AND GAMES LABS

We are championing the future of storytelling through our media labs. Games are an important part of screen culture, and we are uplifting developers and designers through our Games Lab. Play 50 indie titles and discover your next favourite adventure, platformer or RPG. Plus, at our VR Lab, you can try on a VR headset and be transported into a story, time or place. Available to play every day. Book your slot **asff.co.uk.**

Date & Time: 4-7 Nov 10:00-21:30 | 8 Nov 10:00-18:30
Venue: National Centre for Early Music, YO1 9TL

DAILY

MAKERS' FORUM

The Makers' Forum brings together Official Selection creators across film, games, XR and podcasts, each given 10 minutes to showcase their vision. This session is a fast-paced, dynamic insight into the year's most original storytelling, and an exclusive chance to hear directly from the innovative creators who are helping to shape the future of screen and media culture. Each team shares the journey of their project, from idea to final delivery.

Date & Time: 4-7 November | 10:00-18:00
Venue: Colonnade Café, York Theatre Royal, YO1 7HD

DAILY

PODCASTING LOUNGE

Discover the UK's first dedicated Podcasting Lounge at Aesthetica Film Festival – an innovative space where audio storytelling takes centre stage. Curated to spotlight dynamic voices in film, art, tech and culture, this lounge offers the chance to pause and well and truly listen. It is an exciting new chapter in how stories are shared and heard. Sit down, tune in and discover the best in comedy, fiction, true crime and documentary.

Date & Time: 4-7 November | 10:00 - 21:30 | 8 November 10:00-18:30
Venue: City Screen Basement, YO1 9QL

DAILY

FILMMAKER INSIGHTS PANEL DISCUSSIONS

Hear from a selection of filmmakers from the 2026 Official Selection. These daily panel discussions provide you with the perfect opportunity to learn about inspirations, motivations and creative processes, covering a range of topics such as finding your signature aesthetic, honing your artistic vision and breaking the rules of scriptwriting. Go behind the scenes on your favourite films from the programme. See more on **p.180**.

Date & Time: 4-7 November | Various times
Venue: Yorkshire Museum, York Theatre, York St John

VARIOUS DAYS

UNESCO CITY OF MEDIA ARTS EXPO

The UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO showcases the exceptional work being delivered by 40 leading creative businesses across the UK. This year, we're also hosting 10 workshops, providing insights into audience development, intellectual property, pitching, finance, sustainable business models and expansion with speakers from Argonon, Creative UK, Innovate UK and more. **Free to attend.** See more on **p. 61.**

Date & Time: 5-6 November | 9:00-21:00
Venue: De Grey Rooms, YO1 9QN

VARIOUS DAYS

MASTERCLASSES

We are running an unparalleled programme of industry events alongside our film programme, with topics spanning directing, cinematography, documentary and more. Our 2026 speakers include representatives from leading organisations, such as Aardman, Film4, Framestore and Ridley Scott Associates, as well as directors, producers and VFX specialists who have worked on the biggest projects of our times. See listings on **p.180**.

Date & Time: 4-7 November | Various Times
Venue: Various Venues | **See timetable for details.**

VARIOUS DAYS

KIDS WORKSHOPS: ACTING, ANIMATION, FILMMAKING & GAMES

We believe in nurturing children's creativity. We are offering 7-14 year-olds the chance to develop, direct and make their own stop-motion animations, games and films, as well as take part in acting workshops. These practical, fun and inspiring sessions are led by experts from Animation Nation, ComputerXplorers and Pauline Quirke Academy. More information available on **p.212. Separate ticket required | £20**

Date & Time: 7-8 November | Various times
Venue: York St John Creative Centre, YO31 7EX

UK PRODUCTION SUMMIT: TRENDS IN STORYTELLING

This November, we will host one of the most significant screen industry gatherings of the year. The UK Film Production Summit take place on 5 November 2026, bringing together more than 150 of the UK's leading production companies, development executives and commissioners under one roof. The scale is unprecedented. Aesthetica becomes the beating heart of British film and television, as the country's most influential decision-makers converge to define and debate the future of screen content.

15:00-20:00 | 5 November. This event is invite only.

UK PRODUCTION COMPANY SUMMIT 2026

Now in its second year, the Summit brings together senior leaders for panels, networking and keynotes, introducing music into the conversation, followed by visits to York Art Gallery for the Aesthetica Art Prize, UNESCO EXPO and Meet the Music Industry Drinks.

ED BAILIE: TELLING STORIES THROUGH MUSIC

Music supervisor Ed Bailie has worked across film and TV for 15 years, with credits including Netflix's *Legends* and the BAFTA-winning *Mood*. In this talk, Bailie will speak about how he collaborates with filmmakers and discuss the role audio has in building narrative impact.

TRENDS IN STORYTELLING PANEL

Industry leaders discuss evolving narrative formats across film, TV and streaming. They examine audience behaviours, commissioning priorities and franchises. Chaired by Jim Campbell of RSA, this panel includes experienced commissioners from Sky and Warner Bros.

KEYNOTE SPEAKER: FARHANA BHULA

Farhana Bhula is Director of Film4, overseeing popular recent projects like *How to Have Sex*, *All of Us Strangers*, *Rose of Nevada* and *The History of Sound*. In this session, she offers an exclusive insight into the ever-changing industry and what it really takes to get a film made.

BBC

itv

4

STICKS GLASS

BFI

RSA

SCOTT FREE

WORKING TITLE

rocksteady

bigtalk
studios

WELLINGTON

DNEG

pact.

PASSION®

audible

CINESITE

YORK
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COMBINED AUTHORITY

UKRI
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OUT OF
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AARDMAN

The
Pitch

GENESIUS
PICTURES

BBC
FILM

NEALSTREET

GoodChaos

EA

FIGHT
GRAVITY

DON
DADA

ELEMENT
PICTURES

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SCREEN
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FILM
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GOLDFINCH

BBC
COMEDY

blink

ACTIVISION

dock·10

DJ FILMS

POTBOILER
PRODUCTIONS

MINDHOUSE

imagesound

dartmouth
films

THE
KUSP

somesuch

FILM
LONDON

element

STUDIO
LAMBERT

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BEGG
BEARS

The
Guardian
DOCUMENTARIES

BBC
Comedy

UNESCO CITY
OF MEDIA ARTS
expo
GAMES | FILM | VFX | DESIGN
40 EXHIBITING ORGANISATIONS
5-6 NOVEMBER | 9:00-21:00
DE GREY ROOMS, YORK
FREE ENTRY
MEDIACITYEXPO.COM
Aesthetica
YORK & NORTH YORKSHIRE COMBINED AUTHORITY
Est. 1841 YORK ST JOHN UNIVERSITY
York UNESCO City of Media Arts

UNESCO EXPO WORKSHOPS

York Business School Presents:

This workshop programme runs alongside the UNESCO EXPO, bringing together creative practitioners, SMEs, producers and emerging talent with a shared focus: building a stronger, more scalable creative industries economy. The EXPO and all workshops are **free to attend and do not require a festival pass.**

Creative Industries Policy and Evidence Centre

MAPPING VALUE IN THE CREATIVE ECONOMY

Hosted by Giorgio Fazio, Research Director of the Creative Industries Policy at Newcastle University, explore how value is created and distributed across creative industries ecosystems. Participants map their own activity within the wider supply chain.

Date
5 November
Time
10:00-11:00

UKRI Innovate UK

INNOVATION PRACTISE & INVESTMENT READINESS

Led by Emma Cooper, Creative Industries Knowledge Transfer Manager at Innovate UK, this session maps out the funding ecosystem across the creative industries, including public funding, private finance, co-production and hybrid models.

Date
5 November
Time
11:00-12:00

VIRIDIANFX

PITCHING & WINNING BUSINESS

This workshop, presented by Ben Louden, Head of Studio at Viridian FX, focuses on turning creative ideas into commercially viable, commission-ready propositions. Participants learn how to structure pitches and align projects with investor expectations.

Date
5 November
Time
12:00-13:00

ARGONON
THE WORLD WATCHES

INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY AS GROWTH ASSETS

This session positions IP as the core financial asset of the creative economy. Amanda Goddard, Chief Legal and Commercial Officer at Argonon, breaks down ownership, rights structures, licensing and exploitation pathways across multiple formats.

Date
5 November
Time
13:00-14:00

Department for Business, Innovation, Science & Trade

SCALING INTERNATIONALLY & EXPORT GROWTH

Led by Ameeta Virk and Adam Butterworth of the Department for Business, Innovation, Science & Trade, learn how creative businesses move from local success to international markets, covering distribution strategies, and market entry barriers.

Date
5 November
Time
14:00-15:00

UNESCO EXPO WORKSHOPS

BUILDING BUSINESS RELATIONSHIPS

Led by Carol Bell, Creative UK's Regional Associate Director, North, this workshop focuses on how businesses can build meaningful, long-term relationships with both internal and external stakeholders and how to understand different needs.

Date
6 November
Time
10:00-11:00

COLLABORATION & CREATIVE CLUSTERS

Caroline Cooper Charles, Chief Executive at Screen Yorkshire, introduces a session that explores how collaboration drives growth in modern creative economies. See how clusters, shared infrastructure and partnerships increase competitiveness.

Date
6 November
Time
11:00-12:00

CO-PRODUCTION MODELS & STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIPS

Discover how co-production actually works in practice across film, TV and digital content. This workshop, hosted by Carlotta Roveri who is the Head of Production in Film & TV Head Gear Films, covers rights sharing, financing alignment and risk distribution.

Date
6 November
Time
12:00-13:00

THE FUTURE FUNDING LANDSCAPE

This workshop is delivered by PACT. It explores the screen industry, examining the challenges and opportunities ahead and the trends shaping its future. Participants will gain insight into the evolving sector and what it means for creative businesses.

Date
6 November
Time
13:00-14:00

CREATIVE ENTERPRISE GROWTH PATHWAYS

Bringing the programme together, Pip Rymill, Accelerator Community Manager at Natwest, invites participants to map how value creation, audience development, collaboration, IP, funding and export all come together into one singular growth system.

Date
6 November
Time
14:00-15:00

UKRI Innovate UK | Business Connect

Next Wave is an Innovate UK programme that helps innovative businesses across creative industries turn bold ideas into growth.

If you're developing high-potential creative technologies, we want to help you **scale faster, connect with the right expertise,** and **unlock opportunities across the UK.**

We're looking for createch solutions within:

Film and TV
Music, performing and visual arts
Video games
Advertising & marketing

Come and chat with us
and boost your creative career

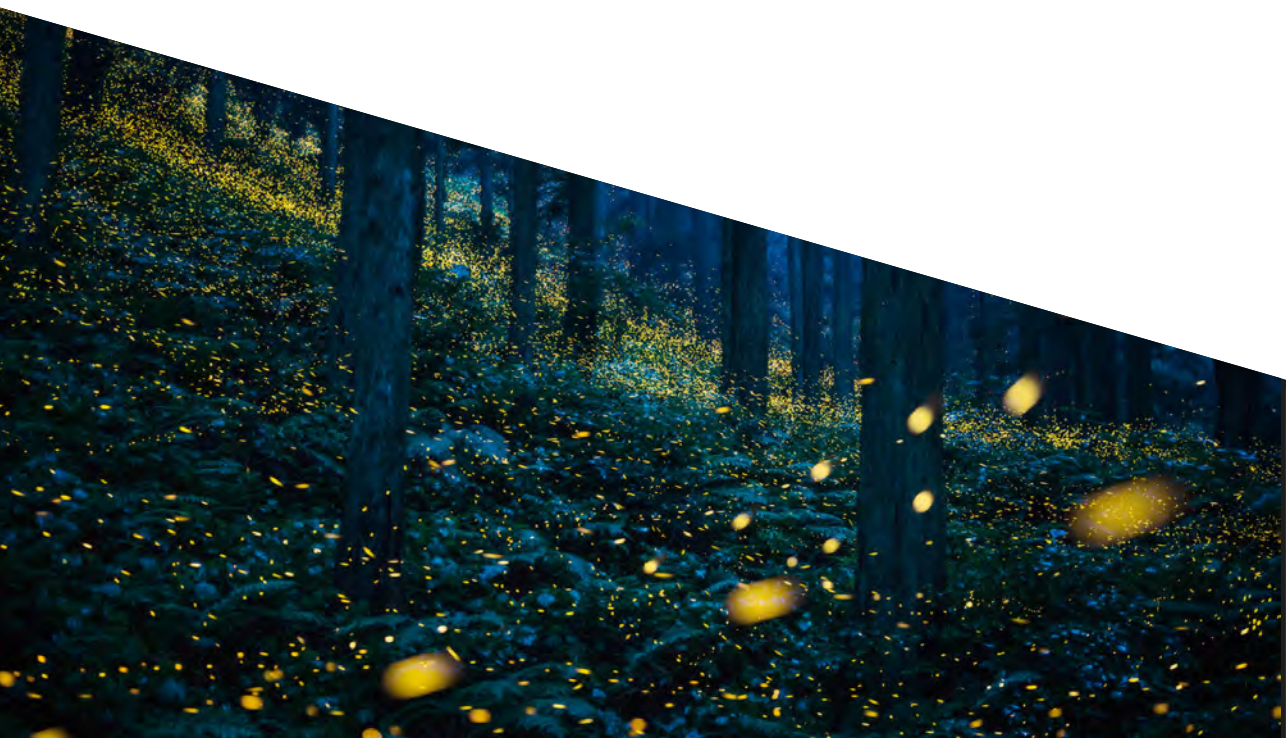
iuk-business-connect.org.uk/creative-industries

AESTHETICA ART PRIZE: 20TH ANNIVERSARY EDITION

Until 15 November | York Art Gallery, YO1 7EW

Aesthetica Art Prize 2026: States of Becoming runs until15 November, marking its 20th anniversary as an international platform for contemporary art. The exhibition showcases 20 artists addressing urgent global themes, including technological acceleration, colonial legacies, identity, belonging and ecological strain. Works disrupt everyday perception, revealing instability in domestic and urban spaces and broader social tensions. Plus, this is a chance to discover the moving-image works by this year's winners: Felipe Castelblanco and DIVA. The Prize fosters dialogue, supports careers and encourages new ways of seeing our world. Curated by Aesthetica Director, Cherie Federico.

Separate ticket required. Book at yorkartgallery.org.uk



RADICAL LISTENING: MEDIA ARTS TRAIL IN THE CITY

4-8 November, 9:00-22:00 | Exhibition Square, King's Square, York Theatre Royal

For the *Radical Listening Immersive Media Trail*, Audible and Aesthetica invites artists to create installation-based works with an integrated audio component, where sound is central to the experience. As part of the Listening Pitch 2026, we sought projects that explore listening as both subject and method, asking: How can audio activate a space? How might an installation guide attention or alter perception? In what ways can audiences be invited not just to hear, but to actively listen?

The selected artists are: Squidsoup, the acclaimed light, sound and technology pioneers; Steve Messam, whose works are characterised by a vibrant use of colour, form and impressive scale; and Being Now Here, who specialises in immersive environments and interactive installations.

For five days only, the trail runs from York Theatre Royal to Exhibition Square and King's Square. Supported by Audible UK, free to all. Part of the Aesthetica Film Festival.

Aesthetica audible

THE AESTHETICA MUSIC PROGRAMME

We're bringing the worlds of music and film together through a dedicated Music Programme designed to spark connection, collaboration and new opportunities. The programme features panels, the New Music Stage featuring 10 breakthrough artists, masterclasses and networking. Meet industry professionals from Beggars Group, **BBC Introducing, Radio 1**, Universal, Futuresound Group and A&R reps. Hear from award-winning sound editors and composers. Gain advice on sync and building a career. Plus, find your next favourite track. Pick up a Music at Aesthetica programme at the City Screen Hub or **find out more at asff.co.uk/music.**

Available to Unlimited Pass, Saturday Day Pass and Music at Aesthetica Pass holders.

MEET THE MUSIC JURY

Saturday 7 Nov | York Theatre Royal | 12:00-13:00

Welcome to the New Music Stage. This panel features Jury members Rob Cannell (Beggars Group), Sally Bryant (Futuresound Group), Nicolas Tyrell (Culture and Music Journalist), Arusa Qureshi (Writer and former Editor of The List) and singer Rachel Croft, discussing the structures that shape how new talent is discovered and supported.

NEW MUSIC STAGE

Saturday 7 Nov | York Theatre Royal | 13:00-20:50

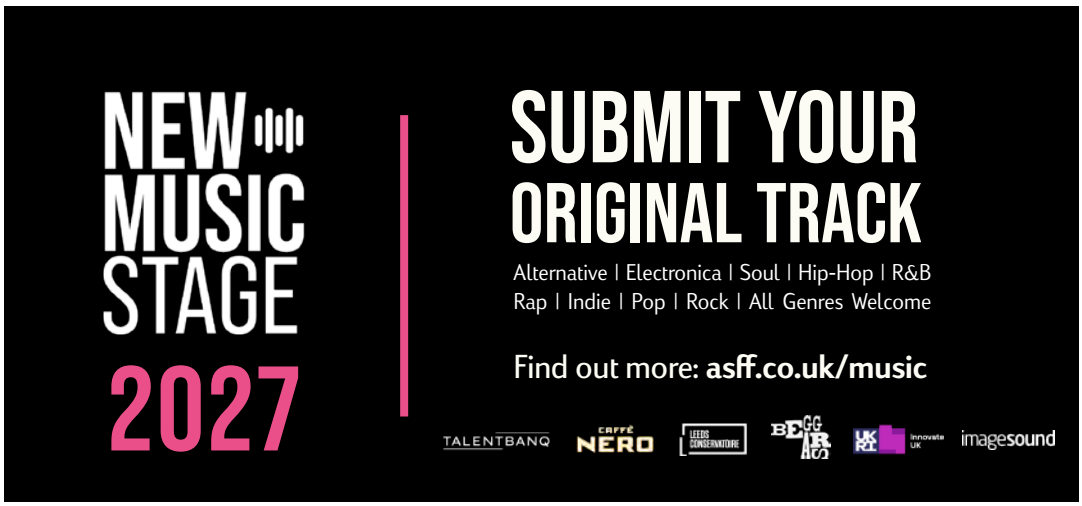
Discover the New Music Stage at Aesthetica, a festival featuring 10 breakthrough acts who are making waves. It's an exciting chance to experience fresh new music from a divese range of genres – indie, folk, jazz, pop – and support emerging talent. 10 incredible acts. Performances take place across two sessions, with five acts in each.

KEYNOTE SPEAKER: JESS ISZATT

Saturday 7 Nov | York Theatre Royal | 17:00-18:00

Thousands of listeners across the UK tune in to BBC Introducing on Radio 1 – a show hosted by Jess Iszatt, dedicated to championing new artists. Florence + the Machine, Lewis Capaldi, Raye and Sam Fender all featured at the start of their careers. In this session, Iszatt speaks about her career, and the importance of nurturing new talent.

EVENT	VENUE	TIME
Masterclass: Sync with Beggars Group (pg.191)	York Theatre Royal Studio	**Thurs 5 Nov** | 14:30-15:30
Beggars Presents: Meet the Music Industry Party	House of Trembling Madness	**Thurs 5 Nov** | 20:00-21:00
A Masterclass in Award-Winning Sound Design (pg.194)	Yorkshire Museum	**Fri 6 Nov** | 10:00-11:00
Masterclass: The Power of Soundtracks (pg.200)	York Theatre Royal Studio	**Fri 6 Nov** | 17:30-18:30
Masterclass: Scoring to Picture with Anna Rice	York Theatre Royal Studio	**Sat 7 Nov** | 10:30-11:30
Meet the Music Jury (pg. 204)	York Theatre Royal Main House	**Sat 7 Nov |** 12:00-13:00
Aesthetica New Music Stage Part 1	York Theatre Royal Main House	**Sat 7 Nov |** 13:00-15:40
Networking: Sync in Focus (pg. 220)	York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer	**Sat 7 Nov |** 15:45-16:45
Keynote: BBC Introducing's Jess Iszatt	York Theatre Royal Main House	**Sat 7 Nov |** 17:00-18:00
Aesthetica New Music Stage Part 2	York Theatre Royal Main House	**Sat 7 Nov |** 18:10-20:50
Live Performance & Q&A with Dilettante	York Theatre Royal Main House	**Sat 7 Nov |** 21:00-21:45
Music Video Screenings (pg. 132)	Various Venues	Various Times (See Listing)



SATURDAY 7 NOVEMBER
York Theatre Royal Main House
12:00-21:45

AESTHETICA NEW MUSIC STAGE

Meet the 10 breakthrough acts who make up this year's New Music Stage. The 2026 lineup spans transcendent vocals, razor-sharp lyrics, old-school hip-hop sounds and art-pop experimentation, highlighting artists that are destined for bigger stages. The artists will be performing throughout the day, giving audiences an exclusive chance to hear the next big thing in the music industry.

LFAY
Performamnce Time: 13:00-13:20

LFay's genre-blurring sound fuses old-school hip-hop, urban jazz and neo-soul with elements of jungle, drum & bass and breaks. She delivers playful yet insightful observations on both isolation and youth experience, influenced by the UK's pirate radio scene of the 1990s.

KATHERINE ALY
Performamnce Time: 13:35-13:55

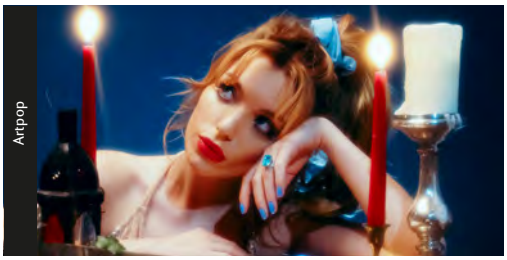
Katherine Aly is a rising alt-pop artist known for her genre-defying sound and fearless storytelling. Her distinctive orange aesthetic and a strong commitment to pushing creative boundaries has garnered praise from press including Wonderland, Notion and Earmilk.

LEPANI
Performamnce Time: 14:10-14:30

Lepani is a Fijian-born, Manchester-based songwriter and producer, who blends alternative pop, R&B and soul. His music – which has gained 14 million streams across digital platforms – draws on a diverse range of influences, creating a smooth and distinctive sound.

CHISARA
Performamnce Time: 14:45-15:05

Chisara's sound is defined as radical hope mixed with punk, curiosity and philosophy. The artist's unique Afro-art-pop sound has received recognition from the likes of BBC Introducing London, The Great Escape, The Roundhouse, Tate Britain and National Theatre.



CIRCE

Performamnce Time: 15:20-15:40

Artist and multi-instrumentalist Circe's songs see huge synths, distorted guitars, strings and layered vocals collide with sharp, atmospheric storytelling. Her music has appeared in Netflix's *Crew Girl* and *Elite*; Amazon Prime's *Hanna*; as well as Channel 4's *Made in Chelsea*.

PAVEY ARK

Performamnce Time: 18:10-18:30

Pavey Ark is an indie-folk band from Hull, UK, making music in which vocals, strings and horns glide over finger-picked guitar and percussion. The result is a sound that incomparable unique sound. Many of their songs have received air play on BBC Radio 6 Music.

PH

Performamnce Time: 18:45-19:05

Manufactured in Northwest London, lyrical rapper PH brings a modern alternative sound to the UK, blending old-school hip-hop with influences from many cultures around the world. He has collaborated with influential names like Soulja Boy, The Game, Onyx and Swayvee.

WINEMOM

Performamnce Time: 19:20-19:40

WineMom is a Dublin-based four piece stepping their way confidently to the very forefront of the Irish music scene. Led by powerhouse frontwoman Rosanna, their sound draws parallels to Fleetwood Mac and Blondie. Their debut EP *Grand Affair* was released in April 2026.

OTHER PEOPLE'S LEISURE

Performamnce Time: 19:55-20:15

This Scottish electronic duo use analogue hardware, digital production as well as multi-projection visuals to create melody-driven music that translates seamlessly to their expansive sets, with lyrics that add emotional depth and drawing from a background in songwriting.

ROE

Performamnce Time: 20:30-20:50

Derry-based songwriter roe describes herself as "an emotional car crash with free will and an impulse to write." Through her live performances at Reeperbahn, SXSW and a UK arena run supporting Snow Patrol, she has connected with audiences all around the world.

FAMILIES AT AESTHETICA

Aesthetica is a festival for everyone – and families are at its heart. Spend a weekend filled with creativity, discovery and imagination. Specially curated film screenings introduce children to inspiring stories from around the world, whilst interactive workshops let young minds explore acting, coding, filmmaking and stop-motion animation with expert guidance. Kids can produce mini movies, design animated characters and spark new passions. Beyond workshops, our Media Arts trail lights up the city with mesmerising installations. From VR and games to podcasting and storytelling, Aesthetica is an adventure for the whole family.

Some events require pre-registration or a separate ticket.
Please check the corresponding pages for details and ratings, and asff.co.uk to book.

SCREENINGS (PG. 125)

Our Family Friendly screenings bring stories that matter to life, offering both children and adults a window to the world. Featuring a fun and vibrant mix of U and PG films, the programme highlights captivating tales from across the globe, sparking imagination for audiences of all ages. Explore this year's programme of Family Friendly animations, engaging dramas and laugh-out-loud comedies for young people.

WORKSHOPS & LABS (PG.214)

Dive headfirst into hands-on creativity at Aesthetica! Children can explore filmmaking, coding and stop-motion animation workshops, or visit our Games & VR Labs – featuring 50 innovative interactive projects. With activities that are suitable for U and PG audiences, everyone can experiment, play and discover new skills in a fun, immersive environment. This is the place to learn something brand new.

MEDIA ARTS TRAIL (PG. 65)

Three new installations light up York during Aesthetica Film Festival. Around the city, you will find works from artists Being Now Here, Squidsoup and Steve Messam, who are all working with colour, illumination and sound. Celebrate creativity and watch as the city of York comes alive. The Radical Listening Media Arts Trail runs from York Theatre Royal to King's Square and Exhibition Square. Free to all.

NEW MUSIC STAGE (PG. 66)

Discover the New Music Stage at Aesthetica, an all-day music festival featuring 10 breakthrough British acts who are already making waves across radio and the festival circuit. It's an exciting chance to experience fresh music from a whole host of genres – indie, folk, jazz, pop – and support emerging talent. 10 incredible acts. 10 unique sounds. See these artists here first, before they explode onto the world stage.

Sample Itinerary | Saturday 7 November

10:00 - 12:00 | Attend a Workshop – Want To Be A Filmmaker? (Separate ticket)
13:30 - 14:30 | Watch a Screening – Family Friendly 2
15:00 - 15:30 | Visit the Radical Listening Media Arts Trail
16:00 - 17:00 | Play at the Games Lab (Pre-register)
17:30 - 18:00 | See a band at the New Music Stage

Whilst children are in workshops, parents and guardians can attend a FREE screening at York St John. Pick up your ticket at the Hub, City Screen or York St John.

Jessie Buckley in The Pitch short film Pulsar

OFFICIAL SELECTION

At Aesthetica, our programme is shaped around how film can inspire, provoke and drive meaningful change. The curatorial focus is bold storytelling, innovative ideas and urgent, relevant themes.

Our Official Selection reflects the world we live in today. Films are programmed thematically by genre, creating a dynamic and thought-provoking viewing experience. We shine a light on timely subjects, using film as a lens to examine the past, confront the present and envision new futures.

Our curation is led by a diverse team of talented experts with backgrounds in some of the world's leading film festivals. Their collective vision enables audiences to engage with different cultures, fresh perspectives and approaches, and hear from the next generation of dynamic cinematic voices.

The festival is programmed into the following genres:

- ADVERTISING
- ANIMATION
- ARTISTS' FILM
- COMEDY
- DANCE
- DOCUMENTARY
- DRAMA
- EXPERIMENTAL
- FAMILY FRIENDLY
- FASHION
- GAMES
- MUSIC VIDEO
- THRILLER
- VR & IMMERSIVE
- PODCASTS

In-venue screenings are curated thematically by genre into programmes. **Seats are first come first served and we recommend getting to your desired screening 15-20 minutes before it starts.**

12

BEYOND THE ADVERT
ADVERTISING

Advertising is everywhere, but the best adverts do more than sell. They tell stories, create worlds and shape the way we see. This programme brings together films made for cars, luxury watches, drinks, independent fashion brands and social campaigns, alongside messages addressing violence against women, the war in Ukraine and the stereotypes that surround us.

01

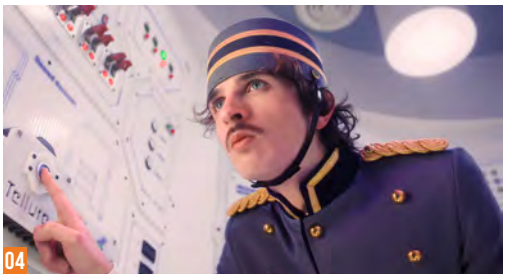
ONWARD MOMENTUM
Sewra G Kidane
USA, 2025, 5:17
A modern-day heroine etched in leather and velocity hurtles down the familiar Route 33. Each stitch is a road marker home, as leather learns its wearer and armor becomes second skin.

02

THE WORLD OF BOA CITY
Nicolee Tsin
UK, 2024, 1:41
An elderly couple reconnects over noodles. A heartbroken teen finds solace in singing love songs with childhood friends. A lonely man waits for his perfect karaoke moment at his regular table.

03

LES AIRELLES COURCHEVEL
Valentin Savin, Katerina Lagoda
France, 2025, 2:34
This film is a cinematic portrait of a mysterious place where time slows down and rituals become magic. *Les Airelles Courchevel* is a winter fairy-tale told through atmosphere, movement and light.



04

YVES SALOMON - ROCKETMAN
Katerina Lagoda, Valentin Savin
France, 2025, 1:50
Rocketman is a cinematic Christmas tale that follows two heroes as their journey unfolds in a handcrafted pop-up world, where rockets orbit planets and presents are delivered by parachute.

05

DON'T STAY BOTTLED UP
Ilanna Barkusky
USA, 2025, 1:30
A love story gets uncorked in Malibu in a spin on the 1960s TV sitcom "cold open." The film is influenced by the enduring charm of the show *Gidget*, with its Californian roots and golden setting.

06

STORY TREE
Max Blustin
Japan, UK, 2025, 1:40
The seed of a narrative is cast aside, and it begins a journey of its own, from tiny beginnings to a vast story world. This film depicts inspiration as a real, tangible aspect of the natural landscape.

07

THAT LITTLE VOICE

Sandy Matta
UK, 2026, 2:00

After experiencing a drive-by Islamophobic remark, Farah is rattled but carries on with her day – until she comes face to face with her inner voice, debating whether she should take action.

08

GWM - THE CALLING

Riyan Durrani
China, Pakistan, 2026, 2:00

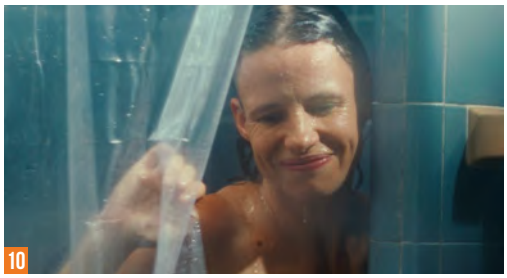
A man, trapped within the confines of a life he mistakes for reality, is haunted by visions of something more. As his perception shifts and horizons open, he follows an instinctive pull into the unknown.

09

WWF - NATURE NEEDS US NOW

Natasza Cetner
Poland, UK, 2026, 0:51

This animated film for WWF's *Nature Needs Us Now* campaign is a poetic reminder that nature sustains our air, water, food, health and joy – and when we protect it, we protect ourselves.



10

NOT JUST A BREAK

Laís Sambugaro
Brazil, 2026, 1:00

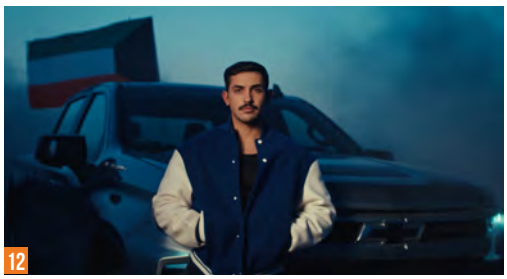
About 40% of women leave work after having children, and it can take up to five years to return. *Not Just A Break*, made for LinkedIn, portrays the daily challenges of maternity leave.

11

LIGHT HOLE

Toru Katori
Japan, 2026, 1:45

After encountering a book, you feel as though you're somewhere else, as though you have become something entirely new. A girl races through that imagined world, propelled by narrative itself.



12

THE SILVERADOS

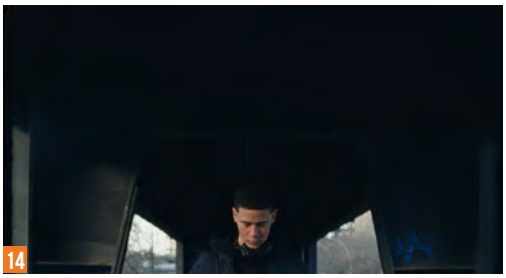
Mohamed Maged
Kuwait, 2025, 1:30

In Kuwait, the Chevrolet Silverado became more than a vehicle; it became synonymous with aggression. This film moves beyond the machine and into the lives of the real men behind the wheel.

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
Friargate	YSJU	Friargate
19:00-20:00	19:00-20:00	13:30-14:30

13

BLUE & YELLOW
Petr Vlček
Czechia, 2026, 1:02
Four years. The war in Ukraine hasn't ended. People just stopped noticing it. In response to this , WMC/GREY, in collaboration with Stink Prague, is launching the #blueyellow awareness initiative.



14

MESS
Anna Rozhetskaya
Germany, 2026, 1:26
This ad, made for a mental health charity, features spoken word about the insecurities of being a man –about being angry and misunderstood – as he goes around his city dancing and moving.

15

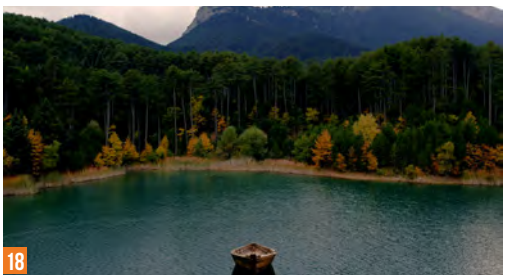
BYSTANDER
Ian Roderick Gray
UK, 2026, 1:26
Across a series of everyday settings – a bus stop late at night, a locker room after a match, an online gaming session – we witness subtle but familiar moments of harassment towards women.

16

THE TESTIMONIAL
Alice Fassi
Italy, 2025, 5:36
Actor Pierfrancesco Favino plays the role of an unconventional testimonial, guiding audiences on an immersive journey through the symbolic locations of the iconic Manufacture in Le Brassus.

17

THE POWER OF LIVE
Lore Loyens
Belgium, 2026, 1:07
A dark beach at night. An illuminated thin stream of sand slowly begins to rise. Guided by deep tones, wind and swelling strings, the living sand dances through deserted corridors of a Kursaal.



18

LIVE YOUR MYTH IN GREECE
Michail
Greece, 2026, 1:48
A cinematic reinterpretation of Greece as origin rather than a holiday destination, positioning the country not as a place to visit, but as a mythical space for personal transformation.

REIGNITE XVII: CULTURE AS INFRASTRUCTURE, STORIES AS POWER

A LANDMARK GATHERING OF CREATIVE CITIES

5 NOVEMBER, CITY SCREEN, YO1 9QL | 18:00-19:30

There are 14 UNESCO Creative Cities in the UK, from Perth's leadership in craft Glasgow's innovation in music, to Aberystwyth and Manchester's role in shaping literature, join representatives from each city to explore how how creative practice is embedded how urban futures are designed and built.

15

THE PEOPLE WHO MAKE US
ANIMATION 1

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 1	YTR Main House	City Screen 1
12:00-13:00	16:00-17:00	12:00-13:00

How much of who we become belongs to us, and how much to others? In these imaginative and deeply human stories, lives are altered by family, love, memory, mentorship, absence and unexpected encounters. From comic misadventure and time-bending devotion to grief, resilience and renewal, they show the lasting influence others leave on our own choices.

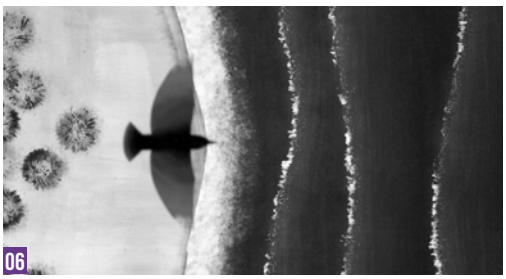
ME, MYSELF AND MARY
John Michell
UK, 2026, 13:20
Chris O'Dowd and Aisling Bea feature in the wild true story of the time Séamas O'Reilly got his days mixed up and ended up alone with his boss and the President of Ireland, whilst high on drugs.

IF/WHEN
Courtney Westbrook
Australia, 2025, 9:40
Ollie Quatch drifts through time, experiencing it out of order. But when they see a reality without Az, the only person who really makes them feel grounded, Ollie refuses to accept fate as final.

THE LAST TIME I SAW YOU
Ella Rose Corrieri
UK, 2026, 9:40
In the year 2225, Romy is far from their home in a derelict city. Determined not to be late for a funeral, Romy embarks on an arduous journey burdened by grief and a large mysterious tank.

BALL FACE
Laurence Thérien
Canada, 2026, 4:30
Ball Face follows a middle school girl who, terrified of all sports, survives a chaotic ball game by accidentally bouncing a ball off her face, discovering an unconventional tactic that leads to victory.

TSUNAMI
Maria Pulido
Spain, 2026, 9:04
In a seaside town, Ana empties her grandmother's house. Among memories, she finds a photograph. As the sea roars and a wave sweeps everything away, she understands the house is not home.



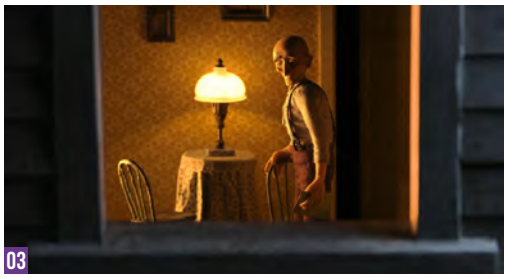
WILDKIND
John McDaid
UK, 2025, 7:18
Voiced by three generations of one family, *WildKind* is a poem to awaken the senses, a fluid journey of hope and healing. It is a universal bedtime story, a call to nurture a life wild and kind.

THE WEIGHT WE CARRY
ANIMATION 2

Conflict can leave a mark on the soul, changing lives forever. Across six powerful narratives, characters confront war, addiction, mental illness, family histories, spiritual turmoil and inner demons. Through journeys of survival, resilience, memory and self-discovery, these stories are about the impact of struggle, the wounds violence creates and the hope that endures.

LITTLE SHREW (SNOWFLAKE)
Kate Bush
UK, 2024, 4:12
A little shrew searches for hope as she makes her way across a bombed-out city. Blissfully unaware of the dangers surrounding her, she slowly journeys through a war-torn Land of the Giants.

SMALL HOURS
Oscar Wyndham Lewis
UK, 2026, 9:56
Made with oil paint on glass, *Small Hours* asks how the isolation of addiction and mental illness can distort our sense of self – and how small acts of care and presence can slowly begin to restore it.



HELL
Parker Croft
USA, 2025, 5:00
Hell follows the patriarch of a dying farm as he is ground down by the machinery of despair. What begins as endurance curdles into a portrait of collapse told through dust, labour and silence.

WHAT'S NEXT
Cristiana Apostol
Romania, 5:23
Baby Sunflower is captivated by the beauty of existence and sets out to discover "what's next." When Grandpa Sunflower cannot offer a simple answer, he tries to offer wisdom from his memories.

EL CUERPO DE CRISTO
Bea Lema
Spain, 2025, 12:00
With an unacknowledged, complex mental disorder, Adela feels like something is harming her and only religion understands. She confesses to her healer the disturbing inception of her suffering.

TRADING CARDS
Radheya Jang
UK, 2026, 14:58
The past, present and future collide when a man confronts his younger self over a game of trading cards. An exploration of identity, nostalgia and the erosion of childhood innocence.

15

VOICES OF TRANSFORMATION
ANIMATION 3

THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 1	YTR Main House	City Screen 2
12:00-13:00	16:00-17:00	22:00-23:00

In today's society, a woman's journey towards herself can be complex. Across six films, voices rise against silence, bodies carry memory and lives are transformed. From struggles for equality and reproductive freedom to reconciliation and self-acceptance, these characters show the courage required to claim identity, challenge expectations and embrace change.

01

VIRGIN FANDANGO
Marcy Page
Portugal, 2026, 10:42
A short musical, using a novel technique of animated azulejos (painted tiles), that features a rebellious Mary using her voice to celebrate the women of history in the struggle for equality.

02

LOST TOUCH
Justine Klaiber
Switzerland, 2025, 12:24
Amelia is the sole survivor on a damaged spaceship that is now caught in the gravitational pull of a planet. When a mysterious presence appears, she is torn between the past and the future.

03

CARLA AND HER LEGS
Christoph Büttner
Germany, 2026, 14:11
Carla has had enough. No one is interested in her talent as an acrobat. All they care about is that she has no legs. Then, out of the blue, the show's director pressures Carla to perform.

04

ONCE IN A BODY
María Cristina Pérez González
Colombia, USA, 2025, 10:20
Whilst dealing with a strange being that lives inside her, a woman decides to reconcile with her sister over an incident from their adolescence, exploring the experiences through their bodies.

05

SUSURROS
Pewinski, Lombard, Reignier, Pluchard, Francillon, Parmentier
France, 2025, 7:27
From the witch hunts of 17th century Europe to the overturning of Roe v. Wade in the United States in 2022, *Susurros* follows the story of two women faced with a pregnancy they did not choose.

06

MAKING A MOTHER
Emily Downe
UK, 2026, 4:05
This animation explores matrescence, the deeply personal but unseen metamorphosis of becoming a mother, calling on ancient wisdom to give voice to this drastic yet invisible transformation.

MAKING SENSE OF THE WORLD
ANIMATION 4

How do we make sense of loss, memory and the mysteries that shape our lives? Characters navigate grief, illness, longing, family histories and childhood reckonings in search of meaning. Through recollections, unlikely journeys and acts of remembrance, these stories illuminate how we see ourselves, honour those we have lost and carry their legacies forward.

01

LIVING WITH A VISIONARY
Stephen P. Neary
USA, 2026, 15:00
After over 50 years of marriage, John must care for his wife, whilst learning how to live alongside her vivid hallucinations. This true story is adapted from John Matthias's *The New Yorker* memoir.

02

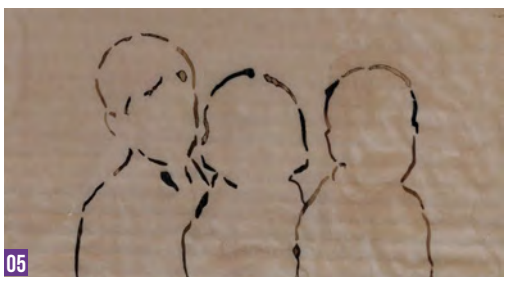
I WAS KIDNAPPED
Dhananjay Barangule
UK, 2026, 6:42
Now that Dhananjay is older, he enjoys recounting stories from his childhood in Mumbai. Upon looking back on his kidnapping, it slowly starts to dawn on him how it may have affected his mum.

03

DEATH'S PEAK
Willy Fair
UK, 2025, 9:00
Desperate for connection and unable to move on, David digs up his brother's corpse. With their trusty red wagon, the two ascend a treacherous mountain in pursuit of their old childhood dream.

04

VISCERA
Hristina Iankova
UK, 2026, 6:59
In the days following her mother's death, Lyra, a fishmonger, is drawn towards a beached whale. Entering its decaying body, she confronts the memories and grief she has long kept buried inside.



05

DOUGH + ME
Cecile Fountain-Jardim
UK, USA, 2026, 5:52
Dough + Me follows the director's search to properly get to know her uncle, who died in 1997 from AIDS. It is the story of both his legacy and the enduring emotional impact of the AIDS crisis.

06

ON SAINT NICHOLAS' EVE
Emy Mirel Ivașcă
Romania, 2025, 11:00
After seeing a man lying in the snow, a boy recalls a night spent with his father years before. But playing with his father takes an unexpected turn, whilst his dream toy leaves a bitter aftertaste.

12

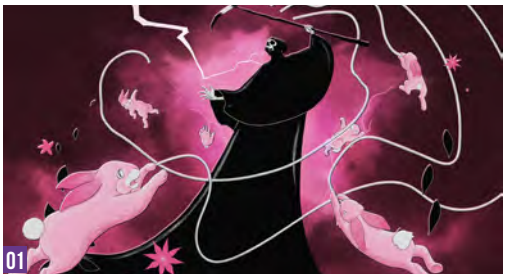
LIVING ON OUR OWN TERMS
ANIMATION 5

WEDNESDAY
YTR Main House
16:30-17:30

THURSDAY
City Screen 2
19:45-20:45

SATURDAY
Yorks. Museum
15:30-16:30

What does it mean to forge your own path? In this thought-provoking series, individuals and communities confront expectation, inheritance, mortality, isolation and oppression in pursuit of freedom. From apprentices and pioneers to revolutionaries and dreamers, this selection is a celebrate resilience, self-determination and the courage to choose one's own future.



A LITTLE DEATH
Leto Meade, Jonathan Rockefeller
UK, 2026, 12:23
Death's patience is tested when his sweet and gentle apprentice appears incapable of carrying out his assigned task, leading him to seek professional help from the most unlikely of places.

ACID CITY
Jack Wedge, Will Freudenheim
USA, 2026, 12:30
Acid City documents life in an isolated city. It is composed of real interviews conducted across NYC, ranging from regular people on the street, to water scientists and emergency responders.

PICKLED
Fanny Capu
UK‹ 2026, 8:39
In Edie's Granny's world, they pickle everything, preserving their family history forever. But when Granny joins their ancestors, Edie has to decide if she'll continue their tradition, or live for herself.

THE FALL
Christine Rebet
France, 2025, 5:19
In 1700s Jamaica, enslaved Africans escaped plantations and founded communities of Maroons, led by Queen Nanny. Simone Harries, one of her descendants, examines her enduring legacy.

IN THE BEGINNING
Ala Nunu
Poland, Portugal, Spain, 2026, 10:50
Legless birds of paradise, the great hamster cull and tardigrades on the moon. A surreal story inspired by real events, which looks at humanity's desire for preservation by controlling the narrative.

LES VIEUX
Axelle, Boris, Fanny, Lucile, Jérémy, Lauren, Maëlys, Manuel
UK, 2026, 12:23
A brief interlude of life, where the end gently unfolds beneath laughter and warmth. This short film portrays a group of elderly individuals leisurely basking in the sunlight along the Côte d'Azur.

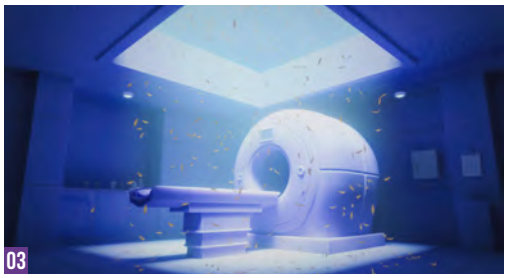
FINDING YOUR PLACE
ANIMATION 6

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 2	YSJU	Yorks. Museum
10:00-11:00	13:30-14:30	19:00-20:00

Our lives are tied to other people, and to lose that is destabilising. Follow as characters navigate gender, grief, illness, family legacies, community and belonging in search of themselves. Through moments of courage, connection and reinvention, these worlds explore how identity is shaped, challenged and reclaimed, revealing the many ways we become who we are.

EYELINER
Aisha Boudjillouli
UK, 2026, 8:30
Nina and her best friend Lily decide to steal an eyeliner. When they receive wildly different reactions to wearing makeup, Nina discovers that her journey as a trans girl might not be so easy.

DAUGHTERS OF THE LATE COLONEL
Elizabeth Hobbs
UK, 2026, 9:23
After the death of their ill-tempered and controlling father, two middle-aged sisters find themselves at a loss. An unexpected visitor sparks the courage in them to begin their lives anew.



THIS IS NOT A MEMOIR
Josh Earle
Australia, 2026, 22:08
When Chris Ramsey, a young Australian man living in London, is diagnosed with bowel cancer, he is forced onto a challenging new path, from first appointments to breaking the news to loved ones.

MAKING IT FIT
Mariana Leal
UK, 2025, 4:30
A short documentary film about how the LGBTQIA+ community has been reinventing funerary and remembrance rituals to better support and reflect the way people live in community.

DANCE OF THE SPIRITS
Andreea-Lorena Florea
UK, 2026, 6:26
Matei, a young Romanian shepherd boy, finds more comfort in his sheep than with his abusive, alcoholic dad. But when he starts to mimic his father's violence, he's faced with a question: "who am I?"

DEEP END
Puzhen Zhang
UK, 2026, 7:38
A shy young girl overcomes her intense fear of swimming – and of connection – when she develops an unexpected and magical summer bond with a bold classmate in the deep end of the pool.

PG

ART ON FILM
ARTISTS' FILM 1

THURSDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
Friargate	Friargate	Yorks. Museum
13:30-14:30	12:00-13:00	13:30-14:30

Art, in its almost countless forms, has always been a way for humans to connect, communicate and learn from one another across time and space. From songs of resistance to what we inherit from our maternal lineage, art has the ability to keep history alive. In this selection, audiences are encouraged to rethink how we view the past and how we inspire future generations.

01

SRS (SILK ROAD SONGBOOK) FILM (NO DIALOGUE)
Millie Chen, Arzu Ozkal
Canada, 2026, 23:00
SRS (Silk Road Songbook) broadcasts songs of resistance, written by women from local areas, on an ancient Eurasian migration route between Istanbul, Tehran, Tashkent, Bishkek and Xi'an.

02

PILLAR (NO DIALOGUE)
Ciril Zupan
Slovenia, 2024, 3:21
Three pillars stand somewhere in nature, their place in the world is unclear. How did they come to be in the forest? How do these manmade structures disrupt the natural rhythms of the space?

03

DHIKR
Mengyun Han
UK, 2026, 21:09
Dhikr transforms acoustics of Uzbek textile workshops – looms, women's voices and prayer – into a bold cinematic meditation that juxtaposes Soviet machine devotion with Sufi remembrance.

04

THE HALL (SUBTITLED)
Jingru (Cyan) Cheng, Chen Zhan, Mengfan Wang
China, 2024, 3:45
This project transforms Shigushan village's People's Commune Assembly Hall – once key to national politics – into an immersive theatre of villagers' everyday lives, which blends past and present.

05

DON'T TOUCH THE ARTWORK
Shams Uz Zuha Mansur
UK, 2025, 7:38
A museum's rigid façade is shattered under the defiant gaze of a young brown woman. Her look is the trigger, instantly launching a "visual riot" where the known rules of reality dissolve into chaos.

HUMAN INTERVENTION
ARTISTS' FILM 2

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
YTR Studio	City Screen 2	YSJU
19:00-20:00	15:30-16:30	20:30-21:30

Our vast world holds many stories that may never be seen by most humans, hidden from society's view – whether that be the frozen tundras of the Arctic, the dark depths of the ocean, eerie silent forests or the rapidly shrinking salt plains of the dead sea. These shorts explore the seemingly endless liminal spaces that explore the intersection of mother nature and mankind.

SINKHOLES
Karen Russo
UK, 2025, 18:45
This hybrid documentary short transforms the rapidly shrinking Dead Sea – on the border of Israel, Palestine and Jordan – into a reflection on both environmental collapse and human fragility.

ONE DAY THE SUN WILL ONLY SHINE FOR YOU.
Gjert Rognli
Norway, 2026, 7:00
In an unpredicatable age, this film takes audiences on a journey that reveals how our actions influence the future. The narrative drawns upon the Indigenous Sámi people's cultural heritage.

NO BEFORE OR AFTER: NOTES ON A FILM
Emily Richardson
UK, 2026, 20:00
Despite thawing permafrost, the World Memory Bank professes to protect important scientific and cultural knowledge for 500-1000 years, housed in a former coal mine in the Arctic Circle.

ONE
Maya de Almeida Araujo
Portugal, 2025, 18:00
Created across Portugal and the Azores, *One* explores humanity's relationship with the oceans. It tells the story of people who came to the island searching for something and found a sense of home.

CELEBRATE THE BEST FILMS. JOIN US AT THIS YEAR'S AWARDS CEREMONY.

SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER, YORKSHIRE MUSEUM | 16:30-19:00

Our 16th edition closes with an awards ceremony where we recognise films from each genre, as well as our Craft Awards, Best of Fest and Special Guest Awards. Be part of the celebration.

PG

NATURAL HERITAGE
ARTISTS' FILM 3

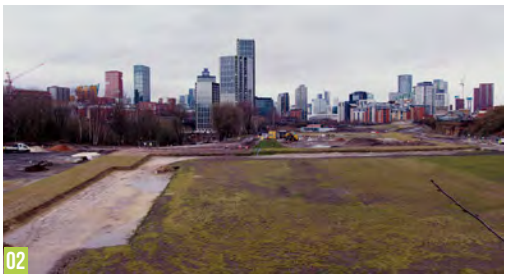
WEDNESDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
YTR Studio	YTR Studio	City Screen 1
20:00-21:00	19:00-20:00	19:00-20:00

From football madness and Welsh folklore to classic works of literature and conversations about the weather, these five films explore the fundamental cornerstones of British identity. Actor Michael Sheen urges audiences to talk more openly about the climate, whilst Stephen Fry provides a cinematic retelling of *Ode to a Nightingale* by British poet, John Keats.

01

YOU TOLD US TO TALK ABOUT THE WEATHER
Harry Tomlin
UK, 2025, 4:49

In the past six hours, 94% of Brits discussed the weather. In the past five years, 7.000 have been arrested for speaking out about the climate crisis. This film, starring Michael Sheen, asks why.



02

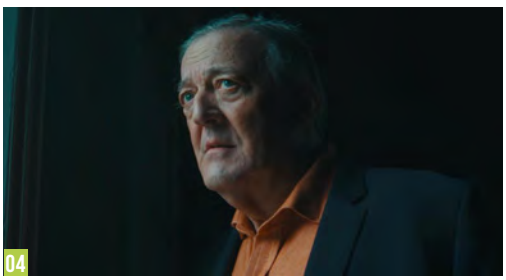
MATERIAL RIVER
Fiona Sinéad Brehony
UK, 2026, 18:29

For more than a decade, Many Hands Craft Collective has met in Victoria Square in Manchester. *Material River* examines how the group responds as regeneration transforms their neighbourhood.

03

FORMS OF CIRCULATION #3 (MIDDLESBROUGH FOOTBALL CLUB)
Paul Stewart, Sarah Perks
UK, 2026, 10:07

Shot at Middlesbrough Football Club's stadium, this film explores the bodies, voices and energies that congregate around football culture, as well as the ecologies that inhabit the stadium's edges.



04

ODE TO A NIGHTINGALE
Tommy Creagh
UK, 2026, 7:23

This is a haunting cinematic interpretation of Keats's *Ode to a Nightingale*, as Stephen Fry gives voice to the poet's meditation on beauty, mortality and transcendence, set within Keats House.

05

TŶ UNNOS
Lily Tiger, Nina Maria Allmoslechner
UK, 2026, 12:20

According to Welsh folklore, if you build a house over one night, the place is yours. One such house in Penrhos, which was built over 200 years ago. Tŷ Unnos tells the story of its last owners.

ODD JOBS (SUBTITLED)
COMEDY 1

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
City Screen 2	City Screen 1	YTR Studio
10:00-11:30	19:00-20:30	15:00-16:30

There's no such thing as an honest day's work. A 16-year-old's first shift descends into initiation rituals and questionable life advice, a security guard goes far beyond the call of duty to protect a taxidermic boar, and a rookie hitman botches his first job. This programme punches the clock so you don't have to, finding the sublime and the ridiculous in the daily grind.

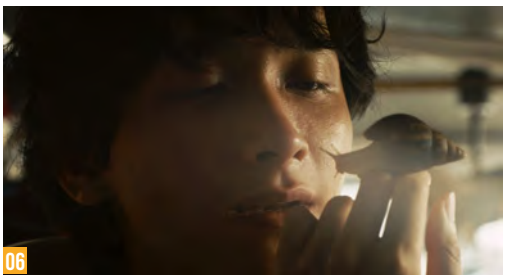
LUCKY LIAM
Thomas Hefferon, TJ Hundtofte
Ireland, 2026, 10:20
Lucky Liam's notorious luck may finally have run out. Digging his own grave, the hustler tries every tactic to survive, until his execution is interrupted by the arrival of a skittish, rookie hitman.

THE SOCIAL ASPECT (SUBTITLED)
Sander August Dahl
Norway, 2025, 16:15
Steinar and Tine navigate Norway's cold corporate world. As the music mirrors their inner struggles, they gradually lose control and dignity within the modern job market and welfare system.

AND WHAT DO THE PIGS THINK? (SUBTITLED)
Edith Jorisch
Canada, 2026, 19:00
An art gallery guard discovers that a precious taxidermied boar has fallen. Absurd accusations, paranoia and delusional theories transforms the incident into a vortex of absurd and awkward chaos.

KETCHUP (SUBTITLED)
Tjeerd Dam
Netherlands, 2025, 8:45
Andrea has an irresistible need to smear herself with ketchup in private. But when the unusual habit crosses into her workplace, it sparks the beginning of a transformative personal journey.

THE CRAB CAKE KID
Kirill Teslia
UK, 2026, 14:05
In a sleepy restaurant, 16-year-old Rob lands his first job, but it is far from fine dining. Despite the madness, Rob finds himself growing fond of the chaotic kitchen and the unpredictable staff.



THE DREAM IS A SNAIL (SUBTITLED)
Thien An Nguyen
South Korea, Vietnam, 2026, 15:00
A young artist develops an odd addiction to snails after landing a bizarre new gig: serving as a motionless human racetrack for snails during a rejuvenation therapy workshop for seniors.

18

THE STATE OF US (SUBTITLED)
COMEDY 2

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 2	City Screen 2	City Screen 2
15:00-16:30	10:00-11:30	10:00-11:30

Every relationship is a performance – and these couples are struggling with their lines. Whether dithering through fatherhood's opening night, auditioning a third party, enduring an strained marriage, choosing between the spotlight and the person in the wings, or restaging an old summer for a better ending, they all discover: there's no script for being an "us."

EGO (SUBTITLED)
Vegard Dahle
Norway, 2025, 14:00
Molecular gastronomy. Pretentious self-realisation. The strange choice of having children. These are all ingredients in this absurd and darkly funny semi-apocalyptic double date taken from hell.

YOUTHFUL INDISCRETIONS (SUBTITLED)
Domenico Cicerone
Italy, 2025, 19:00
One night in a hotel, a long-term couple decides to experiment with a ménage à trois with a much younger woman. But the game of desire opens hidden wounds and reveals long-unspoken truths.

BABY ON BOARD (SUBTITLED)
Jamie Luke Milligan
UK, 2026, 7:57
A new father is paralysed with concerns about being a dad. He keeps finding elaborate reasons to not leave the hospital car park, even though his wife keeps begging him to just go home.

GOBBL (SUBTITLED)
CC Wade
UK, 2026, 20:00
Tom, a struggling musician, is at a life crossroads. He can either climb the ladder with Gobbl, a new blowjob delivery service, to appease his girlfriend, or he can pursue his dreams of performing.

EXAM (SUBTITLED)
Jan Naszewski
France, Poland, 2026, 12:44
One couple, their therapist under close scrutiny, an international evalution, an interpreter, and the hidden frustrations of the long-term spouses. These will be the longest minutes of their lives.

BACK TO TADOU (SUBTITLED)
Jean-Nicolas Bertouille Blais
Canada, 2026, 12:44
How do we all try to rewrite our past in order to make peace with ourselves? Maude seeks closure by revisiting a traumatic memory: a beach encounter in Tadoussac with Justin, over 10 years ago.

IN MY SKIN
COMEDY 3

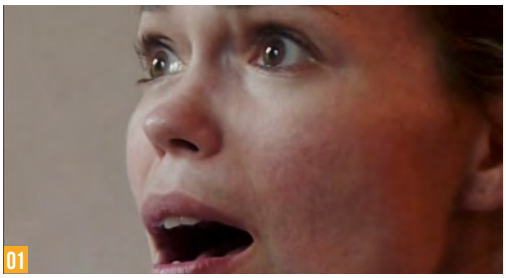
WEDNESDAY
Friargate
15:30-17:00

SATURDAY
City Screen 2
21:00-22:30

SUNDAY
City Screen 2
17:00-18:30

18

Nobody scrutinises us like we scrutinise ourselves. From chopped fringes and stubborn family hair to inherited wrinkles, unusual anatomy and one irreplaceable jumper, these films chart our relationships with our own reflections – until a man wakes up in the body he's spent a lifetime objectifying, and everyone learns what it costs to live on the mirror's other side.

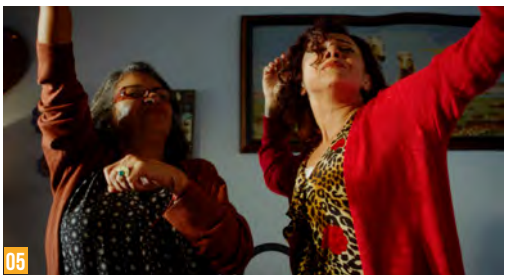


MIRCO BANGS
Iris Breward
UK, 2025, 5:08
A woman quickly spirals as she considers a drastic haircut. She asks her boyfriend whether he likes the idea of her cutting in microbangs and he can't seem to answer the question correctly.

LIKE RABBITS
Henry Carson
UK, 2026, 7:54
On his wedding night, a groom frets about consummating his marriage due to his "unusual" penis. This film explores the real-world consequences of experiencing body dysmorphia.

TELL YOUR FACE
Jill Worsley
UK, 2026, 14:05
Haunted by her late mother's praise of her smooth skin, Chikana hits 30 and begins to obsess over wrinkles. Without the money for Botox, she concocts an absurd and extreme way to stop them.

KITTY
Lizzie Hart, James Newman
UK, 2026, 14:37
Neurodivergent Kitty, lover of trinkets and Kate Bush, discovers her favourite jumper ruined. She's left with one choice: sell her precious collections, or risk losing the beloved jumper forever.



HAIR!
Sara Jade Alfaro-Dehghani
Canada, 2026, 15:36
Sisters Farrah, Miriam and Layla have their monthly hair removal and chai session, as their daughters watch on. With them, they bring decades of family drama and inches of dark, stubborn hair.

ASKING4IT
Emma Rose Jesse
UK, 2026, 15:36
A man views women only as objects of desire, until one morning, he wakes to find he has changed into a woman. Confronted with life on the other side, he discovers the cost of being “desirable.”

15

LEGENDS IN THEIR OWN MINDS
COMEDY 4

THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SUNDAY
Yorks. Museum	City Screen 1	YSJU
21:00-22:30	19:00-20:30	15:00-16:30

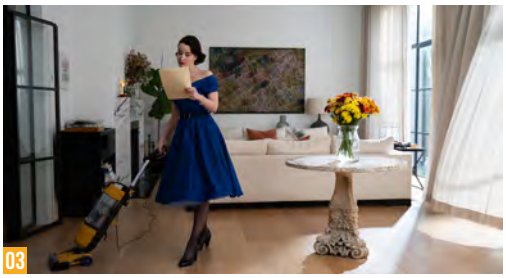
These six shorts follow believers of their own hype wherever it leads: into back alleys spun into epics, monstrous egos mistaken for romance, meathead bravado pushed past breaking, statues competing with deadly seriousness, soulmates found in the mirror, and one husband's watertight excuse for abandoning his family. Magnificent self-belief, in the face of all evidence.

01

MY WIFE DOESN'T MOVE ANYMORE
Rui Wang
UK, 2026, 20:55
In a world where love is currency and women are commodities, a man constructs an elaborate justification for abandoning his immobile wife and caged daughter for a woman living next door.

02

DUG. OR, THE MORAL OF THE STORY IS
Melanie Spencer
UK, 2026, 4:20
Mikey got drunk. But it's no aw bad, know wit ah mean? A film about getting lost up back alley, giving proof that the Scottish gift isn't bagpipes – but the ability to spin anything into an epic.



03

LOVE INTEREST
Tanya Lialina
UK, 2026, 15:47
Hazel auditions for the part of Love Interest in a big budget film. The director is so enamoured with her performance, he continues the romance in real life – all she has to do is stay in character.

04

DYNAMITE DEALER
Jordon Scott Kennedy
UK, 2026, 13:14
Dynamite Dealer follows Alex Ludd, a young rugby lad as he navigates the cartoonishly macho, meathead world of the Idley Trojans, where he pushes himself to prove he's "man enough."

05

POSERS
Alexander O'Loughlin
UK, 2025, 3:29
A documentary film crew is granted access to the 4th Annual Musical Statues Competition. Tensions are high, excitement is buzzing, and for three competitors, it all comes down to this.

06

SELFLOVE (SUBTITLED)
Nik Azad
Germany, 2025, 12:30
A young man finally finds his soulmate: himself. After all, no one understands him so well. The two of them could live forever in their comfort zone – if it just weren't for that one little thing.

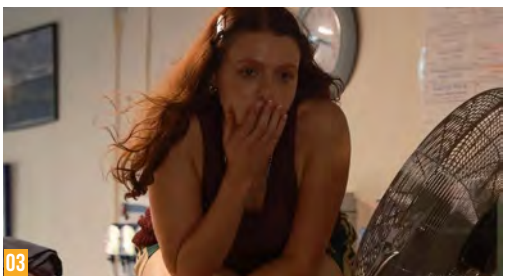
REALITY CHECK
COMEDY 5

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
City Screen 2	City Screen 2	City Screen 1
21:00-22:30	15:00-16:30	17:00-18:30

What if reality came with terms and conditions? One woman knows hers: strong tea, punctuality, never dig behind the shed. The rest learn the hard way – a hypnotherapist under her own spell, an Instagram Romeo too good to be true, a fiancée who exists in the Betaverse, a dog pilgrimage invented in panic, one laundrette's doomed party. Always read the fine print.

TIME'S UP, I'M AFRAID
James Button
UK, 2025, 14:00
A hypnotherapist is running a routine session, when she begins to suspect that she may be the one who has been hypnotised, blurring the lines between patient, therapist and actual reality.

NOBODY BARKS (SUBTITLED)
Júlia Coldwell Serra
Spain, 2025, 19:52
Candela accidentally runs over her nephew's dog, but decides not to confess. Instead, she invents a legend about a dog pilgrimage to a sacred tree and invites him to come with her on the big search.



LAUNDREAMS
Evie Ward-Drummond, Amber Gadd
UK, 2025, 14:17
The hottest day of the summer. A laundrette manned by 20-year-olds Minnie and Leah. Nothing ever happens here, until Danny walks through the doors, and they throw a party to impress him.

FAUX AMIS
Theodore Matza
USA, 2025, 14:00
American 20-somethings Adele and May travel to Paris to unite with the handsome Jacques, who has been courting Adele via Instagram. Jacques turns out to be an infamous reclusive local.

IN BETWEEN
Hannah Mamalis
Ireland, 2025, 13:53
Anna knows that she replaced the Anna that came before her and another Anna will appear. But ahead of her inevitable departure, she decides to leave a letter attempting to pass on her world view.

INTO THE BETAVERSE
Varun Raman, Tom Hancock
UK, 2026, 14:11
Gary proposed to his girlfriend. However, their relationship exists in a virtual world – the Betaverse. His best mate, Dave, suspects she's a scammer, so he also enters the Betaverse to spy on them.

15

IT'S THE LITTLE THINGS
COMEDY 6

WEDNESDAY
City Screen 2
17:30-18:30

THURSDAY
City Screen 3
11:45-12:45

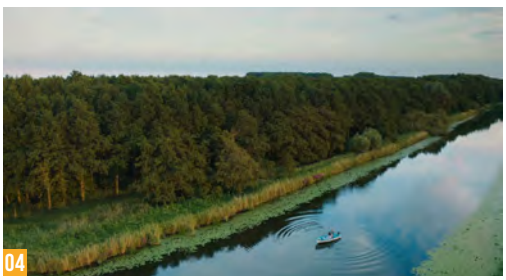
FRIDAY
Yorks. Museum
16:00-17:00

It started so small. A catcall. A pinch. A bus seat. A fly. A game of Scattergories. Viewed from high above, humanity's problems might look trivial to some – but zoom in and every tiny slight is a war that's just waiting to happen. This is a stuffed programme of minor incidents and major meltdowns that proves the shortest fuse is always attached to the smallest bomb.

BREEZEBLOCK (SUBTITLED)
Thomas Bernon, Julien Gamarde
France, 2025, 4:20
In the middle of the forest, a man builds a breezeblock wall to protect himself from a fly swooping down on him, convinced the tiny insect poses an unstoppable, terrifying threat to his safety.

BUS (SUBTITLED)
Andre Balbuena
Peru, 2025, 8:47
In the middle of rush hour traffic in Peru's capital city of Lima, a young student refuses to give up his bus seat to an elderly woman, sparking unexpected chaos among the passengers.

FK FACE**
Tim Hamilton
Australia, 2026, 7:54
During a casual game of Scattergories, four good friends discover that the most dangerous thing in the room isn't time, guns or bad language – it's actually how well they all really know each other.



LITTLE PROBLEMS (SUBTITLED)
Chris de Krijger
Netherlands, 2025, 10:04
Little Problems takes a look at the absurdity of everyday life by following the small setbacks and trivial conflicts of ordinary people, zooming out to an extremely wide bird's-eye perspective.

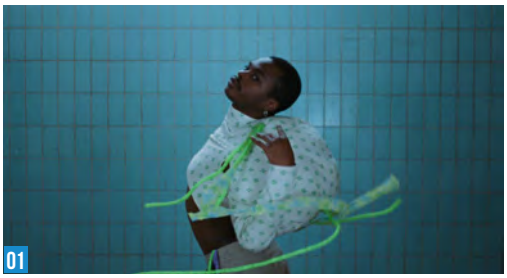
LET'S (NOT) TALK ABOUT THE SNAKE (SUBTITLED)
Håkon Anton Olavsen
Norway, 2026, 14:29
The party is just getting started when Gard pinches his friend Charlotte on the butt, just as a joke. Gard agrees it was pointless. Still, he spends the rest of the evening trying to prove his point.

HEY SEXY
Jess O'Kane
UK, 2026, 7:43
HEY SEXY is an irreverent tour through the mind of Paul, a builder who makes a habit of catcalling women. But before long, Paul's routine is disturbed when his hammer starts talking dirty to him.

LODGED IN THE BRINK (SUBTITLED)
DANCE 1

WEDNESDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
Yorks. Museum	Friargate	Friargate
20:00-21:00	19:00-20:00	12:00-13:00

Johannesburg's single-sex hostels are explored as spaces that both subvert and support traditional Black Zulu patriarchal masculinities, whilst queer people in Stockholm navigate conformity and self-expression. Also within these films, a cleaning routine becomes something new in a pole-dancing studio and a lion dance interrogates the emotional cost of assimilation.



ONCE UPON A TIME IN STOCKHOLM (SUBTITLED)
Parmida Hamdollazadehkive
Sweden, 2026, 9:51
Through both movement and music by Mansa, dancers navigate Stockholm's hidden social demands, tracing the tension between conformity and self-expression in a journey towards liberation.

SONDER
Thuthuka Sibisi
South Africa, 2026, 26:00
On the outskirts of Johannesburg, decrepit buildings house thousands of men. There is a complex system, which subverts and supports traditional Black Zulu patriarchal masculinities.

A LION
Nastassia Winge Tan
Netherlands, 2026, 3:36
A Lion explores identity, assimilation as well as intergenerational silence. Drawing on the traditional lion dance, the film transforms a cultural ritual into a space for quiet reflection, pride and return.

A SAD WOMEN (NO DIALOGUE)
Leïla Macaire, Romane Piffaut
France, 2026, 8:00
Choreographer Romane Piffaut and filmmaker Leïla Macaire reclaim the figure of the crying woman, reimagining her through a new staging that experiments with both the body and absurdity.

DAYSHIFT (NO DIALOGUE)
Zéré Turlykhanova
USA, 2025, 3:05
This story follows a middle-aged cleaning lady tidying a pole dancing studio. When she wanders into a world she's only seen from the sidelines, her life transforms from routine into reverie.

THE BLOOD QUARTER (SUBTITLED)
Florence Peyrard, Max Gozy
France, 2026, 7:15
A security guard watches over an empty building – the former slaughterhouses of the city of Paris. Her presence awakens the memory of the place and the space becomes a living archive.

15

A DISTANT BURNING LIGHT

DANCE 2

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 2	Yorks. Museum	YSJU
21:30-22:30	12:00-13:00	19:00-20:00

A girl finds she is the only Black dancer in her class and escapes to a dream world, where Black ballerinas surround her. Teenagers get ready for a night at "Pico" Mexican dance club in LA. A woman's journey navigates colonial systems to re-count a history-shaping voyage. Amongst the selection, a woman flees to the woods, finding a frenzied forest dance ritual.

01

BRUTA

Sulian Rios
France, 2026, 9:51

Bruta tells the story of a world where seriousness and absurdity coexist. Three protagonists carry these two forces in their bodies and gestures, until they turn against a mysterious masked man.

02

ON A SUNDAY AT ELEVEN

Alicia K. Harris
Canada, 2024, 9:00

Seven-year-old Angel arrives at ballet class, to discover she is the only Black girl in her lesson. She escapes to a dream world where Black ballerinas with bold, elaborate hairstyles dance around her.

03

TALLER THE HAT, CLOSER TO HEAVEN

James Pearson-Howes
UK, 2025, 9:07

Shot on Valentine's Day 2024, this film follows three friends as they get ready for a night out in LA. Set to the beat of Banda and Norteño, it is a celebration of friendship, romance and ritual.

04

MAIA. A MOTHER OF NATIONS

Sara Dos Santos
UK, 2025, 10:56

This dance film traces a woman's journey across oceans – carried by faith, resilience and hope. The elegant account of a single experience considers unexpected alliances and inherited fates.

05

UNSPUN FLESH, UNSPUN SHELL

Nailong Song
China, 2025, 4:46

This is a work about what has "not yet become." It explores the unsettling feeling of being perpetually in the middle: neither a beginning nor an end, but a suspended "ongoing" moment.

06

THE DANCING PLAGUE

Alex Leggatt
UK, 2026, 9:38

1518 AD. When a pregnant woman murders her husband, she has to flee to the woods, where she forms an unlikely connection with a band of outcasts who draw her into a frenzied forest dance ritual.

LANDSCAPES OF MEMORY
DANCE 3

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 3	YSJU	Friargate
10:00-11:00	15:30-16:30	20:30-21:30

PG

Across landscapes marked by conflict, absence and longing, this programme explores the body as a vessel for memory, resistance and transformation. These dance films move through abandoned spaces, fractured histories and imagined worlds where language fails, and movement ultimately becomes a way to confront the issues that remain unresolved.

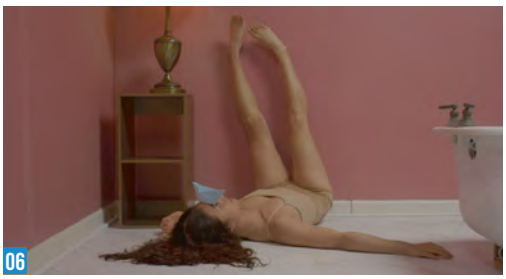
WAR_N_ING
Jia-jing Wu
Taiwan, 2026, 14:40
A man awakens in a decaying military village – a relic of Cold War ruins in Taiwan. Moving through the silent architecture towards the shoreline, his gestures trace an imagined path of conflict.

COMB
Rongfei Guo
China, 2026, 13:54
Backstage at a dance competition, 12-year-old Lotus observes mothers combing their daughters' hair. But her attempt to mimic them unravels into a physical confrontation her imagined mother.

LIMBES (NO DIALOGUE)
Karl Cannone
France, 2025, 5:32
Limbes unlocks a window into both the dreams and nightmares of a young man. Between paralysis and release, it reflects on our collective fears, shared traumas and the long path toward healing.

RIVER OF INK
Abe Abraham
USA, 2026, 17:25
A student is left on their own in an odd, abandoned classroom, drifting into a dreamscape where scattered, damaged books awaken memories of disemodied voices that are long vanished.

THE GIFT (NO DIALOGUE)
Mikki Sindhunata
Netherlands, 2025, 11:00
Alesya lives entirely alone and has made a ritual of spending her birthday in complete solitude. But this year, the day takes an unexpected turn when a mysterious box appears at her doorstep.



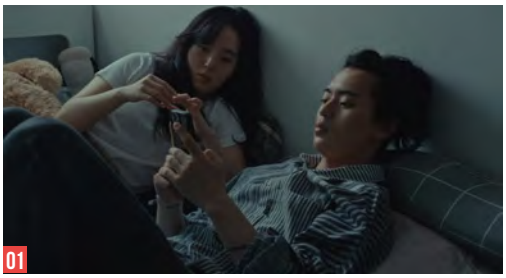
DAYS WITHOUT END
Chung-Wei Huang
USA, 2025, 8:00
Trapped in a surreal limbo, a dancer chases the paper boats that always drift just out of reach. Her journey transforms when she climbs into the bathtub and emerges in an enchanting blue room.

12

TRANSFORMATION (SUBTITLED)
DOCUMENTARY 1

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	FRIDAY
Cityy Screen 1	City Screen 2	City Screen 1
15:30-17:00	10:00-11:30	11:30-13:00

Transformation is always possible. *Han's Call* follows a South Korean student who yearns for rebirth via a fake funeral ceremony. *The Climb*, *Return to Water* and *Body to Heart* feature protagonists healing and re-building. *Tsingtao–Qingdao* sees a beer brand become embedded in national identity, whilst *Five Minute Brides* transforms the ordinary into the extraordinary.



01

HAN'S CALL (SUBTITLED)
Paul Van der Stegen
France, 2026, 29:55
In Seoul, Joon Woo, a young student, takes part in fake funerals to confront his past. *Han's Call* explores the unease of a Korean youth searching for meaning in a society obsessed with success.

02

THE CLIMB (SUBTITLED)
Raginie Duara
UK, 2026, 6:00
The Climb captures the journey of a woman through trauma, addiction and recovery. The short film holds one singular lived experience at its core, speaking to universal themes of healing.

03

TSINGTAO–QINGDAO (SUBTITLED)
Shu Lin
China, 2026, 9:49
Sourced from the archives of Tsingtao Beer in China, this film explores the construction of modern Chinese nationalism by retracing the localisation process of beer, a foreign product.

04

RETUN TO WATER (SUBTITLED)
Kate Malyon
UK, 2025, 5:10
A swimmer reflects on how water is a space for self-discovery. As the tides shift and the pool appears and disappears, so too does their gender identity – sometimes opaque, sometimes clear.

05

BODY TO HEART (SUBTITLED)
Jenny Barruol
UK, 2026, 21:57
In the village of Mazan in Southern France, known for the Gisèle Pélicot rape case, a farm provides free horse therapy to women rebuilding their lives following domestic and sexual violence.

06

FIVE MINUTE BRIDES (SUBTITLED)
Jacqueline Maxted
UK, 2025, 15:45
In a Skipton bridal shop, seamstress Mandy Abramson invites all women, of any age, shape or size, to come in and enjoy a wedding dress-up day of their own – twice a year, every year, at no charge.

A PART OF THIS PLACE
DOCUMENTARY 2

WEDNESDAY
Friargate
10:00-11:30

SATURDAY
City Screen 1
13:30-15:00

SUNDAY
City Screen 3
10:00-11:30

PG

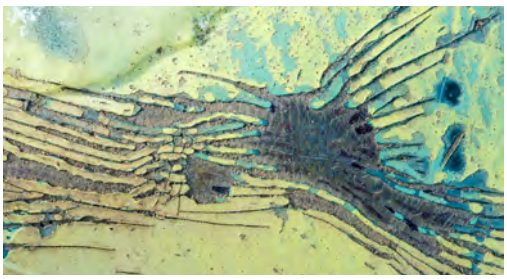
These films explore connections made between humans and their surroundings. Uncover a dialogue between ice and sea in *Glacier's Requiem*. Meet a shepherd who refuses to abandon his land in South Lebanon. The impact of colonialism on Indigenous communities is explored in *Marrparang*, whilst an artist returns to the same spot for 17 years in *The Art of Seeing*.

GLACIER'S REQUIEM
Saddiq Abubakar
UK, 2025, 20:44
In isolation on Iceland's Snæfellsnes Peninsula, Nigerian-born artist Colloboh transforms glacial and oceanic recordings into sonic compositions – uncovering a dialogue between ice and sea.

EVERY GRAIN OF DIRT
Aya Chouaib, Julie Mallat
Lebanon, 2026, 18:00
As mass evacuation orders force over a million people in South Lebanon from their homes, some choose to remain. Among them is Ismail, a shepherd who refuses to abandon his village.

PUSH THE MACHINE
Max Ward
Australia, France, UK, 2025, 14:15
A stuntman embarks on the most perilous, and illegal, project of his life. With the police hot on his trail, and an arduous mission to reach the takeoff, the jump itself is only half the challenge.

MARRPARANG
Tom Murray, Minitja Marawili
Australia, 2026, 21:00
Marrparang is a Yolngu Aboriginal word for the viviyfing feeling a person experiences in their Ancestral Country. As the community faces new and oppressive laws, it feels more important than ever.



THE ART OF SEEING
George Louis Tsougrianis
Canada, 2026, 21:35
For 17 years, one photographer has returned again and again to the vast prairie landscape, often to a single, unassuming subject that most people would pass without even a second glance.

15

STRENGTH IN THE COLLECTIVE
DOCUMENTARY 3

WEDNESDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY
Yorks. Museum	City Screen 1	YSJU
18:00-19:30	17:00-18:30	10:00-11:30

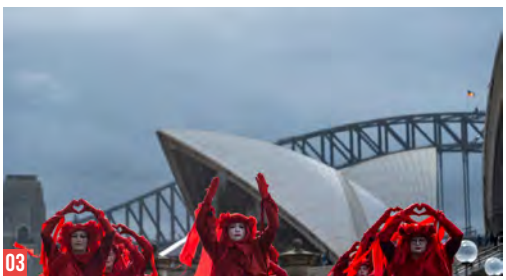
These films demonstrate that we are stronger together. Travel across the globe as we hear from an Indigenous community in Hawai'i, members of the DIY punk scene in Leeds and a group of residents in remote Alaska. Follow humanitarian aid from Bristol to Gaza, stop by an open house for the transgender community and reflect on the importance of protest.

01

AN AMBULANCE FOR GAZA
Parsifal Elviro Gomez
UK, 2026, 10:00
Sakir, an ordinary working-class man, travels across the world as an activist. This film features a journey in 2009, in an ambulance full of aid, beginning in Bristol and ending up on the Gaza Strip.

02

ROSE'S HOUSE
Naomi Abel-Hirsch
UK, 2026, 19:58
In 1979, Martine Rose bought a dilapidated terraced house in Sheffield and renovated it herself, creating one of the UK's first dedicated spaces for a community of trans people: Rose's House.

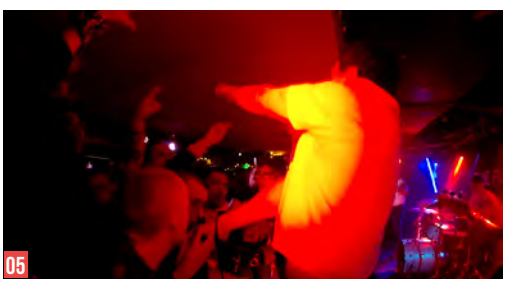


03

ACTS OF PROTEST
Zebedee Parkes
Australia, 2025, 7:42
Acts of Protest considers the huge emotional spectrum of protest amid ongoing global crises, offering a sensory experience that explores the contested right to dissent in today's turbulent world.

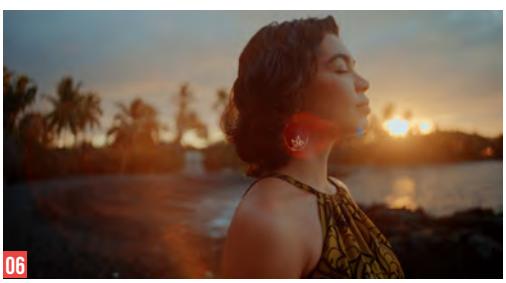
04

PRETTIER IN WHITTIER
Joe Kowalski
USA, 2026, 12:28
Nestled in a mountainous rainforest in Alaska is a town where nearly the entire population lives in one apartment building, bringing new meaning to getting along with your neighbour.



05

DON'T BOTHER WITH THE OUTSIDE WORLD
Elliott George
UK, 2026, 17:26
An experimental exploration of the self-made culture behind live hardcore music in Leeds. It's one of the most vibrant underground scenes across the entire country, led by iconic grassroots venues.



06

HO'OLONO (TO LISTEN DEEPLY)
Samantha Ramirez-Herrera
USA, 2026, 19:08
Ho'olono is an exploration of our enduring relationship to land and self, inviting audiences to remember that the path through ecological crisis may also prove to be a route back to ourselves.

FACING WHAT HURTS
DOCUMENTARY 4

THURSDAY City Screen 1 13:30-14:30
SATURDAY Yorks. Museum 19:00-20:00
SUNDAY City Screen 2 20:30-21:30

We don't mend by avoiding. Follow the protagonist of *Tamashi* as they embark on a journey of intergenerational healing, while *Town Called Needville* examines the non-linear process of recovery. A filmmaker meets his grandmother's murderer in *Correspondence*, plus a Vietnamese tattoo artist helps her clients to reclaim their bodies in *They Call Me the Tattoo Witch*.

TAMASHI
Ashima Shiraishi, Jess X. Snow
China, France, Japan, USA, 2026, 12:56
Ashima Shiraishi, a former child prodigy climber – alongside their butoh dancer father – take part in a ceremony of climbing and movement that offers healing for their relationship and the land.

A TOWN CALLED NEEDVILLE
Audrey Lane
Canada, USA, 2026, 5:37
Told through both 35mm photographs and first-person narration, this narrative follows the filmmaker's four-month inpatient stay at an all-women's mental health facility based in Needville in Texas.

MÕDOR
Natasha Audtin-Green
UK, 2025, 12:11
Society often paints a picture of motherhood as the pinnacle of a woman's life, but is this true? *MÕDOR* delves into the complexities, contradictions and the unspoken realities of maternal experience.

CORRESPONDENCE
Paul K. Oh
UK, 2026, 5:40
A filmmaker conducts an interview with the man convicted of murdering his grandmother. He tries to reconcile the person sitting across from him with the act that shattered his family.

THEY CALL ME THE TATTOO WITCH
Lindsay Nyman
USA, 2024, 14:17
In Hanoi, Vietnam, tattoo artist Tran Ngoc specialises in tattooing over scars. Ngoc empowers her clients, who include breast cancer survivors and women with self-harm scars, to reclaim their bodies.

15

FRAGMENTED MEMORY
DOCUMENTARY 5

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
Friargate	City Screen 2	YSJU
21:00-22:30	21:00-22:30	17:00-18:30

These short films explore the nature of memory. Delve into the complex ways that our past experiences form our outlook, from the forgotten story of an Afghan spaceman and the tragic truth behind the loss of an Irish matriarch. Gain access to the world of a man born without sight, uncover family archives and explore the heartache of time's passing in *Seasons*.

YAD (TO REMEMBER)
Aeyliya Husain
Canada, 2025, 14:38
This tender found footage project considers memory and identity. The film constructs a personal narrative of how the filmmaker's experiences have shaped both their life and creative trajectory.

FORGOTTEN SPACEMAN (SUBTITLED)
Elham Ehsas
Afghanistan, UK, 2026, 16:00
In 1988, Afghanistan sent its first and only astronaut, Abdul Ahad Momand, into space. From orbit, he called his mother, making Pashto the fourth language ever spoken beyond Earth.

CALL ME MAEVE
Jack O'Malley
Ireland, 2026, 6:23
This is a conversation between the director and his mother about a woman he never got the opportunity to meet – his grandmother, Maeve. Together, the two piece together a fragile family history.

THE VEIL OF SENSES
Elisa Baccolo
Italy, 2026, 19:06
Dante, a man born blind, has never seen the world. For him, there is no visual memory. His universe is made of sounds, textures, tastes and scents, a living fabric that reveals new ways of sensing.

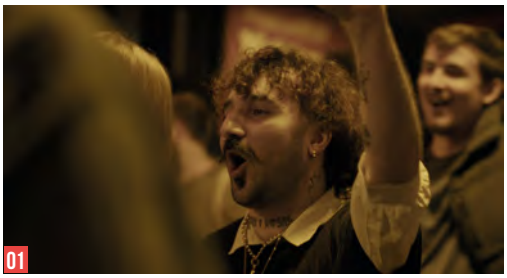
THIS IS THE HOUSE: IF I DON'T SEE YOU, I LOVE YOU
Claudia Owusu
USA, 2026, 14:50
A Ghanaian-American father and daughter duo work through their crowded basement, uncovering forgotten family archives and the fragments caused by immigration, divorce and loss.

SEASONS
Renee Nabinger
USA, 2026, 5:46
Shot on 16mm and VHS, *Seasons* is a love letter to the director's home in Vermont. The film drifts through fragmented memories of home, family as well as the quiet heartache of time passing.

IDENTITY
DOCUMENTARY 6

THURSDAY Friargate 19:00-20:30 | **FRIDAY** Yorks. Museum 20:30-22:00 | **SATURDAY** City Screen 2 19:00-20:30

This collection tackles the complex notion of identity. in it, one young man moves through pivotal moments of his private and political life. *Mother's Influence* explores a single mum's battle with ageing, whilst another tries to understand the new views of a radicalised friend, and three South Asian transgender women defiantly resist a society that tries to erase them.



EVEN YOU, COMRADE
Giorgio Dinello
Germany, 2025, 15:49
Batu, a young worker, second-generation migrant and member of a communist organisation navigates, with his comrades, the tense lead-up to Germany's snap elections in February 2025.

MOTHER'S INFLUENCE
Meg Wriggles
UK, 2025, 14:00
Meg grew up with an unconventional single mother, who works as an influencer navigating aging and body dysmorphia. Today, she admires her but questions how it shaped her own self-image.

DEEP PLATE (SUBTITLED)
Daria Pyshna
Ukraine, UK, 2026, 15:50
Built from audio interviews, *Deep Plate* weaves the voices of four Ukrainians who exist outside the expected image of Slavic people, into a portrait of identity shaped by language, memory, and place.

MY FRIEND, KEV
Colin Peppard
Ireland, 2026, 17:35
A filmmaker reconnects with an old friend, revealing the distance time can create. He questions how time, algorithms, loneliness and identity can shape a person in ways we can't always perceive.

BODY OF OUR OWN (SUBTITLED)
Rahemur Rahman, Lily Vetch
UK, 2026, 25:00
Amidst the vibrant chaos of South Asia, this narrative follows three Hijra – Momo, Neshi and Jannat – as they navigate freedom and self-expression in a world that seeks to erase transgender women.

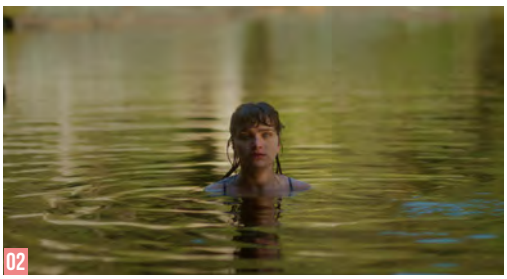
18

THE RECKONING
DRAMA 1

THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY
Friargate	Friargate	City Screen 1
21:00-22:30	15:00-16:30	10:00-11:30

The past doesn't ask permission to return. It arrives mid-celebration, wearing the face of a childhood friend. It waits in a forest's shadow, in a lover's camera roll, behind a door that should have stayed shut, on a golden day in Italy. Unflinching but never sensational, these films navigate desire, memory and power – and follow their characters to moments of truth.

CLAONADH
Ciara Ní É
Ireland, 2025, 13:00
Ireland, 1920. Inside a house where Irish maids are not allowed to speak their own language, Peigí has desires that turn to obsession. She is discovered in a bedroom which she really shouldn't be in.



XY (SUBTITLED)
Alice Gadbled
Belgium, 2025, 19:10
In the middle of a scorching summer, 25-year-old X returns to her home village to celebrate her mother's birthday. Y joins her for a walk. Secrets that are about to catch up with them lie in the forest.

CELESTE & THE CYAN SUN
Claire Jamison
USA, 2026, 16:46
On her last day in Italy, a young woman finds herself being swept away by a new intimate friendship. This connection sees her be catapulted towards reckless abandon and tragic circumstances.

SOUVENIR
Renée Marie Petropoulos
Australia, 2025, 14:33
Whilst stuck on a long family vacation, Keira, a young closeted teenager, must confront the unnerving hold her girlfriend has over her after she takes unwarranted photos of her during sex.

THE LOBSTER (SUBTITLED)
Maïa Descamps
Belgium, 2025, 26:23
During a bachelor party, Sami runs into a childhood friend who accuses him of abuse. Throughout the weekend, he navigates his own, sometimes misguided, conscience, searching for the truth.

THIN ICE
DRAMA 2

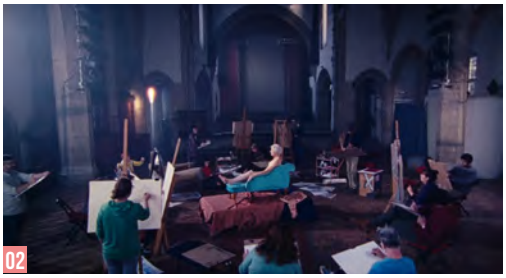
WEDNESDAY
City Screen 2
19:00-20:30

FRIDAY
City Screen 1
15:00-16:30

SATURDAY
YTR Studio
17:00-18:30

Life rarely pans out the way we plan. In this collection, a partner commits the cruellest betrayal, a fairy-tale romance can't survive reality, something new blooms among the pear trees but quickly rots and an AI confidant should never have heard those secrets. Yet, in the wreckage – fighting the cold, or bare before a life class – some discover what they're truly made of.

LOSS OF ALTITUDE (SUBTITLED)
Hoàng Quỳnh Nguyen
Germany, 2025, 11:45
This is a story about a relationship. But it also tackles guilt, silent complicity and how love and betrayal can both exist in the same breath. It is about what happens when silence becomes political.

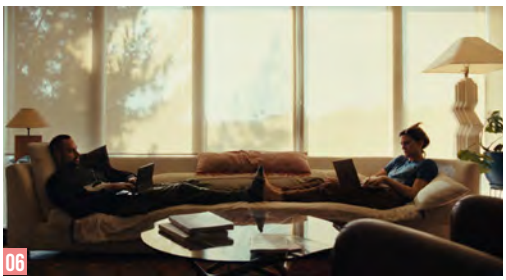


EMBODIED
Chanelle Eidenbenz
UK, 2025, 11:00
Refusing to submit to being "an overlooked old woman," Tona bares all to the gazing eyes of a life drawing class – reclaiming the way she is seen both by others, and herself, in the process.

TO BUILD A FIRE
Lorenzo Puntoni
Italy, 2026, 20:03
An experienced explorer and his dog cross a cold mountain pass, confronting extreme conditions. When the ice breaks underneath his feet, building a fire becomes the only chance of their survival.

FOLDS (SUBTITLED)
Katya Skakun
USA, 2025, 15:00
In Suzdal, a town pulled right out of a fairy tale, Asya – a manual therapist crippled by impostor syndrome – meets Misha, a local guide. When uninvited guests arrive, Asya must trust in her craft.

PECKERHEAD (SUBTITLED)
Ante Pask
Belgium, 2024, 24:07
Peckerhead follows a group of friends with car trouble, who end up spending the weekend in a farmhouse. Oskar meets Justine, and something beautiful begins to blossom under the pear trees.



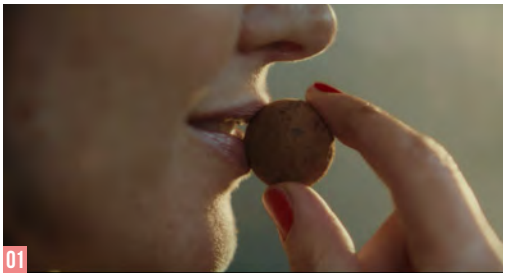
USELESS
Ariel Heller
USA, 2025, 9:48
A man, who is struggling to find employment, starts using an AI therapist. He soon faces humiliating consequences, as it exposes his inner thoughts and failings as a partner to his successful wife.

15

THE ANIMALISTIC
DRAMA 3

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
YTR Studio	City Screen 1	YSJU
18:00-19:30	21:00-22:30	10:00-11:30

These films have a feel of the wild side to them. Each story touches on what we need to escape and release. From the creature of the night to the rampant duvet, these are stories of how forces beyond our control often lead us to catharsis. *Roastin* is about control, *Lone* jumps into the unknown, whilst *The Pigeon* explores what it means to hold on and let go.



01

THE EMANCIPATION OF MEGAN OR HOW TO EAT A CHOCOLATE BON BON
Chi Thai
UK, 2025, 14:59
A pregnant 40-something woman takes revenge against the man who abused her as her child. Far from bleak, this is an irreverent, unapologetic drama – delivering "a sugar rush and a gut punch."

02

DUVET
Bel Parker
UK, 2025, 14:00
Duvet is a short horror film about a woman who is trying to leave a coercive relationship. The film combines puppetry techniques with stark visuals to build a tense and suffocating atmosphere.

03

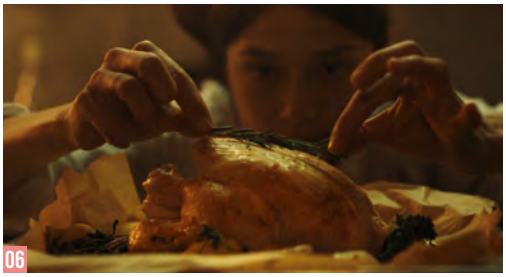
LONE
Emma-Jane Heaton
UK, 2026, 20:51
In this folk horror-meets-drama, a man wishes he never escaped the city for the weekend when he encounters a beast in the dark. The big question is: will he get away, or will he embrace the wild?

04

MEATMYLK
Lucy Luscombe
UK, 2026, 15:00
An insecure personal trainer spirals out of control when a fitness influencer joins his gym. Desperate to compete, he decides to max out his gains with a promising new protein shake: MEATMYLK.

05

THE PIGEON
Chloe Culpin
UK, 2025, 11:36
A bereaved young woman believes that her late sister has been reincarnated – as a pigeon. This film follows as she bonds with the bird, learning about grief and coping mechanisms along the way.



06

ROASTIN
Sue bynn Bae
UK, 2025, 17:33
In London, Dakota, a sous-chef drowning in self-doubt, confronts her deepest fears when a bizarre, headless talking chicken shows up in the empty restaurant. A narrative about reclaiming control.

WHO AM I? (SUBTITLED)
DRAMA 4

THURSDAY Friargate 17:00-18:30
FRIDAY Friargate 20:30-22:00
SUNDAY YSJU 15:00-16:30

12

Self-discovery is a great subject for a short film. Here we present six special works that chart young characters as they decide who they are, or will be – whether that be through music, work, social media, or each other. Yet, these stories also show what it's like when that opportunity is taken away. A poignant collection about coming-of-age in different circumstances.

01

CLOSE YOUR EYES HIND (SUBTITLED)
Amir Zaza
Netherlands, 2025, 30:00
Amid the war in Gaza, six-year-old Hind Rajab and her family are desperately trying to escape to a place of safety. To momentarily forget the danger, they begin to dance in the car to loud music.

02

THE GIRL IS TAKEN BY ALIENS (SUBTITLED)
Mu Wang
Germany, 2026, 19:15
"Don't go out on the night of the Ghost Festival!" is a warning that children with Chinese mothers are all too familiar with. 18-year-old Ming feels like the only weirdo in her small German town.

03

NOWT (SUBTITLED)
Milda Baginskaitė
UK, 2026, 13:35
On a Huddersfield estate, a rebellious teenager, Bailey, falls dangerously in love with an older boy. The encounter leads her down a troubling path that could change her life forever.

04

GODDESS OF WEALTH (SUBTITLED)
Aashna Singh
India, 2025, 9:35
Based in a small town in India during Diwali, *Goddess Of Wealth* follows a day in the life of a child influencer, whose parents have unintentionally traded her innocence for social media attention.

05

I PROMISE (SUBTITLED)
Sara Louise Engeli
Norway, 2025, 8:00
Stella is worried for her friend Maja. Both of them are having a hard time with their parents at home. After Stella suggests that Maja should speak up at school, their friendship is put at stake.

06

FATHERS & DAUGHTERS (SUBTITLED)
Luke Alexander
UK, 2026, 15:15
In a swimming pool in Bangor, Northern Ireland, lifeguard Orla Murphy spends her days daydreaming, dealing with negligent parents and gossiping with friends whilst avoiding her manager.

15

CHANGES
DRAMA 5

WEDNESDAY
City Screen 1
21:00-22:30

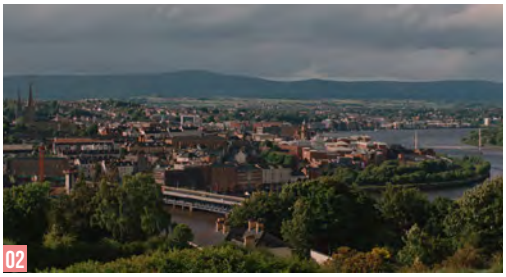
SATURDAY
Friargate
10:00-11:30

SUNDAY
City Screen 1
10:00-11:30

Every one of these shorts features a lead character who undergoes a massive internal shift. These changes could be sparked by anything: music, moving house, an accident, coming out, even an organ transplant. Sometimes the thirst to figure it all out finds people desperate, and they'll stop at nothing to uncover their destiny. Other times, the change is much more subtle.

01

BROADCAST
Ewan Pollitt
UK, 2025, 8:00
Amidst a housing crisis in a near-future London, one struggling young woman pursues a controversial deal. *Broadcast* asks: what happens when privacy becomes a currency we're asked to spend?



02

PULSE
Sam Nutt
Ireland, UK, 2025, 15:40
After a heart transplant, Heather returns to her quiet life in rural Northern Ireland. But something lingers: a melody that she can't place, words from a community that has long felt foreign to her.

03

AS IT SHOULD BE
Edwin Lai
Hong Kong, 2026, 11:58
During a Lunar New Year reunion dinner in Hong Kong, Megan returns home from overseas to celebrate with her family. A film about love, and how acceptance arrives in the gentlest of ways.

04

SOPHIE
Logan Graham Greene
Canada, 2025, 20:00
Isolated and recovering from a severe injury, Sophie finds herself haunted by a mysterious phenomenon as she's hurtled toward a devastating realisation. A story about how grief can distort reality.

05

F MINOR
Josh Litman
USA, 2025, 14:59
A struggling musician is plagued by feelings of insecurity after he discovers he wasn't a target of his music teacher's predatory behaviour. *F Minor* navigates the effects of unresolved trauma.

06

THE STORIES WE TELL OURSELVES
Kasandra Baruch
USA, 2025, 19:58
Liv is a quirky introvert who once thrived in the spotlight, until she allowed the great expectations of the world to swallow her up. Can she gain the strength to step back into the public eye?

BEING HUMAN
DRAMA 6

WEDNESDAY Yorks. Museum 16:30-17:30
FRIDAY City Screen 1 10:00-11:00
SATURDAY City Screen 3 11:45-12:45

The way we connect with ourselves or with other people can occasionally be mystifying – and we don't really know why we do what we do. Why punish ourselves or get drawn into others' lives, when we know they are dangerous? One thing is clear about these shorts: they all deal with human connection and understanding. And some have twists you would not expect.

SLAP!! (SUBTITLED)
Mikolaj Piszczan
Poland, 2025, 22:12
In a desperate search for acceptance, a troubled man is taking part in brutal slap fighting competitions. He crosses more and more dangerous boundaries, disregarding the consequences.

SHUSH, NOW
Craig Austin Reynolds
Ireland, 2025, 11:45
Shush, Now is a short and simple story that follows Kara, a seven-year-old girl who discovers her mother's secret. It's a realisation that forces her to consider the realities of adulthood all too soon.

BLUE HOUR
Kate Graham
UK, 2026, 13:13
This intimate coming-of-age film is set on the final day before university, when 18-year-old Bea spends a summer afternoon drifting across the Yorkshire countryside with her three friends.

GREETINGS FROM SUMATRA
KAROLINA FRONIK, MARTA KOWALSKA
Poland, 2025, 13:00
Aga is a popular journalist who travels the world in order to report on international conflicts. That is, until a secret comes out that will change everything. The events make her think: is her work ethical?

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15

IN THE NEAR FUTURE
DRAMA 7

WEDNESDAY
City Screen 3
11:45-12:45

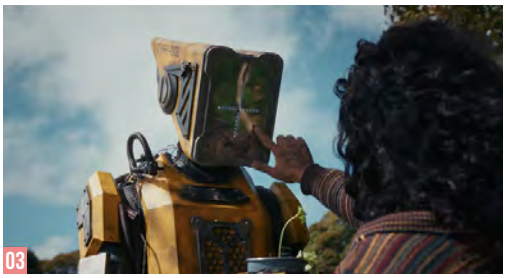
SATURDAY
YSJU
20:30-21:30

SUNDAY
City Screen 1
13:30-14:30

Fiction is always looking to the future. We are long past the date that *Terminator*'s Skynet AI became aware and are living in the very same year that Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* plays out. AI is a huge concern for many: not just job losses and ecological impact, but the uncertainty over its use and regulation. We are living in the future and our anxiety is reaching fever pitch.

SAFARI
Jack Holden
UK, 2025, 13:30
A new drug called 'Safari' allows the taker to flip their sexual preference for a few hours. When Josh meets Oscar, the pair immediately lock eyes and decide to spend the night together.

DROPS FROM THE SKY
Marcus Anthony Thomas
UK, 2026, 9:00
In the immediate future, where alien abductions are regular and global war has begun, a nomadic group of people follows the vision of a young woman who claims to have seen their salvation.



MOLLY & THE ROBOT
Táine King
Ireland, 2025, 15:00
This short film is set in a post-apocalyptic Ireland devastated by war and machine domination. *Molly and the Robot* follows a lone woman surviving on the last unspoiled land in the country.

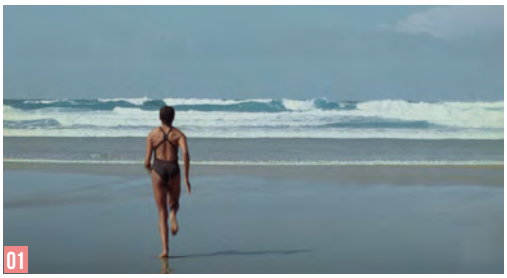
EYES WIDE
Elliot Bloom
UK, 2026, 6:30
Eden is twenty-five, working from home, behind on her deadlines, ahead on her shopping. Outside her flat, something is happening: protests, sirens, voices, a city in revolt. She chooses to scroll past.

FISH THE MOON
Maddie Dai
New Zealand, UK, 9:30
Fish The Moon follows a writer who begins getting calls from a government-appointed censor: a woman called Jasmine. As he attempts to write, she now has front row seats to his every move.

WE, TOGETHER
DRAMA 8

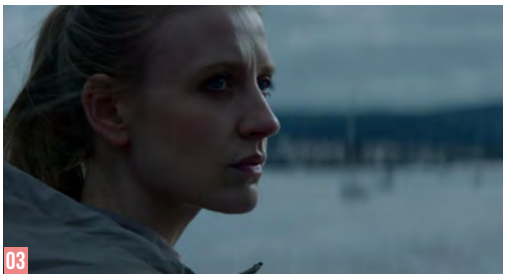
WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
YTR Main House	City Screen 2	YSJU
15:00-16:30	13:30-14:30	15:30-16:30

The definition of "family" is always changing, just as our own relatives evolve around us year-on-year. We choose, we move, we extend, we grow, we break and we sever. Beginning with a couple hoping to conceive and ending with a multi-generational connection through care, these films explore family through processes of joining, losing, combining and connecting.



JELLYFISH
Jesse May Fisher
UK, 2026, 8:57
A short film following a woman who is consumed by fantasies of impregnating her girlfriend through her own touch alone. Could jellyfish hold the power to make feminine conception a reality?

MARRIAGE TEST
Sara Nourizadeh
UK, 2025, 11:00
In 1980s South Wales, a young Welsh woman and her Iranian fiancé sit side-by-side. They are moments away from a decision that will determine whether they can start their life together.



THE TIDE
Anne-Marie Scragg
UK, 2026, 12:00
A mother battles with the family court system to save herself and her son from his abusive father. *The Tide* draws from research to explore complex trauma, motherhood and the fight for freedom.

GUMBALL
James Murray
UK, 2026, 4:00
Whilst spending a day at the seaside, a father attempts to build the beginnings of a new relationship with his son. This story is inspired by real events, as witnessed in Margate last summer.

STILL LIFE
Sophie King
UK, 2026, 10:54
A darkly comic, deeply personal short which explores life in the aftermath of stillbirth. It follows Jess and Max, who navigate grief, unexpected forms of parenthood and the quiet absurdities of loss.

SEE YOU TOMORROW, TOMORROW, TOMORROW
Desdemona Chiang
USA, 2025, 14:00
An aspiring, up-and-coming stand-up comedian delays her own career aspirations in order to do greater work: caring for her elderly 99-year-old grandmother during her final years.

15

WITHIN
DRAMA 9

WEDNESDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 1	YTR Studio	City Screen 2
13:30-15:00	20:30-22:00	15:00-16:30

These films subtly pushes and pulls those within them. The characters find themselves exposed, unable to keep undercover, or finally able to break free and be seen. With considerations around shortfalls in care, and increasing levels of hostility towards those with protected characteristics, these films highlight how we may opt to hide or choose to confront injustice.

CLOSEDOWN
Michael Spicer
UK, 2025, 17:24
As his mother's memories slip away, a man goes to extraordinary lengths to preserve their relationship, whilst navigating the fragile terrain of a new romance. *Closedown* is Spicer's directorial debut.

THE ACRES
Alice Johannessen
UK, 2026, 16:31
Christine enters The Acres estate with gardening tools and a plan. But then she encounters Ama, a lonely young mum who reminds her of the very early days of motherhood – a much simpler time.

BEYOND SILENCE (SUBTITLED)
Marine Blok
Netherlands, 2024, 16:51
Two women, two generations, one shared trauma. One has stayed silent for over 30 years, the other "only" 18 months. Where one retreats further into silence, the other finds the courage to break it.

SIGNAL
Zak Jarvis
UK, 2026, 13:00
Signal stars Christopher Eccleston as Ray, a railway signalman whose routine night shift turns into a tense race to save a life after spotting Billy, a distressed young man trespassing on the tracks.

ECHOES
Alex Lanipekun
UK, 2026, 17:43
When a successful businessman unexpectedly reunites with his homeless childhood friend, buried secrets from their boarding school days force him to confront the trauma he's tried to forget.

PETER
Hannah Van Der Westhuysen
UK, 2026, 11:07
A trans man caring for his father with alcohol-induced dementia finds unexpected re-connection when the disease grants him with temporary anonymity. A story about dignity and vulnerability.

AFTER THE THUNDER
DRAMA 10

FRIDAY
YTR Main House
14:30-15:30

SATURDAY
City Screen 1
15:30-16:30

SUNDAY
Yorks. Museum
15:00-16:00

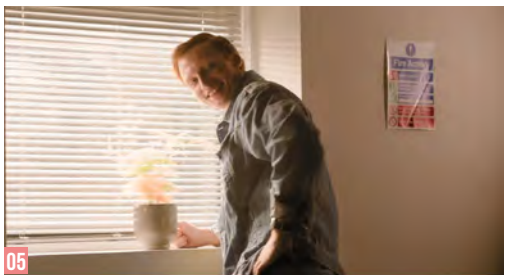
Life can be a constant battle: with ourselves, against the outside world. We may be overcome, even break. Each of these storeis looks at ways of seeking or findinf closure from stress fractures and losses. They also deal with the fallout of grief in a personal way. With the world full of pressing global issues, sometimes individuals need to be heard amongst the noise.

TONY SPITERI
Daniel Rands
UK, 2026, 3:30
A one-on-one game of basketball develops into a fragile, volatile confrontation between two men struggling to process loss. This is a story of blame, reconciliation and the emotive power of sports.

MAYFLIES
Lydia McNulty
UK, 2026, 16:13
Six months after graduating, oddball Cath takes a trip to the countryside to scatter their pet rabbit's ashes with former best friend Willow. Over one weekend, unexpected feelings awaken.

JOONÈ DELAM
Shadi Soheili
Australia, 2025, 14:15
In a bid for closure, a young woman is compelled to confront her estranged father on his deathbed. A semi-autobiographical film that hopes to raise awareness of the effects of childhood trauma.

SUNNY OAKS
Max Davies
UK, 2025, 11:00
An Irish dark comedy – fragile, surreal and strangely funny – that tells the story of a son visiting his elderly mother in a care home, where he is confronted with an unthinkable dilemma.



BEING BILLY
Ian Puleston-Davies
UK, 2026, 12:39
William Livesey is a Falklands veteran who has dementia. A brief connection with new carer Lisa stirs memories, taking him back to the closing stages of the war in 1982 and a life changing incident.

THE EASY WAY OUT
Ben Bovington-Key
UK, 2026, 13:50
The Easy Way Out is about those who leave us and those who are left behind. Ted discovers his big brother, Jim, in the middle of an attempt on his own life. Now, there is nothing left to do but talk.

12

BETWEEN TWO WORLDS (SUBTITLED)
DRAMA 11

THURSDAY
City Screen 1
15:00-16:30

FRIDAY
City Screen 2
11:30-13:00

SUNDAY
Friargate
17:00-18:30

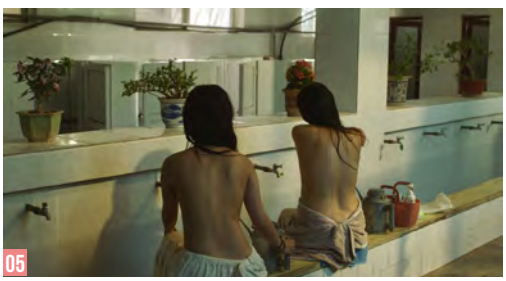
We are constantly in transition. This selection of films explores the spaces inbetween: the past and the present, the rational and irrational mind, who we are now and the people we hope to become in future. These stories take audiences on complex journeys through characters' inner conflicts, that relate to identity, spirituality, relationships, growing up and mental health.

JUST A THOUGHT (SUBTITLED)
Hendrik Ehlers
Germany, 2026, 23:48
Klara is troubled by intrusive mental images triggered by OCD. During a date, she sees herself stabbing her girlfriend. As the pair grow closer, Klara worries she might secretly be a terrible person.

IN DREAMING (SUBTITLED)
Kristina Pringle
UK, 2026, 6:23
Ryan is destined to dance, but has to put his passion aside to tend to his duties at his family's nail salon. However, that doesn't thwart his wild imagination. This film is a love letter to queer Asian youth.

BETWEEN DAY AND DAWN (SUBTITLED)
Lore Loyens
Belgium, Netherlands, 2025, 14:47
Summer feels endless as Marthe travels through the Ardennes with her friends in the late 1990s. As they laugh, drink and drift through the days, her thoughts stay with her sick sister at home.

TRANCE (SUBTITLED)
Jona Schloßer
Germany, 2026, 20:00
Exhausted, 28-year-old Yasmin struggles through her shift as a paramedic. She fights her way through the day, juggling critical emergency calls and the pressure of supporting her own family.



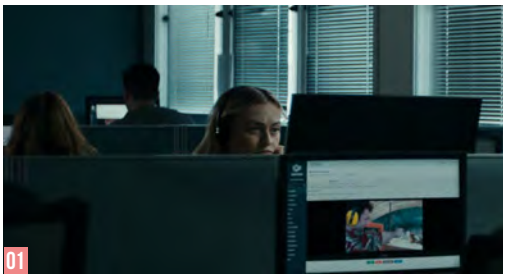
JUMAH (SUBTITLED)
LIU QING LIN, YE HAN LING
China, 2025, 16:14
Xingyue was born into a devout Muslim family in a Chinese city, where both her mother and grandmother are practicing believers. Now nineteen, she feels increasingly different to her peer group.

LITTLE BUG (SUBTITLED)
Matt Branston
UK, 2025, 9:00
In 1957, the Soviet Union sends a dog into space. The night before, a scientist (Martin Freeman) takes her home to meet his daughter (Alexandra Barredo), and hopefully help repair their relationship.

NOT WHOLE, BUT IN PART
DRAMA 12

THURSDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 1	City Screen 2	Friargate
10:00-11:30	17:00-18:30	10:00-11:30

As Toni Morrison said: "sometimes, you don't survive whole, you just survive in part. But the grandeur of life is that attempt." This collection of shorts navigates the various intentional, unintentional and at times unconventional methods of coping under impossible circumstances. It is an exploration of the life that can exist at the other side of immense personal effort.



01

MODERATION
Benedict Cohen
UK, 2026, 13:27
To cope with the gruesome realities of their job role, two content moderators start having sex at work. But they must battle with a new-found addiction to trauma bonding, lest it consume them.

02

THAT WHICH FEEDS ME (SUBTITLED)
Olga Navalón, Bea Hohenleiter
Spain, 2026, 14:26
When Lourdes' mother dies, a deafening silence settles over her home. The family avoids mourning, whilst Lourdes' friends keep her company via external validation: leisure, parties and alcohol.

03

POUR ME
Jesse Lewis-Reece
UK, 2026, 12:30
Oliver's not drinking at the moment. Taking place entirely within a traditional British pub, *Pour Me* is a short portrait of a man who is quietly wrestling against feelings of shame, grief and self-pity.

04

CHICKEN JAZZ (SUBTITLED)
Imanol Ruiz De Lara
Spain, 2025, 21:00
Teo is a former trumpet player who works at the chicken shop left to him by his father. His life goes by monotonously, a far cry from his old dreams, until Andrea, his ex, shows up with his old trumpet.

05

AUNTY JI
Milli Bhatia
UK, 2026, :25
On her daughter's birthday, Kulsoom finally leaves her flat. Cut off from the world, a series of simple errands spirals into a tense everyday odyssey that shakes her as she struggles to get home.

06

WHITE (SUBTITLED)
Navroz Shaban
Iraq, 2026, 12:11
In a village classroom, a teacher transforms the blackboard with a white sheet. When it is taken for a burial rite, the children refuse to let the moment slip – and set to reclaim what they were promised.

12

SHIFTING PERSPECTIVE
DRAMA 13

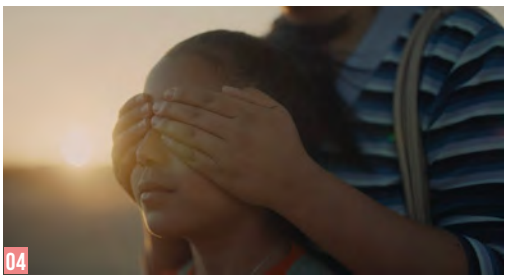
FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 2	Yorks. Museum	City Screen 1
17:00-18:30	17:00-18:30	17:00-18:30

What is the turning point between preserving tradition and embracing change? Here is a selection of films that showcase the rich yet complex intergenerational dynamic. Confronting gender roles, domesticity, identity and parenting, these works encourage us to step back and ask: how do we navigate a society where community feels more distant than ever before?

SMOOTH SUMMER (SUBTITLED)
Amanda Sandberg Fætten
Norway, 2026, 13:09
As Hanna and her ten-year-old niece, Erle, get ready for a day out at the beach, Hanna finds herself faced with a dilemma: how can she manage to be both a cool aunt as well as a good role model?

THE APPLE DOESN'T FALL (SUBTITLED)
Dean Wei
China, 2025, 18:00
A portrait of an ordinary "one child" Chinese family living in their ordinary apartment. Over the course of five nights, the events in their lives range from the unremarkable to the downright banal.

WOMAN LAND
Yasmin Yassin
USA, 2025, 10:29
This coming-of-age story follows two young Somali sisters living in Minneapolis, who balance rebellion with reputation when their matchmaking business attracts a client a little too close to home.



A WHOLE LIFE (SUBTITLED)
Camila Pineda
Spain, 2026, 14:53
Sabrina, an eight-year-old Colombian girl, arrives in Barcelona with her mother after a sudden move that she cannot understand. They live in a single room space that does not feel like their own.

GULALA (SUBTITLED)
Kardo Shiwan
Finland, 2026, 7:51
A son creates new memories with his mother by making home videos. During a day spent together, they reminisce on shared experiences. *Gulala* is a celebration of family, love and food.

ALPA (SUBTITLED)
Dhiwangkara Seta
Indonesia, 2026, 16:00
Banyu, a punk vocalist, is sent to a moral rehabilitation centre after his arrest. He fights against the system, only to realise that true freedom lies within the last person on Earth he wants to see.

TOGETHER, APART
DRAMA 14

WEDNESDAY
Friargate
13:30-15:00

SATURDAY
Friargate
20:30-22:00

SUNDAY
YSJU
10:00-11:30

PG

From uncomfortable family reunions to blossoming relationships between unlikely friends, these projects are dedicated to human beings: how we come together and fall apart. It navigates office buildings, hairdressers, childhood homes and care facilities, connecting the dots between people and prompting us to think about those we cherish within our personal lives.

BESHERT
Lewis Rose
UK, 2025, 19:57
A poignant, tender drama about a "grumpy old man" living in a Leeds care home, and a reluctant Barmitzvah boy. It charts an unlikely friendship that changes both of their lives forever.

NOSTALJIA (SUBTITLED)
Pierre Audouin
France, 2025, 19:00
Back in his childhood home, Michaël confronts old grudges within a family he never truly left. Between laughter, tension and memories, nostalgia becomes both refuge and burden.

SISTER OF MINE (SUBTITLED)
André Vaara
Sweden, 2026, 12:24
Ten-year-old Noel wants to be more like his older sister. A visit to the hairdresser sparks jealousy, bringing sibling rivalries to the surface and pushing beyond the norms of 2000s boyhood.

THE DEPARTMENT OF THEY
Lisa Kenney
UK, 2026, 15:45
The Department of They tells of a delicate romance between two women... and a snail. Repressed feelings disrupt their absurdist workplace as they must make a choice between head and heart.

ALONE
Shian Denovan
UK, 2025, 12:02
A woman's daily commute is thrown into chaos when she finds the city inexplicably abandoned. *Alone* is a haunting psychological thriller exploring timely themes of loneliness and disconnection.

15

FAULT LINES
DRAMA 15

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
City Screen 1	YTR Studio	City Screen 1
10:00-11:30	19:00-20:30	21:00-22:30

Six films exploring the unexpected disruptions that can alter the course of everyday life. Each introduces an event or circumstance that shifts the protagonist's trajectory, from a noise heard through the ceiling to a chance interaction in the park. Together, they consider how easily the familiar can be disrupted, and how small moments can send life in a new direction.

TO RUN IS TO RETURN
Precious Wura Alabi
UK, 2026, 14:54
A young Black British man drives his car through a busy London landscape as his music blares. He is willing it to be a good day. But, as he approaches his destination, the cracks begin to show.

NOISE & NEIGHBOURS
Liza Ludick
South Africa, 2024, 21:07
Noise & Neighbours is the story of a bored little girl, and a man who has given up. They become friends who never meet, but are always there for each other throughout life's ups and downs.

HELPING HAND (SUBTITLED)
William Simmons
Czechia, 2025, 11:17
Anna hears concerning sounds in the flat above her, which ignites an unexpected coming together with an inconceivable outcome. A film about what it means to share a building with other people.

MAMA
Santiago Ponce de León
UK, 2026, 14:55
Captured through the lens of a car's backup camera, a grieving immigrant mother is forced into a night of crime. After receiving a frantic call from her son in prison, motherly love is put to the test.

REBORNING
Alanna MacNamee
Ireland, 2025, 13:54
In a small Irish town, two women cross paths in the park, each of them pushing a pram. Across a single day, and through intercut flashbacks, their guarded chat softens into something revealing.

TURTLENECK
Laurie Fahy
UK, 2026, 9:59
It's an ordinary autumnal Saturday. Somewhere between date four and five, Laura and Gus trade jokes and half-insults with a familiar rhythm. But they're circling the topic that matters most.

CLOSE TO HOME (SUBTITLED)
DRAMA 16

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 1	Yorks. Museum	YSJU
21:00-22:30	13:30-15:00	17:00-18:30

Ecological crisis. The rise of right-wing politics. Accessibility in universities. These five stories explore socio-political issues through the lens of the everyday, from local canvassing in *Vote Gavin Lyle* to the relationship between a biology student and an Deaf eco-activist in *Green Grass*. Together, they demonstrate the power of shorts to bring complex issues into focus.

DEGREE OF CERTAINTY (SUBTITLED)
Simon Schneider
USA, 2025, 16:38
50 years ago, the biggest oil companies in the USA discovered the existence of the climate crisis – and then decided to deny it. It was a decision that created the reality with which we are dealing today.

VOTE GAVIN LYLE (SUBTITLED)
Aneil Karia
UK, 2026, 16:48
Jack Lowden stars in *Vote Gavin Lyle*, a disquieting portrait of a typical middle-England family man and aspiring right-wing parliamentary candidate, relayed through intimate vignettes.

GERONTO (SUBTITLED)
Mark Pluck
UK, 2026, 18:41
Geronto is a short LGBTQ+ coming-of-age drama about longing, connection and self-discovery. Set over one night during the late 2000s, it follows Younger, in his 20s, who meets Older, in his 60s.

GREEN GRASS (SUBTITLED)
Aram Atkinson
UK, 2026, 16:45
Declan is a disengaged biology student who cares more about drawing than his degree. Now in his second year, where grades count, even his closest friends don't want to partner with him.

HOW TO WASH A BODY, HOW TO CLEANSE A SOUL (SUBTITLED)
Luke Bather
UK, 2025, 19:47
The first time Jack ever sees his biological father, Richard, is only two hours before his funeral. He's been asked to wash and dress his lifeless body – which, all of a sudden, starts talking to him.

15

UNDER PRESSURE

DRAMA 17

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	FRIDAY
City Screen 2	City Screen 3	Friargate
15:30-17:00	10:00-11:30	11:30-13:00

From a mother confronting grief in the privacy of her bathroom, to a woman risking everything for one dinner, this selection of shorts finds ordinary people pushed to extraordinary lengths. Whether it's the suffocation of isolation, financial precarity or the fragile structures we build to survive, each film asks the same question: what do we do when the walls close in?

01

CONTROL LINE

Kofi A. Ntiforo
UK, 2026, 14:15

Control Line is an intimate portrait of motherhood, seen through the eyes of a Black woman inside a private space: her bathroom. Here, Ida confronts the weight of grief, responsibility and hope.

02

THE GALLEY

Thomas Bennett
Ireland, 2026, 13:45

After being made redundant, Helen commits a victimless crime to pay for dinner. *The Galley* is a short drama starring Tony award winner Bríd Brennan and IFTA 2026 nominee Seán T. Ó Meallaigh.

03

THE PAINTING & THE STATUE

Freddie Fox
UK, 2025, 20:00

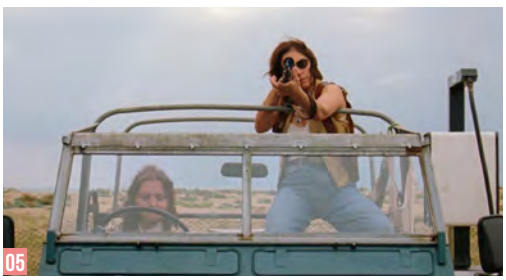
Two lonely strangers meet across a crowded room. All it takes is one held look, one breathless moment, to literally bring them to life. A film about patience, yearning and the value of artwork.

04

BIRDHOUSE

Moritz Valero
UK, 2025, 13:44

Lewis, a young, dishevelled, unsuspecting man finds himself in a cacophony of trouble, as a local gang leader, Frankie takes advantage of his need for connection and sets up shop in his flat.



05

GOBSTOPPER

Pippa Lore Feldberg Collins
UK, 2026, 14:26

When a neighbour shows a prurient interest in twelve year-old Kit (Mia McKenna-Bruce), her agoraphobic mother Rayna (Annabel Scholey) puts aside her fears and bundles them into a Land Rover.

06

A WOMAN OF GOOD ABILITIES

Mark Chapman
UK, 2026, 15:30

Rachel works the night shift, out of sync with daily life. When she is suspected of stealing from a delivery driver, it creates a fracture in the fragile social support structure she has created.

ARCHITECTURAL HISTORIES
EXPERIMENTAL 1

FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
Friargate	YSJU	YSJU
17:00-18:30	20:30-22:00	10:00-11:30

From inner cities to rural coastlines; wooden structures to porcelain figures; quiet churches to busy highways, human history is irreversibly imprinted onto the Earth. It's true in the societies we have built and the enormous impact we have had on the natural world. This collection explores war, spirituality and environment all through the lens of our architectural impact.

CONCRETE MOVES (SUBTITLED
Fagamou Fama Ndiaye
Senegal, 2025, 12:00
Inspired by a childhood memory of encountering a snake during a trip to a lighthouse in Dakar. Returning to that same hill decades later, the coastline is transformed by relentless urban expansion.

A WALK IN PORCELAIN (NO DIALOGUE)
Veronica Gonzalez Vanek
France, 2026, 18:07
A poetic and sonic wandering through the very heart of Breton heritage, where the fragility of porcelain meets the memory of stone, inviting reflection on history, craftsmanship and place.

FOR SHARON (NO DIALOGUE)
Mohamed Mussa
2026, UK, 13:47
In a space that is suspended between church and home, a mother and child navigate faith, endurance and spiritual responsibility, drawing on Christianity and African diasporic spiritual traditions.

CLAWS (NO DIALOGUE)
Aurèle Ferrier
Switzerland, 2025, 18:23
In this dialogue-free moving-image essay, the camera glides through rapidly expanding cities, tracing a path from peripheral terrains into urban cores before opening back onto the horizon.

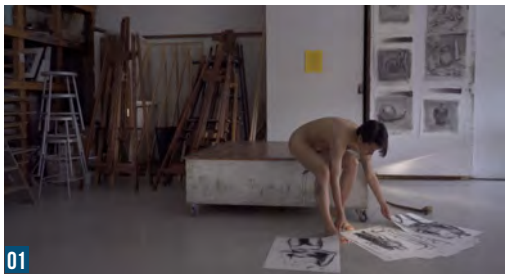
RITUALS OF THE ROADWAY (NO DIALOGUE)
Libby Bove
UK, 2025, 15:15
Rituals of the Roadways explores an imagined, alternate timeline where the profound connection between labour and ritual, once central to agricultural life, thrives in our contemporary world.

18

HOW FAR IS TOO FAR?
EXPERIMENTAL 2

THURSDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 1	Friargate	YSJU
17:00-18:30	13:30-15:00	17:00-18:30

As technology advances faster than ever, society is entering uncharted territory, full of confusion, uncertainty and fear. Each project explores the consequences we're seeing in our modern world and examine the scary prospect of advancements that move faster than humanity can keep up with. They leave us to wonder: how far is too far for new technology?



01

INFINITE REPLICA
Kwan Q Li
UK, 2026, 10:44
Beneath a nanotechnology lab, a non-binary model is barred from posing nude during a life-drawing session. As the machinery murmurs, the boundaries between flesh and technology dissolve.

02

IT GIRL
Hebe Wang
UK, 2026, 4:14
Set between a white void and a dark hotel room, the film unfolds as hallucinatory voices instruct, persuade and affirm the main character as she morphs into her idealised self: her digital twin.

03

A SIGNIFICANT DEVELOPMENT
Jackson Lapsley Scott
Australia, 2025, 20:00
An unseen presence drifts through the homes of people making Artificial Intelligence systems in 2025. It searches rooms and asks questions of their residents, who are also hidden from view.

04

OCCLUSION
Stephen Cornford
UK, 2026, 19:15
This film considers how the accuracy of LiDAR offers new digital opportunities for scientists to understand the forest's complexity. But it also opens up the chance for extraction and exploitation.

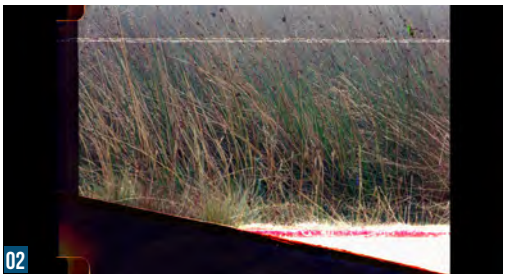
05

BITFLIP
Muwen Li
USA, 2026, 8:06
Searching through forgotten belongings, a woman rediscovers a camera she shared with an old friend. Inside are fragments of another time: images, voices, gestures suspended in storage.

OUR PLACE IN THE WORLD
EXPERIMENTAL 3

Our gender influences how we move through the world – shaping how we see and express ourselves, and how we are perceived by those around us. Join filmmakers who question this idea, examining how gender leaves its mark on friendships, relationships, self-expression, personal freedoms and artistic output. Each one has something vital to say about our world.

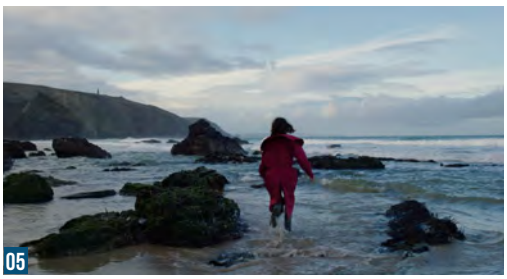
RUSALKI
Eva Blackwell-Rogelj
UK, 2026, 8:40
A young girl wakes up by a lake with a collection of women and no memory of how she got there. As fragments from her past resurface, tensions rise and the girl tries to find a way to escape.



TO LOVE WHAT FEELS MOST AKIN
Annie Crabtree
UK, 2026, 13:58
Merging digital and analogue footage shot on location at the supposed site of Emily Brontë's novel *Wuthering Heights*, the project evokes the cyclical nature of traumatised memory.

BLUEBIRD
Maya Yoncali
UK, 2026, 17:40
Noah leaves London behind and walks out onto the banks of the Thames. Alone with a rucksack and a need for direction, they encounter a dancer, whose movement speaks what Noah cannot.

RULES (SUBTITLED)
Tove Bornhøft
Denmark, 2025, 11:00
New to a group of performers, one woman tries and fails to keep up with the routine, seemingly unable to get to grips with the movement and behaviours of her two companions.



BEES AND BEASTS
Maria Garcia
UK, 2026, 19:56
Gilda, a renowned endometriosis surgeon, suddenly discovers herself trapped in a recurring nightmare with a beekeeper who wants to use her womb to bring back an extinct species of bee.

METAMORPHOSIS
Gillian Katungi
UK, 2026, 10:44
Metamorphosis weaves together snippets of dreams, rituals and intergenerational conversation, inviting audiences to remember their connection to the landscape, themselves and each other.

12

WHO ARE YOU REALLY?
EXPERIMENTAL 4

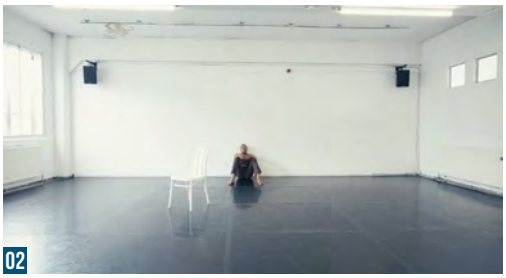
WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
City Screen 3	Frairgate	Yorks. Museum
10:00-11:30	15:00-16:30	10:00-11:30

Is it possible to truly know oneself? These films consider what it means to forge an identity, often shaped by societal expectations and the ideas of those around us. They offer a moment of contemplation, inviting audiences to look inwards and take a second to think about who they really are, without all of the noise and distractions found within modern life.

SELF
Ross Casswell
UK, 2025, 29:25
Part social experiment, part cinematic exploration of identity, *Self* documents a film crew and 10 actors as they embark on a surreal journey to answer the undefinable question: what truly is the self?

5 UNUSUAL STORIES ABOUT HUMAN NEEDS (SUBTITLED)
Filippos Kordalis
Greece, 2026, 15:26
In five chapters, five seemingly unrelated stories come together to become a complete anthology. Each aspect explores a different fundamental human need, based on Maslow's famous hierarchy.

ENNUI
Eric Perriard
Australia, 2025, 7:52
Ennui offers a slow contemplation of South Australian settings, punctuated by succinct moments of magical realism. The film's main character is the location, murmuring a profound story.



CHOIR OF CATHARSIS
Chiara Lari, Joséphine Fransilja
UK, 2025, 4:14
This intimate and poetic short film gives voice to the sacred anger of Black women, as seven figures gather in a collective scream, transforming rage into ritual, catharsis and healing.

BURNING LIES
Raviva Nsiama
Germany, 2026, 10:15
Based on poems by Dorcas Nsiama and performed in English, Lingala and Kikongo, the film traces an inner journey – from the question "who are you?" to a rebirth beyond illusion and ego.

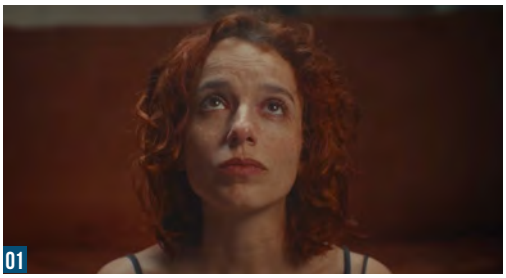
GHOST NOON (NO DIALOGUE)
Ting-Kin Chan
China, 2026, 7:30
A restless wanderer rejects identity, borders, and time, becoming a ghostly figure that resists society's methods of control, whilst searching for personal freedom in an increasingly haunted world.

INNER JOURNEYS
EXPERIMENTAL 5

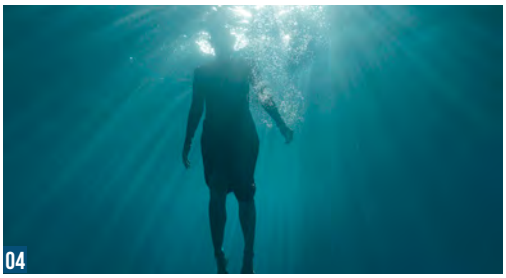
WEDNESDAY	FRIDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 1	City Screen 1	YSJU
17:30-18:30	13:30-14:30	19:00-20:00

PG

Each of these five stories offers a different perspective on self expression, and how we convey this to the world – through dreams, ritual and rage. *Metamorphosis* explores connections formed across generations, histories and landscapes, whilst *Choir of Catharsis* harnesses the power of a collective scream for healing. *Burning Lies* explores the possibility of rebirth.



DECONSTRUCTION OF AN INDIVIDUAL (SUBTITLED)
Ruben Arede
Portugal, 2025, 9:49
Eva and Alice are best friends. Between them, there existed a territory made of silence, laughter and shared moments. When a third presence enters, that territory begins to slowly fracture.



BETWEEN WATER AND ROOF: STORIES OF BLACK (SUBTITLED)
Efi Spyrou
Greece, 2025, 10:15
Through poetic imagery, narrative interviews and choreographic expression, this film asks viewers to think more deeply about the fluid space between darkness and light, fear and transformation.

A BLACK FAIRYTALE
Isabelle Edi, Mariama Sow, Kim Sanou
Germany, 2026, 23:00
We follow princess, who lives deep under the sea and is called by cauri shells to travel across time and space. On their journey, they become a witness of possibilities of Black resistance and existence.

BALLYMAN
Faruq Adigun
UK, 2025, 17:30
Ballyman follows Deji as he traverses London, hiding behind his (bally) balaclava. As his mental state deteriorates, a new path of discovery unfolds – one that is as isolating as it is enlightening.

Æ - III WHOLENESS AND BODY (SUBTITLED)
Reiko Yonezawa
Japan, USA, 2025, 3:44
She(æ) comes face to face with a version of herself constructed to fit society's standards. Driven by the fear of her other self, She(æ) unconsciously brings about unforeseen consequences.

FAMILY FRIENDLY

INSPIRE YOUR CHILDREN WITH A FUN SELECTION OF INCREDIBLE FILMS & ANIMATION.

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BELONGING AND BIG ADVENTURES
FAMILY FRIENDLY 1 (SUBTITLED)

WEDNESDAY Friargate 12:00-13:00 | **SATURDAY** YSJU 12:00-13:00 | **SUNDAY** YSJU 13:30-14:30

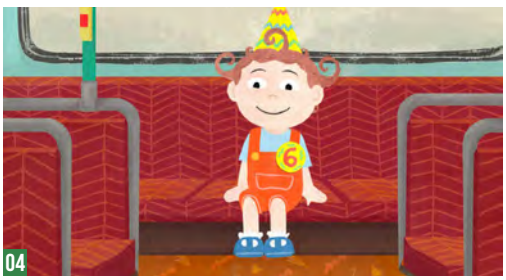
U

What amazing adventures can happen when you open your heart to others? In these delightful films, brave heroes, curious dreamers and unlikely friends discover the power of kindness, teamwork and imagination. From rescuing kingdoms and building creative worlds to helping strangers and finding belonging, these stories celebrate friendship and courage.

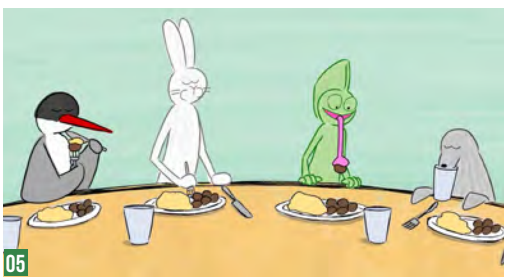
FLINK'S PIGEON PROBLEMS (NO DIALOGUE)
Susan Fitzer, Brian Pimental
USA, 2025, 3:45
Flink, an adorable purple fluffball, leaves no stone unturned trying to rescue his kingdom's pigeons. He sets out with a bit of magic to help the creatures that have somehow turned to stone.

INTO THE FOREST (NO DIALOGUE)
Antonin Niclass
Switzerland, 2026, 9:55
In a stop-motion studio, a small monkey opens its eyes. On a computer screen, a jungle appears. With the help of companions, it begins to build a jungle of its own, using whatever it can find.

SUNSPARK (NO DIALOGUE)
Danny Bourque
USA, 2026, 11:00
Whilst scavenging for useful spare parts, a lonely robot discovers someone who desperately needs his help. His actions show that it is possible to live a life of quiet but meaningful connection.



BWGAN (SUBTITLED)
Hywel Prytherch Roberts
UK, 2026, 8:02
Six-year-old Betti isn't used to sharing her Mam, especially on her birthday. But when a baking disaster sends them looking for a cake, a gatecrasher turns a simple trip into a difficult adventure.



SHIFTING (NO DIALOGUE)
Oona Tiirakari
Finland, 2025, 8:48
Cleo, an anthropomorphic chameleon, travels from a very dense forest to a new jungle. They find themself struggling to fit into the new environment, until one day they rescue an unlikely friend.

ONE MORE CUP (SUBTITLED)
Max Wagenblass
USA, 2026, 4:52
Toddler Leona is about to host her very first tea party with her own stuffed animals. It unexplainably turns into a worldwide spectacle – but all she really wants is to share some tea with her best friends.

U

FINDING YOUR PLACE
FAMILY FRIENDLY 2

THURSDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
Friargate	YSJU	YSJU
12:00-13:00	13:30-14:30	12:00-13:00

Follow along as these young people embark on exciting journeys of courage, creativity, friendship and self-discovery. From magical encounters and treasured memories to environmental challenges and cultural connections, these stories celebrate finding your voice, embracing your uniqueness and growing through life's many unexpected adventures.

AMUSEMENT
Stephanie Zari
UK, 2026, 10:00
A downbeat 10-year-old girl needs to act quickly to make her trip to the amusements count and win her dream prize, but she hasn't contended with the self-appointed "king of the amusement park."

THE JACKET
Holly Louise Psaliou
UK, 2026, 4:35
This is the story of young man's grief for his father. After donating his beloved dad's possessions to a charity, he comes to believe that he has made a mistake when it comes to his favourite jacket.

CORNFIELD
Michał Cygan
UK, 2026, 12:00
A child escapes school through her imagination, where a battle between mice and a hawk mirrors her fight for self-expression. Her creativity will change her life – and the life of her teacher.

THE CURIOUS INCIDENT OF EVERETT WILDER
Ben Tobin
USA, 2025, 15:00
The story of a child in 1952 who encounters a jackalope at his birthday party. Following this curious incident, Everett becomes obsessed with capturing the elusive, uncatchable horned rabbit.

TIP OF THE ICEBERG (NO DIALOGUE)
Sophia McDonnell
UK, 2026, 3:37
A baby penguin is hatched by a falling plastic bottle. Imprinting upon the plastic waste, the baby follows the bottle as it is blown over land and sea, until our protagonist's fortune comes to an end.

WEEYAGALE
Ainslie Senfuka
UK, 2025, 6:23
This magical-realist drama is about a young British-Ugandan girl whose classroom show-and-tell unlocks a dreamlike journey into her heritage, revealing how culture is a source of immense joy.

GROWING UP, LOOKING FORWARD
FAMILY FRIENDLY 3

FRIDAY
Friargate
10:00-11:00

SATURDAY
YSJU
12:00-13:00

SUNDAY
YSJU
13:30-14:30

PG

When the future feels uncertain, it can be hard to find your way. Across imaginative and heartfelt films, young people navigate grief, friendship, identity, ambition, heritage, and first promises. From transformative journeys and fairytales to football pitches, exam halls and dreams, these stories capture the challenges and discoveries that shape the path to adulthood.

TO CATCH A SIREN
Raphaela Wagner
Germany, Switzerland, UK, 2026, 19:50
A young refugee desperately searches for her beloved mother, who she believes to be a mermaid. This film is a modern fairytale about grief and displacement, seen from a child's perspective.

MULTIPLE CHOICE
Aaron Lucas
Australia, 2026, 5:43
During her very last school maths exam, high-achieving Grace is swept up into the hypnotic rhythm of the room and forced to confront her future as a variety of multiple-choice questions.

FULL PITCH
Róisín Leavy-Sahin
Ireland, 2026, 10:44
Returning as the captain of her football team after an extended absence, Meadbh is excited to meet her friends again. But when she's introduced to Úna, she's not quite sure what to make of her.

SAFE SPACE
Matthew Eyre
UK, 2026, 15:00
A troubled young girl embarks on a journey to the Moon in her homemade rocket, where she will explore its surface with her hero: Neil Armstrong, the first person to set foot on the celestial body.

THE SKY WAS CANDY (NO DIALOGUE)
Anh Tú Nguyen
Germany, 2025, 3:00
A yellow and blue day in the life of a little child, who discovers a bird that has fallen out of a tree and decides to take care of it. This is a story of dealing with complex first experiences of loss.

OUR KINGDOM
Chris Ross
UK, 2026, 8:38
After school on a blissful summer's afternoon, neighbours Becky and Jake offer each other a safe haven from life at home, escaping into a playground of chips, ball games, vows and Shakespeare.

12

WAYS OF BEING
FASHION

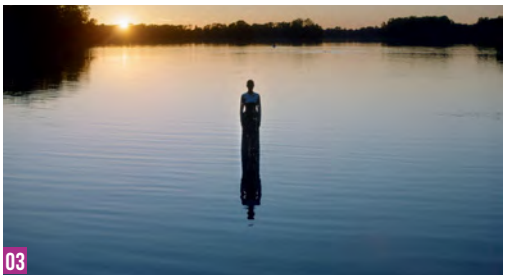
How do culture, place, movement, memory and the people around us shape our sense of self? This programme features films that explore identity through fashion, the body and personal expression. Across different worlds and perspectives, something recognisable emerges: our desire to express who we are, where we come from, and who we might become.

01

MADE IN X
Sofia Ivanova-Kozhevnikova
UK, 2025, 5:03
Blending gritty, documentary realism with surreal dreamscapes, *MADE IN X* follows a young immigrant who is navigating life on the margins of a society that sees her as a label before a person.

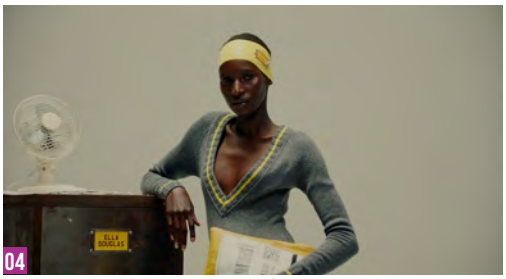
02

PRONTO | WEAR YOUR NEXT STORY
Dimitri Yuri
Qatar, 2025, 7:30
A strange and unexpected job interview at an emerging fashion start-up leads a young woman to improvise, deciding to create cinematic stories about each new outfit that is presented to her.



03

CRUMBLE
Isabella Hoffmann
Germany, 2025, 2:23
A woman drifts between dream and reality. When she meets the child she once was, she sees that healing is not something given by others. It begins when she has the courage to face herself.



04

YELLOW PAGES
Tom Oliver
UK, 2025, 1:34
Yellow Pages is a study of duality, pulling viewers into the grease-stained office of a lesbian-run garage, an in-between space where microwaves hum and the hiss of drills bleed through thin walls.

05

ABJAD HAWAZ
Hadi Moussally
Lebanon, 2025, 5:00
Abjad Hawaz takes its name from the traditional ordering of the Arabic alphabet. Through the physical body of Salma Zahore, each letter is danced and embodied in the ruins of Barcelona.

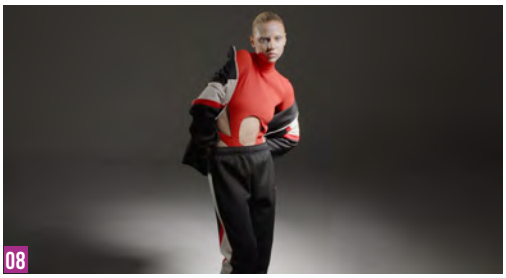
06

FEARLESS FLIGHT
Jonathan David Edwards
USA, 2026, 0:40
In a short film that explores the multiple facets of masculinity, this narrative emerges as an ode to the tales of Greek mythology that once shaped our history. This film was part of a *GQ* editorial.

TOM FORD PRIVATE COLLECTION

Edward Lee
USA, 2025, 0:21

Behind closed doors, the gaze turns inward. Featuring renowned Spanish actor and model Jon Kortajarena, this film offers a raw, voyeuristic glimpse into the quiet world of the Private Collection.



SELF-MIMETIC

Christophe Chudy
France, 2025, 3:05

Through a carefully interwoven beauty and fashion narrative, *Self Mimetic* unfolds as a bold philosophical introspection on the perception and projection of our own image in modern society.

QUIETUDE

Krystyna Leonova
Ukraine, 2025, 2:11

Two women's clothes mirror their surroundings of stone, ice, and wind, revealing the true luxury of silence in a world overwhelmed by noise and the innate human desire to connect with nature.

IN THE HEART OF THE FLOWER CITADEL

Adam Muscat
UK, 2025, 4:48

A known world fractures into sublime encounters as odd tricksters vault and somersault across a celestial cityscape, their pounding feet carrying the viewer toward moments of both awe and terror.

FAME

Federico Nickl, Andrea Bolzoni
Italy, 2026, 3:55

Set entirely inside a theatre, where desire, tension, anxiety and exhaustion are told through the body. In fragments of mirrors, breath and skin, the protagonist chases a flawless performance.

MY KANGA AND ME

Izzy Mana
UK, 2026, 5:00

Guided by spoken word and intimate interviews, *My Kanga and Me* follows three young wanderers wrapped in East African kanga as they move through Brixton and into the open fields beyond.

12 WAYS OF BEING
FASHION

13

THE UNSPOKEN SECRETS BEHIND BARCELONA'S HAPPINESS
Victor Claramunt
Spain, 2026, 1:12

There are stereotypes of residents of Barcelona: that it's the city where people speak the least, or that they eat churros every day. But behind these stories lies a different truth: Barcelona is fashion.

14

KAADIKI - POOL PARTY
Jordan Harvey
Canada, 2026, 2:18

At a sun-drenched hideaway, a group of very chic, dangerously attractive criminals lounge at a pool party. In the bushes, two young feds meant to be surveilling them become captivated.

15

WHEN THE WIND BLOWS
Gigi Yang
Hong Kong, UK, 2025, 8:43

After undergoing a routine procedure, Birdy wakes to find herself stranded in a dimension that feels eerily familiar. As the night falls, Birdy is abruptly transported into a rave like dimension.

16

PRYVID
Jan Bujnowski
Poland, 2025, 4:34

The film explores Polish tradition, which is slowly fading. Rural landscapes have been supplanted by post-industrial images of the Polish countryside, interpreting a new cultural identity.

17

AMBERSTICHE
Victoria Juemei Gong
UK, 2025, 5:20

Four hybrid beings, part human and part animal, enact their final moments before becoming suspended within amber, a luminous substance that can both preserve and immobilise a creature.

18

WITHIN
Valentina Khodnevich
UK, 2026, 2:29

A London-based vocal ensemble of six women transforms human stories into an improvised experience sound and movement. This is an intimate exploration of voice, vulnerability and connection.

FUTUR SHOK
Adam Hayes
South Korea, 2026, 1:45
Futur Shok was originally a cutting edge fashion shoot produced in Seoul. The director collaborated with a group of avant-garde Korean fashion designers to create a futuristic film campaign.

THE STREETS MOVE AS ONE
Joshua Ellis
Brazil, 2026, 1:20
This project considers how a diverse range of people engaging in sports activities within the urban environment are interconnected, blending sportstyle and streetwear into one overriding narrative.

HELLO
Pete Wylde
France, 2026, 3:14
A phone call between two women descends into a bizarre, looping exchange where comprehension slips just out of reach and drifts into a conversation that repeats, fragments and resists resolution.

À LA FOLIE, PAS DU TOUT
LUTZ
Brazil, 2026, 1:56
À la folie, pas du tout is a film about adornment as a way of being transported. Not jewelry as decoration or status, but as something that opens an entire imaginary life inside the person wearing it.

AKIN
Pelin Terzi
Germany, 2025, 8:40
One protagonist describes feelings, whilst three figures appear as mirrors of her inner state. In a world that demands perfection, everyday life continues even when inside we are overwhelmed.

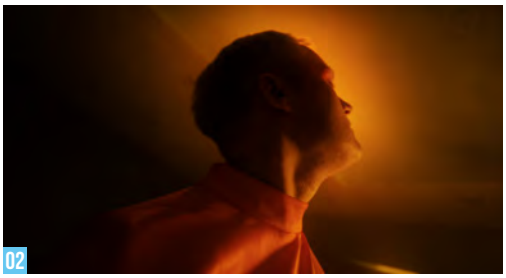
THE GESTURE
Andrea Martínez Mares
Mexico, 2026, 1:58
Four moments are embodied by four garments and four dancers. As new women gradually enter the space, gestures are observed, repeated and transformed, creating a collective choreography.

PG

SHIFTING REALITY
MUSIC VIDEO 1

Reality slips seamlessly between dreamscapes, imagined characters and the everyday in this inventive and thought-provoking collection of shorts. Across a variety of visual styles, from animation to movement-driven works, these bold creative projects explore both personal and collective transformation through the subtle art forms of music, movement and image.

DOOM
Chamberlain Staub
USA, 2025, 5:50
A man celebrates his brother's birthday but is soon forced to relive childhood trauma. As he claws through his subconscious, he's faced with the reality that his brother died a long time ago.



LUCY DREAMS - CODE TO MY MIND
Monika Jungwirth
Austria, 2025, 3:07
Lucy Dreams' unique brand of "SonicWaveArtPop" enters a fresh new visual era with *Code to My Mind,* introducing a world beyond reality where humans, machines and emotions combine together.

PÔT-POT: THE LIGHTS ARE ON
Cheryl Gelover, Tom Murray
USA, 2025, 4:16
Duo Tulipomania scanned, printed and photographed an eclectic array of objects, alongside clay model lips and their own hands, in order to create the stop-motion for pôt-pot's *The Lights Are On.*

TAMARA FLORES - CHIGONA
Rupert Höller
Austria, 2025, 3:15
Tamara Flores moves with determination through the colourful streets of Acatlán, Mexico. Bursting with colour, rhythm and dance, *Chingona* is a bold visual anthem about carving your own path.

GLANCE - WHITEISLANDS
Cameron Perry
UK, 2025, 2:57
When two former lovers cross paths after a breakup, memories of joy and heartbreak collide in this dreamlike, neon, Wong Kar-wai-inspired journey. Starring David Jonsson and Honor Swinton.

RAIN
Jasper de Bruin
Netherlands, 2025, 6:15
Escaping the hustle and bustle, Immen parks at the forest, where she improvises a comforting song on her guitar. Her singing wakes up a mysterious, dormant forest spirit called the Reed Wanderer.

07

OTHER I

Alina Popescu
France, 2025, 02:55

Set in a vast cathedral devoted to an otherworldly deity, a young girl offers up gifts that begin as harmless tokens but escalate into brutal sacrifices of her own body. *Other I* is a haunting allegory.

08

CHRISTMAS AMBULANCE

Nina Celine Gantz
UK, 2025, 4:25

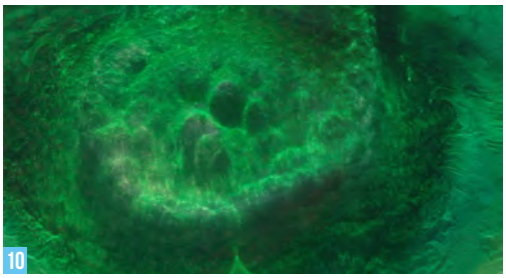
For some people, Christmas can be weird. It's especially strange if you are teetering somewhere between this world and the next. This is the premise for Saltend Recovery's *Christmas Ambulance*.

09

THE 3RD

Lauren Taylor Gee
UK, 2025, 4:13

An experimental music video for South London singer-songwriter Hillarynx. The piece is inspired by Ousmane Sembène's seminal black-and-white directorial debut *Black Girl*, released in 1966.



10

BECOMING

Shelley Hopkins
UK, 2025, 4:48

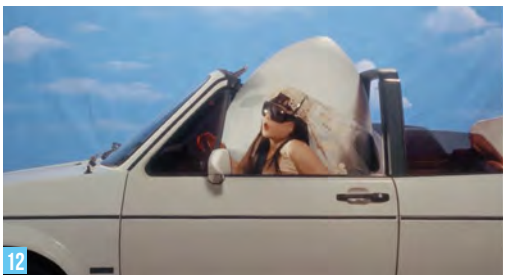
BECOMING transports us to a realm where an angelic chorus of synth and suggestion underscores an ever-changing landscape – an unknowable abstract universe swirling towards its next stage.

11

ROUND CORNERS - SUCH A FOOL

Elias Papastamatiou
Greece, 2023, 4:03

Set against a backdrop of serene coastal landscapes, the video for Round Corners' *Such a Fool* showcases the band's blend of indie and dream pop, infused with the lingering spirit of 70s rock music.



12

WET LEG - POKEMON

Elliott Arndt
UK, USA, 2025, 3:36

A fitting entry into the ever-surreal Wet Leg archive, *Pokemon* tells story of a person, played by Alice Longyu Gao, who enters into an unusual relationship with a giant egg – which eventually hatches.

12 MOVING FORWARD / LOOKING BACK
MUSIC VIDEO 2

From lost loves to imagined futures, these films trace longing across time and space. An eclectic mix of musical genres carries us between worlds, traversing distant coastlines, domestic spaces and dreamlike landscapes. There is also a palpable tension between conformity and freedom, with many of these shorts operating as a rallying cry to embrace your true self.

01

GIRL IN RED - HEMINGWAY
Isak Jenssen
Norway, 2025, 3:27
In an attempt to avoid reality, Marie finds herself sitting at a bar late at night. We follow her journey back home, before she is – yet again – confronted with the sad truth about her relationship.

02

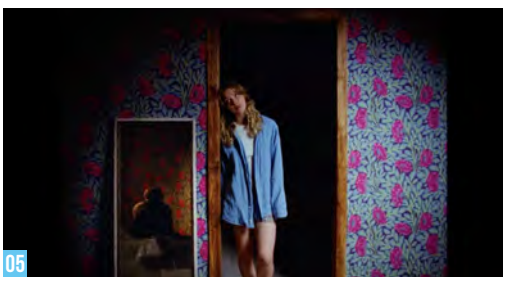
HEART WIDE OPEN
Lauren Luxenberg
UK, 2025, 4:28
In Madame Gandhi's *Heart Wide Open*, the energetic movements of a group of Black and Brown femmes and queer dancers pulse in conversation with an instrumental swell of drums, sax and bass.

03

SEA, TAKE IT AWAY
Raia Vasileva, Masha Rodicheva
Georgia, 2026, 3:13
Sea, Take it Away is a stop-motion music video for the independent singer-songwriter menya zovut masha. It reflects on ideas of exile, belonging, the pull of the sea, growing up and accepting change.

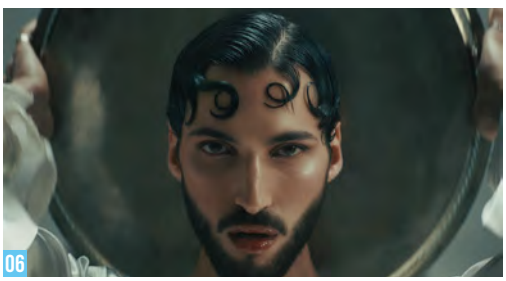
04

YOU ARE AN IDIOT
Inari Sirola
UK, 2025, 2:50
"A cathartic anthem for the absolutely mad times we are living in", *You Are An Idiot* features Sirola's signature animation style: comedic, surreal and filled with flawed but lovable characters.



05

IVANA JUNE - AROUND (MUSIC VIDEO)
Hogarth Coote
UK, 2025, 2:00
This film is shot on Bolex 16mm film for R&B artist Ivana June's single *Around*. The song itself blends bossa nova, neo-soul and pop influences, exploring themes of memory, love and pain.



06

EL FILM
El Mehdi
Canada, 2025, 2:24
El Film is a conceptual musical short exploring identity, shame, the sacred and nostalgia. The film unfolds in a world that polices who gets to exist freely – where queer Arab visibility is fraught.

07

CHARLATANS

Tess Martin
USA, 2026, 4:45

In this abstract music video for Mutual Shock, oil, water and other elements form unstable chemical landscapes – filmed in macro – that evoke central themes of seduction, distortion and collapse.

08

FISHBOWL

Jonah Moshammer, Maria Donjacour
USA, 2025, 4:38

This evocative, dance-driven piece explores the curated identities we construct online, and the obsession that can follow. The piece celebrates the release that comes from shattering these façades.

09

GO SLOW

Tom Oliver
UK, 2026, 4:33

In Western culture, and particularly across the UK, rituals around death are often confined to the sombre formality of the funeral. In *Go Slow*, Mr Bruce finds himself at the limits of these traditions.

10

BAMBIE THUG - REDRUM (OFFICIAL MUSIC VIDEO)

Jake William Ringsell
UK, 2025, 3:39

Irish singer-songwriter Bambie Thug's *REDRUM* is a visceral descent into a world of coercion and control, exploring the struggle to preserve identity in the face of forced conformity.

11

VALKYRIE

Alfred Benjamin Wright
UK, 2026, 8:45

Bandi, in the pursuit of knowledge and a deeper understanding of his own identity, embarks on a pilgrimage under the guidance of a distant figure who watches him plunge into the depths of his soul.

12

HAVE YOU NEVER SEEN BIRDS?

Jessica Fecteau, ROB
Canada, 2025, 2:32

The narrative of *Have You Never Seen Birds?* unfolds against the tension between authority and mysticism: a quest for freedom in the face of the control imposed by a Catholic private school.

18

MY RIDES HERE

THRILLER 1

THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY
Friargate	City Screen 3	City Screen 1
10:00-11:30	11:15-12:45	19:00-20:30

Taxis, yellow cars, technology and a heavy dose of morality bring the fear factor in this collection of shorts that makes us think about where we are now, how we are being affected by modernity, and what may soon come to pass. What choice would you make if someone else's fate was in your hands? Can we ever truly separate our actions from our surroundings?

01

BLACK CAB

James Arden
UK, 2026, 15:00

In the near future, Harry, a third-generation cab driver in London, struggles to find his place and purpose in a fast-changing world. He seems tirelessly optimistic, but can his enthusiasm really last?

02

EVERY TIME I SEE A YELLOW CAR

Matt Chandler
UK, 2025, 14:12

After a violent act shatters the lives of two brothers, Olly tries his best to articulate a fractured and repressed truth, whilst his older sibling Liam spirals between feeling guilt and seeking revenge.

03

MAXXED OUT

Milo Miller
UK, 2025, 16:00

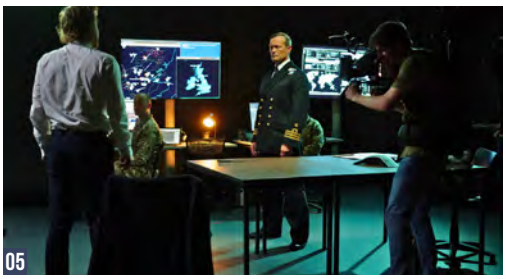
An insecure and isolated young man embarks on a twisted self improvement journey guided by his online hero, Brad, a popular "looksmaxxing" influencer with hidden and sinister intentions.

04

4 MINUTES BEFORE FOREVER

Yoann Zak
UK, 2026, 13:49

What starts as seemingly harmless fun with their phones turns into a countdown to destruction, when an algorithm predicts the downfall of the couple's relationship with terrifying precision.



05

CODES

Eleanor Rhode
UK, 2025, 10:34

What if you had to kill a person to save the world? Only four days ago, Jasper was appointed as Deputy Prime Minister. Today, he's in a bunker being asked to save the country from annihilation.

06

ANON

Dylan Brady
UK, 2026, 14:00

A brief encounter between a closeted taxi driver and young male passenger leads to a truly frightening exchange with life-altering consequences, in this exploration of anonymous hook-up culture.

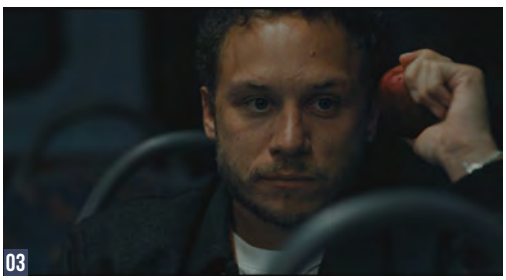
THE KIDS ARE ALRIGHT
THRILLER 2

WEDNESDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
City Screen 2	Yorks. Museum	Yorks. Museum
13:30-15:00	20:30-22:00	10:00-11:30

From serial killers to hitmen and trauma, the young people in this collection of films all find themselves in physical and psychological danger. They ask the audience to consider: What would you do to fix the situation if you found yourself in a similar situation? And more importantly, what would you do if you happened to discover a severed head in an old suitcase?

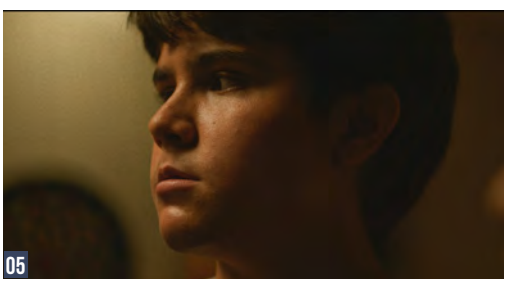
BRUISED SKY
Gary James Kent
UK, 2025, 18:00
1970, Halstead, Essex. George meets Tommy in a basketball court. After sharing a joint, George invites Tommy to his dealer's house to get more weed. But the night becomes something unexpected.

ADULT MALE BLOND
Harry Quinlan
Australia, 2025, 14:57
A man is told to collect his employer's girlfriend and take her to a party. As night falls, the woman realises he has been sent to kill her. The only chance to escape is a test he makes his victims take.



BUNDLE
Carlo Milillo
UK, 2026, 13:12
Will heads to a party to meet his brother, but when he gets there, something isn't right. Chaos follows and Will's world collapses around him. This is an aggressive, symbolic tale of grief and loss.

SMALL SPACES
Jona Headon
UK, 2026, 7:56
When a mysterious stranger offers to cure his claustrophobia, a sceptical man agrees to her bizarre treatment, only to learn that the most dangerous spaces are the ones you walk into willingly.



BLIND MAN'S BLUFF (SUBTITLED)
João de Souza Aranha Toldi
Brazil, 2025, 12:00
Home alone while their parents are out, four cousins play "gato mia" (blind man's bluff). Their fun ends when two of the kids get into a heated argument, which escalates to sinister circumstances.

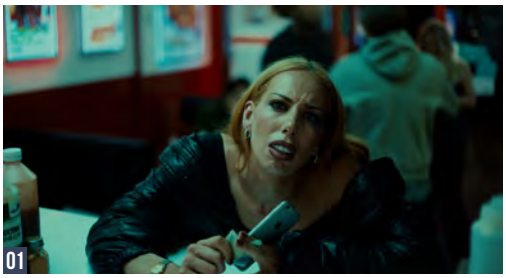
SUMMER PROJECT (SUBTITLED)
Yuki Hara
Japan, 2025, 15:00
A lonely school boy discovers a human head inside a suitcase by the river. What begins as a strange "summer research project" with his peers gradually reveals the darker side of childish curiosity.

15

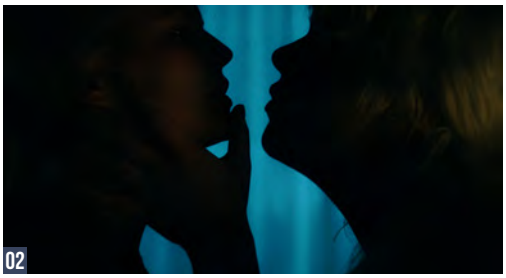
I'M EVERY WOMAN
THRILLER 3

WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	SATURDAY
Friargate	YTR Studio	City Screen 3
19:00-20:30	21:00-22:30	10:00-11:30

In these short films, women are forced to confront dilemmas in both their professional and private lives. The basic tasks of navigating life's challenges and experiences – like walking home in the dark, going for a late-night swim and online dating – coincide with more major problems. In one instance, a character finds themselves at the end of the world as we know it.



MEAT
Jacob Hopewell
UK, 2026, 15:00
What happens when the male gaze is suddenly turned back on itself? A young woman walks into a men's support group, telling the tale of an awful night, when the hunter becomes the hunted.



A DIRGE
Petros
UK, 2026, 15:00
Beth and Nel seek redemption in the wake of a traumatic event. This short film is an eerie exploration of who we become when anger turns into delusion and when love becomes desperation.

INTERTIDAL
James Morgan
UK, 2026, 15:00
After encountering something strange during a swim, a woman is confined to a forensic tent on a remote beach where a government agent offers her reassurance – and a different version of events.

LUCKY
Ryan Malloy, Michael Langan
USA, 2025, 11:34
Tess is on a blind date when the world suddenly collapses. Should she accept Sebastian's offer to escape to his remote island and leave her entire life behind? She's only got six minutes to decide.

PLEASURE-SEEKING
Michaela Holmes
Australia, 2025, 14:20
Suffering from intense loneliness, Sasha spends her days chasing a constant stream of dopamine – until a bizarre physical malady and a persistent neighbour unearth her unravelling mental state.

DATE 3
Cristabel Sved
Australia, 2025, 15:48
Haunted by an abusive relationship, Ella tries to psych herself up for her third date with Harry. But she is uneasy, as almost imperceptible things have been happening around her home.

HORRORS OF SELF (SUBTITLED)
THRILLER 4

THURSDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY
Yorks. Museum	Friargate	City Screen 1
19:00-20:30	17:00-18:30	15:00-16:30

Descend into the depths of the unknown in this chilling anthology of pschological horror films that bring together unique and unsettling creatures, mythical dark storylines and ominous settings. Double check your sweets too, because that humbug you are sucking might not be exactly what you think it is. This collection is classic, spine-tingling thriller at its best.

THE PIGS UNDERNEATH
Charlie Dennis
UK, 2025, 12:36
Residents from one tight-knit working-class town are constantly forced to fulfill a brutal quota just to survive. If they fail to meet it, they are punished with a fate that is far worse than death itself.

BREADSONG (SUBTITLED)
Katariina Aule
Estonia, 2025, 16:00
Breadsong follows the story of a 19th century rural family, who discover a catchy song that is somehow broadcasted from far in the future through the children after they are fed mouldy bread.

FOREIGN BODY (SUBTITLED)
Mathieu Mortelmans, Cécile Delberghe
Belgium, 2025, 16:33
In the middle of the night, a police detective is called to a crime scene in a monastery on a remote island. Left alone to examine the body, she slowly realises that it may not actually be human.

HOLLOW (SUBTITLED)
Jesper Jönsson
Sweden, 2026, 12:27
In the forests of southern Sweden, a poor farmer makes a horrific discovery – a dormant creature and a nugget of gold. When the gold is taken, something awakens that shouldn't be disturbed.

DON'T GO IN THE GARDEN
Adam El-Sharawy
UK, 2025, 18:52
After an accident whilst trimming down her overgrown garden, Lily begins to sense a sinister presence is growing under the soil. She feels she has no choice but to confront the monster beneath.

THE HUMBUG
Cole Paviour
UK, 2025, 9:09
Vera's carehome routine is disrupted when her friend offers her magical mint humbugs – sweets that promise intense pleasure, as long as one rule is obeyed: save the middle for "the Humbug."

PG

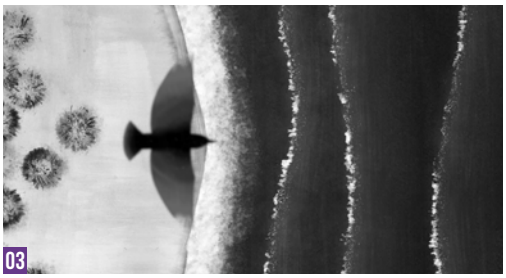
PICK & MIX 1
ANIMATION

WEDNESDAY
YTR Main House
10:30-11:30

These six stories showcase the boundless possibilities of animation techniques, from hand-painted poetry in *Wildkind*, to underwater stop-motion with *Deep End*. Plus, they also hold up a mirror to what it is to be human: characters come face-to-face with themselves in *Trading Cards*, *Acid City* navigates the metropolis, whilst *Making a Mother* considers parenthood.

TRADING CARDS
Radheya Jang
UK, 2026, 14:58
The past, present and future collide when a man confronts his younger self over a game of trading cards. An exploration of identity, nostalgia and the erosion of childhood innocence.

ACID CITY
Jack Wedge, Will Freudenheim
USA, 2026, 12:30
Acid City documents life in an isolated city. It is composed of real interviews conducted across NYC, ranging from regular people on the street, to water scientists and emergency responders.



WILDKIND
John McDaid
UK, 2025, 7:18
Voiced by three generations of one family, *WildKind* is a poem to awaken the senses, a fluid journey of hope and healing. It is a universal bedtime story, a call to nurture a life wild and kind.

DEEP END
Puzhen Zhang
UK, 2026, 7:38
A shy young girl overcomes her intense fear of swimming – and of connection – when she develops an unexpected and magical summer bond with a bold classmate in the deep end of the pool.

IN THE BEGINNING
Ala Nunu
Poland, Portugal, Spain, 2026, 10:50
Legless birds of paradise, the great hamster cull and tardigrades on the moon. A surreal story inspired by real events, which looks at humanity's desire for preservation by controlling the narrative.

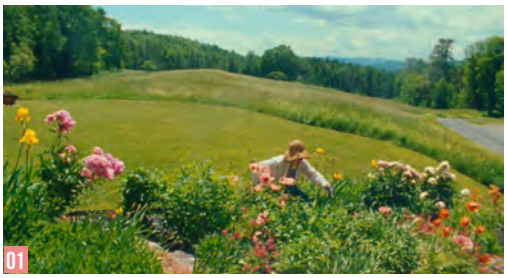
MAKING A MOTHER
Emily Downe
UK, 2026, 4:05
This animation explores matrescence, the deeply personal but unseen metamorphosis of becoming a mother, calling on ancient wisdom to give voice to this drastic yet invisible transformation.

PICK & MIX 2
DRAMA, DOCUMENTARY, DANCE

THURSDAY
YTR Main House
11:30-12:30

PG

Three genres collide in one exciting collection of shorts. Martin Freeman stars in drama *Little Bug*, in which we meet a dog who is about to go into orbit. *Maia. A Mother of Nations* traces a woman's journey across the seas, as told through the medium of dance. In documentary, *Acts of Protest* shows ordinary people who are speaking up against injustice across the world.



SEASONS
Renee Nabinger
USA, 2026, 5:46
Shot on 16mm and VHS, *Seasons* is a love letter to the director's home in Vermont. The film drifts through fragmented memories of home, family as well as the quiet heartache of time passing.

MAIA. A MOTHER OF NATIONS
Sara Dos Santos
UK, 2025, 10:56
This dance film traces a woman's journey across oceans – carried by faith, resilience and hope. The elegant account of a single experience considers unexpected alliances and inherited fates.

LITTLE BUG
Matt Branston
UK, 2025, 9:00
In 1957, the Soviet Union sends a dog into space. The night before, a scientist (Martin Freeman) takes her home to meet his daughter (Alexandra Barredo), and hopefully help repair their relationship.

ACTS OF PROTEST
Zebedee Parkes
Australia, 2025, 7:42
Acts of Protest considers the huge emotional spectrum of protest amid ongoing global crises, offering a sensory experience that explores the contested right to dissent in today's turbulent world.

ON A SUNDAY AT ELEVEN
Alicia K. Harris
Canada, 2024, 9:00
Seven-year-old Angel arrives at ballet class, to discover she is the only Black girl in her lesson. She escapes to a dream world where Black ballerinas with bold, elaborate hairstyles dance around her.

AS IT SHOULD BE
Edwin Lai
Hong Kong, 2026, 11:58
During a Lunar New Year reunion dinner in Hong Kong, Megan returns home from overseas to celebrate with her family. A film about love, and how acceptance arrives in the gentlest of ways.

PG

PICK & MIX 3

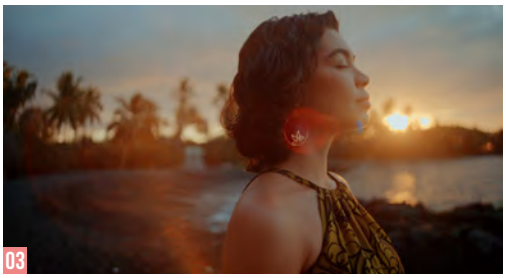
DRAMA, DOCUMENTARY, DANCE

FRIDAY
YTR Main House
10:00-11:00

Across drama, dance and documentary, six stories ask what it means to carve out an identity and exist in a world that seems to be one unprecedented and destabilising event after another. A swimmer reflects on their gender expression; *Ho'olono* looks at our relationship to the land; a woman deals with the loss of her sister; and a dancer processes shared trauma.

FISH THE MOON
Maddie Dai
New Zealand, UK, 9:30
Fish The Moon follows a writer who begins getting calls from a government-appointed censor: a woman called Jasmine. As he attempts to write, she now has front row seats to his every move.

BRUTA
Sulian Rios
France, 2026, 9:51
Bruta tells the story of a world where seriousness and absurdity coexist. Three protagonists carry these two forces in their bodies and gestures, until they turn against a mysterious masked man.



HO'OLONO (TO LISTEN DEEPLY)
Samantha Ramirez-Herrera
USA, 2026, 19:08
Ho'olono is an exploration of our enduring relationship to land and self, inviting audiences to remember that the path through ecological crisis may also prove to be a route back to ourselves.

LIMBES (NO DIALOGUE)
Karl Cannone
France, 2025, 5:32
Limbes unlocks a window into both the dreams and nightmares of a young man. Between paralysis and release, it reflects on our collective fears, shared traumas and the long path toward healing.

THE PIGEON
Chloe Culpin
UK, 2025, 11:36
A bereaved young woman believes that her late sister has been reincarnated – as a pigeon. This film follows as she bonds with the bird, learning about grief and coping mechanisms along the way.

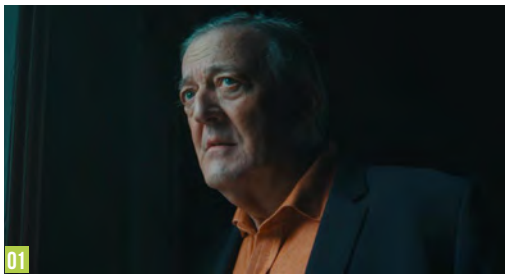
RETUN TO WATER
Kate Malyon
UK, 2025, 5:10
A swimmer reflects on how water is a space for self-discovery. As the tides shift and the pool appears and disappears, so too does their gender identity – sometimes opaque, sometimes clear.

AESTHETICA & YORK THEATRE ROYAL PRESENT:
NEW VOICES, NEW STORIES

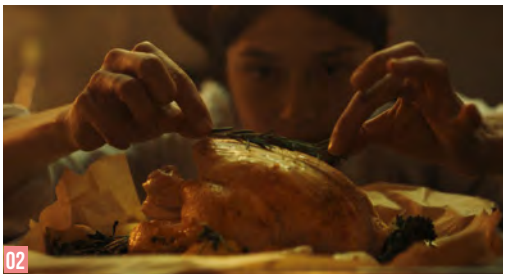
WEDNESDAY
YTR Main House
19:30-21:00

PG

Across these six films runs a shared interest in voices that are suppressed, doubted, distorted or unexpectedly reclaimed. Together, they move between the personal and political, real and surreal, asking what happens when experience cannot remain silent. Memory, grief, desire, sexuality, ageing and gender become sources of both vulnerability and resistance.



ODE TO A NIGHTINGALE
Tommy Creagh
UK, 2026, 7:23
This is a haunting cinematic interpretation of Keats's *Ode to a Nightingale*, as Stephen Fry gives voice to the poet's meditation on beauty, mortality and transcendence, set within Keats House.



ROASTIN
Sue bynn Bae
UK, 2025, 17:33
In London, Dakota, a sous-chef drowning in self-doubt, confronts her deepest fears when a bizarre, headless talking chicken shows up in the empty restaurant. A narrative about reclaiming control.

OLD LESBIANS
Megan
UK, 2024
For the past 25 years, Arden Eversmeyer has travelled all across the USA to record the oral accounts of a fading community – old lesbians, documenting their legacy in a heteronormative society.

ALONE
Shian Denovan
UK, 2025, 12:02
A woman's daily commute is thrown into chaos when she finds the city inexplicably abandoned. *Alone* is a haunting psychological thriller exploring timely themes of loneliness and disconnection.

SOUVENIR
Renée Marie Petropoulos
Australia, 2025, 14:33
Whilst stuck on a long family vacation, Keira, a young closeted teenager, must confront the unnerving hold her girlfriend has over her after she takes unwarranted photos of her during sex.

VIRGIN FANDANGO
Marcy Page
Portugal, 2026, 10:42
A short musical, using a novel technique of animated azulejos (painted tiles), that features a rebellious Mary using her voice to celebrate the women of history in the struggle for equality.

Est. 1841 | YORK ST JOHN UNIVERSITY

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VR & IMMERSIVE EXPERIENCES LAB

Aesthetica Est. 1841 | YORK ST JOHN UNIVERSITY

The potential of 360° cinema knows no bounds. These immersive formats put audiences into the heart of the story, allowing them to explore both real-world and fantastical environments. By placing viewers at the centre of the action, immersive storytelling creates new opportunities to connect with characters, places and perspectives that goes beyond traditional filmmaking.

Now in its eighth year, our 360° Cinema and Immersive Experiences Lab returns to push the boundaries of storytelling. The Lab runs at NCEM on 4-7 November 10.00-21.30, and on 8 November between 10.00-18.30. Pre-registration to the VR Lab is recommended.

We are also hosting daily panel discussions that explore urgent questions in emerging tech, from ethical considerations to the art of how to create emotionally driven narratives. These conversations offer an opportunity to hear from artists, filmmakers, innovators and industry leaders who are working at the forefront of immersive media today.

This is an invitation to step into someone else's shoes and see the world through their eyes – to experience how human innovation continues to influence the different ways we tell stories.

Free with your Festival Pass and Pre-registration is recommended. asff.co.uk

IMMERSIVE ELLUR
Tom Sefton
UK, 2026, 25:00
A pioneering fully interactive and immersive experience with the music artist Ellur. Filmed in York Minster for a live performance and at the recording studio where she mastered her latest album.

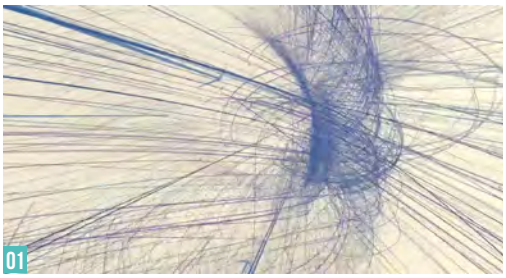
DIATRIBES
Veronica Graham
USA, 2024, 20:00
Diatribes explores the internal conflicts that arise when we're confronted with the reality of climate change. Audiences must navigate through anxiety in an obstacle course of distractions.

VR LAB

4-7 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-18:30

These pieces use immersive technology to take us to different worlds and moments in time. These experiences allow us to step into another realities, encouraging us to slow down and take in our surroundings, whether that's floating on the wind or listening to the words of Emily Dickinson. They're an opportunity to step out of our reality for a moment of brief reprieve.

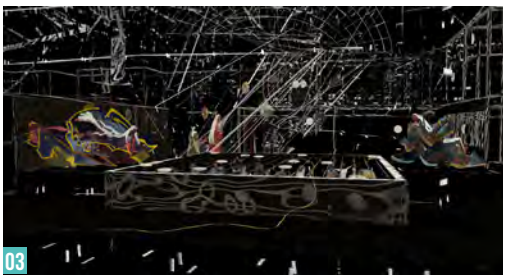


FLOW
Adriaan Lokman
France, 2023, 15:00

Flow invites audiences to float with the wind on what seems, at first glance, to be a day like any other. It is a portrait of night in the life of a woman, painted by the ebb and flow of air currents.

REALITY LOOKS BACK
Anne Jeppesen, Omid Zarei
UK, 2025, 20:59

When you watch a particle, it acts like a particle. But when you look away, it does a whole other thing. This story explores modes of experiencing the strange quantum basis of our everyday life.



ITO MEIKYO
Boris Labbé
France, 2024, 20:00

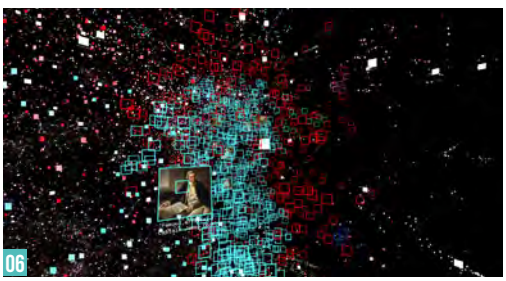
Interior and exterior; transparency and opacity; exhibitionism and voyeurism; feminine and masculine; all of these varying notions oppose or unite in the labyrinth that seems to have no real exit.

KNAPWEED 360
Rebecca Goldsmith
UK, 2023, 3:34

Viewers are transported to a dreamlike space of calm reflection, where family, memory and the cyclical nature of life are quietly revealed through words, connected themes and gentle movement.

EARTHS TO COME
Rose Bond
USA, 2024, 13:00

A virtual journey into the profound depths of a love poem. Painterly images interweave with original vocal music to find vastness and insularity in an 8-line poem by Emily Dickinson.



TERRA ULTIMA, FIELD NOTES FROM LATENT SPACE
Richard Vijgen
Netherlands, 2026, 8:00

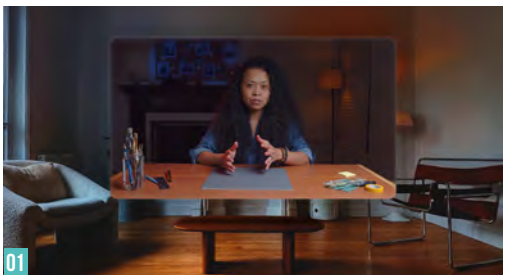
Step inside the mind of a generative AI, where the memories and stories we share online are compressed. This data-driven VR experience examines how AI models extract our visual culture.

VR LAB

4-7 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-18:30

Documentaries have always given us the opportunity to step into someone else's shoes, but with VR, this is taken to the next level. These six projects open the door to a different reality, engaging audiences in major world history, like the Chernobyl disaster or the worsening consequences of climate change, as well as the intimate inner lives of a single individual.



CRAFTING CRIMES
Chloé Rochereuil
France, 2025, 20:00

This immersive, mixed-reality true crime series allows audiences to reconstruct history's most infamous crime scenes and unsolved murders, guided by host and miniaturist Carol Rasaphangthong.

INSIDE CHERNOBYL
Jonathan Wells
UK, 2026, 7:00

This 360° documentary brings viewers inside the Chornobyl site, recreating scenes from 1986 alongside interviews with people who worked there, including those who witnessed the accident.

LIVING IN WATER
Ana P Santos
Philippines, 2026, 15:00

In Isla TIbaguin, Philippines, rising seas arrive quietly as creeping water levels. Nearly every day, flooding submerges homes and turns the streets into rivers. This is climate change in slow motion.

ALONE AT NIGHT
Beata Harju
Finland, 2026, 12:16

This is an empathy-provoking journey through a seemingly safe city, told through the wary eyes of a young woman, Emma, who sees everything on her nighttime walk as a heightened.

MIRAGE
Naima Karim
Bangladesh, Netherlands, Saudi Arabia 2025, 8:00

A young girl struggles with depression and anxiety. Set in a desert landscape, the audience embarks on a VR journey through the girl's mind, encouraged to support her through her challenges.

THE CROWN WITH A SHADOW & THE SEARCH FOR SELF!
Jasbir (JB) Singh Ghuman
USA, 2026, 17:10

A 4D 6K VR colour-therapy film where elements of wind, scent, colours, deep breathing and floating motion each play a role. A powerful story that aims to inspire global compassion and unity.

VR LAB

4-7 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-18:30

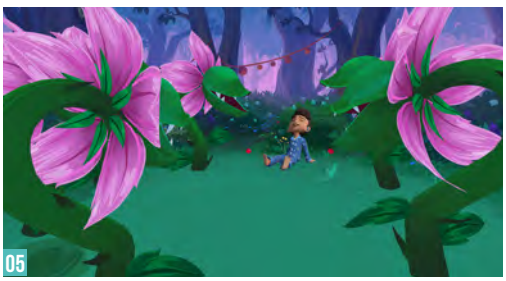
These six immersive animations offer us the chance to step into a piece of art. Their narratives take us on a journey through imagined worlds and help visualise familiar concepts from new angles. Here is an unique opportunity to become one with the forest, interact with an elusive monster and recontextualise the psychological theory of Maslow's hierarchy of needs.

OUT OF NOWHERE
Kris Hofmann, Andreas Wuthe
Germany, 2026, 10:00
Our weather is getting angrier. *Out of Nowhere* gently explores how preserving alluvial forests, marshes and wetlands can help us face the challenges of an ever angrier, unpredictable climate.

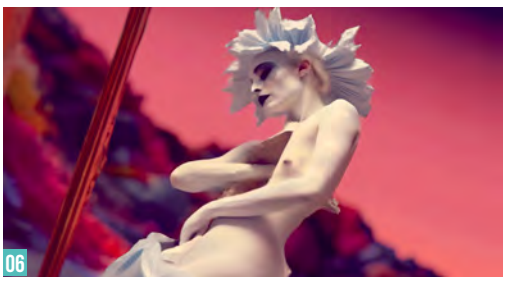
HAUNTS
Tom Chetwode-Barton, Lucy Hammond
UK, 2026, 13:00
It's 2006. In a small town in North Wales, 16-year-old Morgan stands on the edge of his future, guiding us through the haunts, hangouts and nights that linger long after the last bus leaves.

THE BIG CUBE
Menghui Huang
Belgium, China, Finland, Portugal 2025, 6:43
A world is made of cubes. The creatures there follow instructions and push the cubes numbly. Yet, when one of them chooses not to follow the instructions, something truly unexpected happens.

THE DOLLHOUSE
Charlotte Bruneau, Dominic Desjardins
Canada, Luxembourg, 2026, 20:00
The Dollhouse is an unfolding paper world where nine-year-old Juniper untangles feelings of guilt around how her family treated Magnolia, a woman who came from far away to work as a cleaner.



EDDIE AND I
Maya Shekela
France, Germany, Israel, 20:00
An 8-year-old deaf child is scared of his first camping trip. To calm him, his mother tells him, in sign language, the story of "Eddie the Camper", a hairy, monster who grew up in the forest.



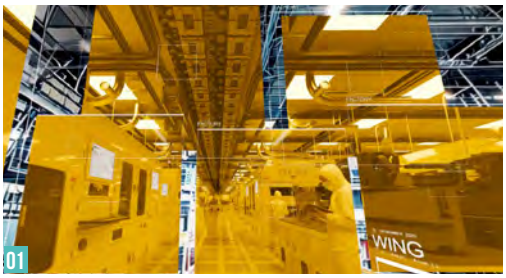
GLUTTONY VR
ECHLO & Dr. Formalyst
Canada, 2025, 10:00
Organised into five acts, based on Maslow's hierarchy of needs, each stage is a different interactive environment that viewers can enter, touch and feel, guided by a powerful orchestral score.

VR LAB

4-7 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
NCEM
10:00-18:30

These five narrative VR projects are rooted in reality, representing a remarkable evolution in human-led storytelling. They feature real people, real environments, real experiences – but they're accessible to audiences in an entirely different time and place. Each one expands our worldview and deepens our understanding of what filmmaking has the power to become.

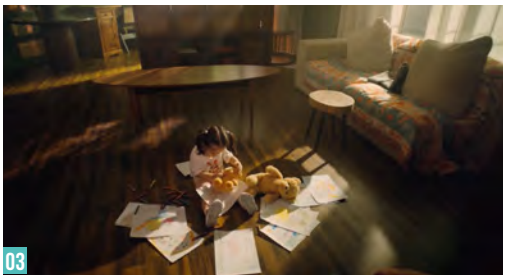


01

SILIQ
Te-Hsing Lu
Taiwan, 2026, 20:00
In the near future, SILIQ, an advanced drone, crosses Taiwan to deliver secret cargo. On its way, it gathers data to speculate its own understanding of spirituality, consciousness and the world.

02

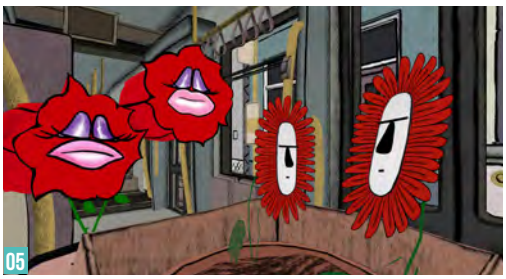
RUBBERS - 360 IMMERSIVE VERSION
Cat Davies
UK, 2026, 10:39
In this dark comedy, a neurodivergent woman who struggles to form personal relationships explores her private passion for stationery in order to unlock her explosive, fantasy world.


03

MOMENTS APART VR
Mohammed Mamdouh
UAE, 2026, 7:20
As Alzheimer's erodes his own sense of time, place and self, a man navigates a reality where love is the only thread holding his world together. If memory can fade, will love remember what remains?

04

PLAY LIFE
Naujokas, Petrauskas, Pronckus, Ulvydas
Lithuania, 2026, 25:00
Play Life invites viewers into the vibrant world of Algis Kriščiūnas' paintings, where art transforms into living, breathing stories. This poetic film explores love, memory and the slow passage of time.


05

THE GREAT ESCAPE
Joren Vandenbroucke
Belgium, 2025, 25:00
Three moody geraniums are trapped on the windowsill of a sad, bare living room. They take control over their fate and plan their escape from the windowsill they spent their entire, boring life on.

EXPLORE THE GAMES LAB

Video games are an essential pillar of modern entertainment and pop culture. This year, we're excited to present the fourth edition of our fully interactive Games Lab, where festival-goers in York are invited to experience a curated selection of indie games across genres including adventure, puzzles, 2D platformers and more.

Games now offer a truly immersive experience and we view them as an essential medium for exploring the evolution of storytelling. We're celebrating every aspect of game culture, design and development, with both hands-on play sessions and insightful panels and talks taking place as part of our masterclass programme.

The Games Lab features over 50 titles, which span PC, console, VR headsets and mobile devices, meaning there's something that both adults and children are guaranteed to enjoy. Expect striking visuals and fun-filled gameplay loops.

The Games Lab is at the National Centre for Early Music.
Free with pass and pre-registration recommended.

4-7 November 10.00-21.30
8 November 10.00-18.30

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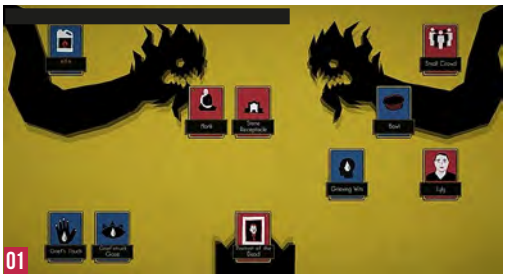


01

SIRE
heartcase
Netherlands, 2025
SIRE is about dealing with the death of a parent, and the whirlwind of emotions that follow. The players combine cards to explore a darkly comedic, surreal world of both personal loss and learning.

02

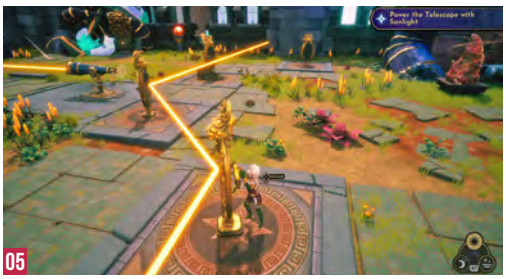
AS LONG AS YOU'RE HERE
Autoscopia Interactive
Denmark, 2025
What if you lost all your memories? This is a family drama seen through the eyes of a woman with Alzheimer's disease. Inspired by real stories and made with care by a small team of developers.

03

A TALE IN THE GARDEN
Dream Outpost
UK, 2025
In this short, slow-paced, narrative-driven point-and-click game, you can follow Filomena, as she prepares her garden for a local competition and awaits the arrival of her young grandchild, Frida.

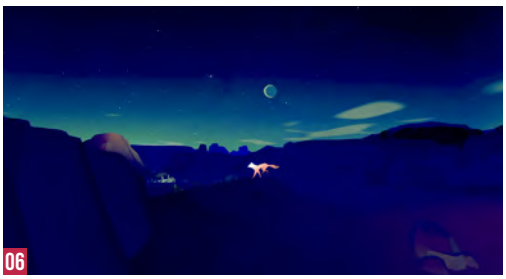
04

LET ME SEE THE SEA
Katharina Faller
Germany, 2026
A point-and-click adventure about the longing for the sea and the experiences it inspires. Guided by a woman recalling her last trip, an ordinary morning unfolds into a memory-filled journey.



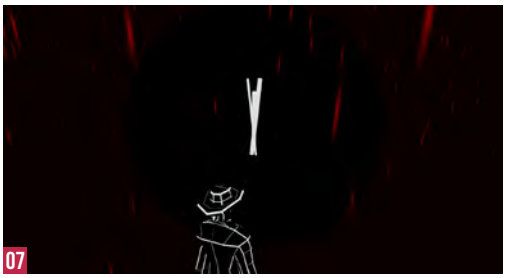
05

ASCEND
Miami Avalon
UK, 2025
Attempt to decode ancient puzzles, collect tarot cards, complete the zodiac trials and use their magical Time Turner to climb the mountain and save their people in *Ascend*, a 3D puzzle adventure.



06

ATUEL
Matajuegos
Argentina, 2022
Atuel is an award-winning surrealist documentary game in which players explore beautiful, dreamlike landscapes inspired by the topography and wildlife of the Atuel River Valley in Argentina.



07

CRIMSON RAIN
Square Zero
UK, 2026
A noir-detective puzzle game where every character is identical. *Crimson Rain* addresses the stereotyping and bias that is rooted in classic mystery fiction, and its perpetuation in sleuth games.

08

ROUTINE
Lunar Software
UK, 2025
Set on an abandoned lunar base designed around a 1980s idea of the future, this first person sci-fi horror allows players to explore their surroundings as they try to survive against unknown threats.

09

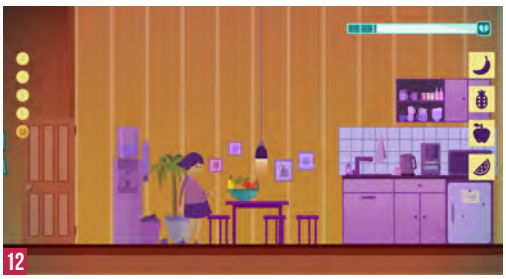
ADORABLE ADVENTURES
Wild Sheep Studio
France, 2026
Boris, a curious baby boar, must learn how to use his nose across rolling meadows, sun-dappled forest paths and rocky highlands to reunite with his family, who were separated after a forest fire.

10

THERE ARE NO GHOSTS AT THE GRAND
Friday Sundae
UK, 2026
Inherit an old crumbling English hotel and restore it by day, while battling ghosts by night. With a sardonic cat, a talking power tool and a supernatural plot, this is a musical mystery unlike any other.

11

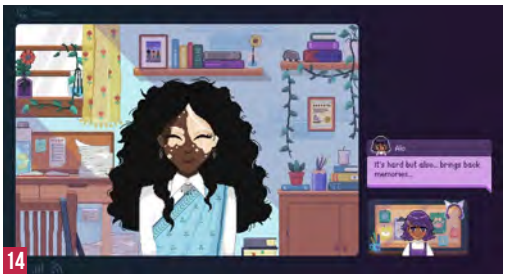
TOROA: SKYCALL
Atawhai Interactive
New Zealand, 2025
Soar, swoop and glide across the vast ocean as Toroa. Fly as an albatross on an epic journey to reunite with their family in this relaxing, atmospheric flight game grounded in the Māori world.



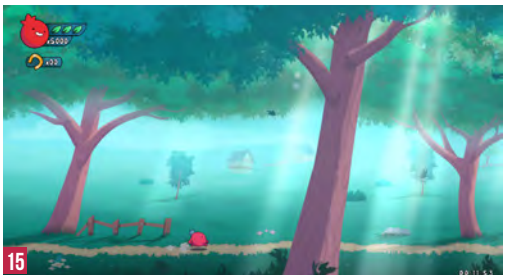
12

BLUEBERRY
MELLOW Games
Germany, 2026
Blueberry is a story-driven puzzle that takes players deep into a woman's mind. Ascend her Tower of Life, relive her key memories, and collect fragments of her self to unlock her mysterious past.

THE LONESOME GUILD
Tiny Bull Studios
Italy, 2025
Embark on an adventure as Ghost, a spirit who wakes to find they hold no memories. The whole world is shrouded by loneliness and the mist just keeps spreading, corrupting everyone in its path.



FISHBOWL
imissmyfriends.studio
India, 2026
Fishbowl is a narrative-driven game about dreams, grief and hope. Rediscover memories and reveal the correct way into the present in this intimate experience where slice-of-life meets the surreal.



REGGIE & HIS COUSIN
degoma
Netherlands, 2026
The fate of the entire universe is in Reggie's hands. Unfortunately, Reggie is just an ordinary person from the 16,000th century, who must now must stop an enormous disaster of colossal dimensions.

MY CANNIBAL FAMILY
Wolf & Wood
UK, 2026
Players are the lurking terror in *My Cannibal Family*. Design and build a twisted theme park, then use traps and stealthy attacks to harvest guests within a deadly sandbox of your own creation.

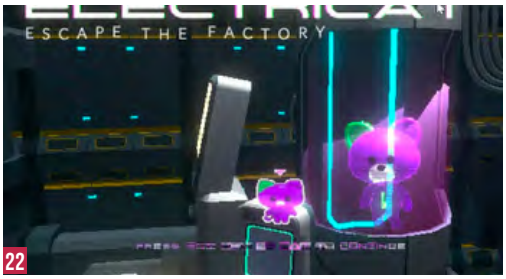
THE AMUSEMENT
Curvature games
Germany, 2026
Sent by her mother to check in on her late father's abandoned amusement park, Samantha is faced with childhood memories, as she uncovers and solves mysteries hidden within the rides.

LOOKING FOR FAEL
Swing Swing Submarine
France, 2026
A narrative puzzle game in which the player sets out to find their roommate. Explore a maze of apartments equipped with a retro game console to solve the enigmatic puzzles Fael left behind.

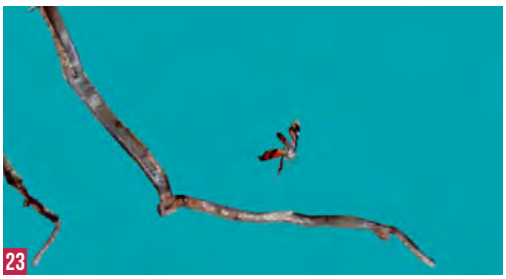
BEYOND THE PLASTIC WALL
Motvind Studio
Sweden, 2026
Hal, a young Scavenger, finds a box of letters written by a woman he doesn't know. She lives within the walls of the last city at the end of the world, so he sets off on a journey to search for her.

WAX HEADS
Patattie Games
UK, 2026
Chat to quirky record store customers with unique tastes, explore a handcrafted record collection, fall in love with bands, or simply slack off with colleagues – whatever gets everyone's groove back.

LESBIAN SIMULATOR
Studio Biarritz
Netherlands, 2025
Lesbian Simulator holds up a mirror to society, highlighting the many blind spots in relation to the acceptance of lesbians and other queer people. It is a colourful ode to love and sexuality.



ELECTRICAT
Shuyi Chen / Shuyi Wu
UK, 2026
In this game, players need to control a cat and interact with the environment through electricity-based mechanics. The objective is to collect three key batteries required to unlock the final exit.



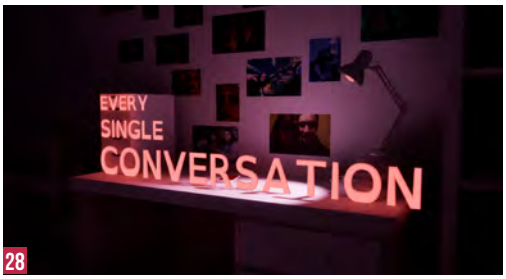
WE ARE DEAD ANIMALS
Frank Bosma
Netherlands, 2025
Bring animals back to life in the virtual paradise created by Tote Tiere Maarten. He collected all the animals he found in his direct surroundings and placed their corpses in his own made paradise.

WHIRLIGHT - NO TIME TO TRIP
imaginarylab
Italy, 2026
Follow Hector, a 1960s inventor, as he discovers a "light-squeezer." His invention sends him to the 1990s, alongside artist Margaret. Together, they navigate through the eras to prevent a catastrophe.

WHEN THE EMBERS WAKE
Llamaplay
Malta, 2026
A woman shares a dream she had, and players enter that dream as a red panda navigating a burning forest. The game weaves a journey that touches on loss, resilience and wildlife preservation.

BLACK JACKET
Mi'pu'mi Games GmbH
Austria, 2026
Black Jacket turns one of the world's most familar games into something entirely new: every suit has unique mechanics, face cards evolve and shifting table effects make each run different.

JOURNEY II ETERNITY
HitherYon Games
USA, 2026
Based on the story by Logan Hamel as well as the record by Pixel Anthem, the game follows Molly and July, two sisters who wake in a dark forest with absolutely no memory of how they got there.

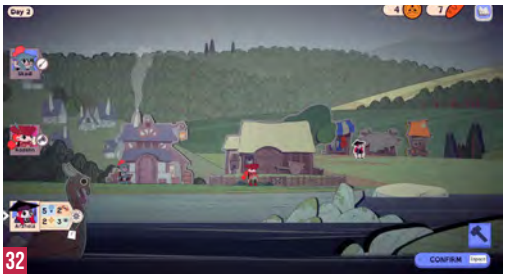


REPEAT AFTER ME: IT'S NOT YOUR FAULT YOU'RE SICK
Eloise Salt
UK, 2026
Repeat After Me is an autobiographical walking simulator with a narrative theme surrounding the mental health impact of living with Type 1 Diabetes, which affects 400,000 people in the UK.

ASHES
Plot Twist
Australia, 2026
After witnessing a murder, 16-year-old skater Azar Warren seeks refuge with her estranged grandfather on his rural compound, only to suspect he may be more dangerous than her pursuers.

KNUCKLE PARADISE
Flying Oak Games
France, 2027
A character action game that stars Jane, a retired boxer, plus her chicken sidekick. Learn combos from a pirate seagull. Fight harder. Level up the chicken. Fight your kidnappers. Teach them a lesson.

LEWIS AND THE BOOK OF SECRETS
Ollie Nalder
UK, 2026
A curiosity-driven 2D platformer game with eight levels, each one with its own unique and distinctive game mechanic. These are used in subversive ways to hide secrets for players to uncover.



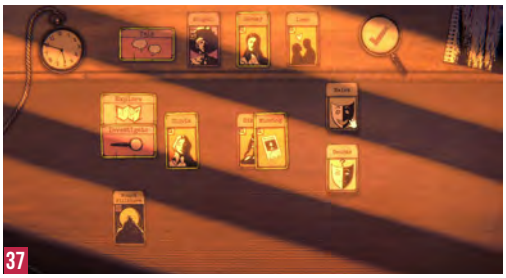
MATELOTES
La Poule Noire
France, 2027
Nobody knows where Pépette, fifth of its name and Hen of the King, has gone. Players will need an adventurous spirit, lots of courage and a big stock of rum to succeed in bringing him home.

HOPE IN THE CITY
Lofty Sky Games
Canada, 2026
Seventeen-year-old Hope Song's future seems clear until she returns home to find her apartment ransacked and her parents missing. Hope decides to begin an investigation of her own.

ROMAN CASTLEFORD UNCOVERED
One to One Development Trust`
UK, 2026
Roman Castleford Uncovered is a journey into the past: a top-down exploration game that lets viewers uncover the hidden stories of Roman Castleford (Lagentium) in West Yorkshire, UK.

OPUS: PRISM PEAK
SIGONO
Taiwan, 2026
Eugene, a weary middle-aged photographer, becomes stranded in the mysterious Dusklands. Travelling with Ren, a girl who has forgotten who she is, Eugene journeys toward a distant mountain.

FORGOTLINGS
Throughline Games
Denmark, 2026
An award-winning cinematic narrative adventure set in a hand-drawn world of living forgotten objects. Players lead Fig and the crew of the Volare through a story of identity, unity and survival.



HILLTHORN
Fool Moon
Canada, 2026
Experience a dark investigation game told entirely through cards. The story unfolds in the player's mind, where every action makes the clock tick forward, and every run can lead to new discoveries.

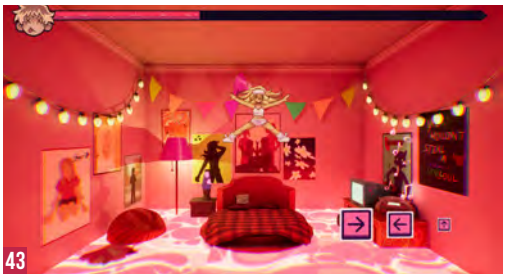
MIO: MEMORIES IN ORBIT
Douze Dixièmes
France, 2026
Play as an android called MIO to explore the Vessel, an enormous technological ark overgrown with machines gone rogue. Uncover its secrets and save the spaceship and its residents from oblivion.

PLEASE, WATCH THE ARTWORK
Thomas Waterzooi
Belgium, 2026
Inspired by the works of American realist painter Edward Hopper, play as a detective who is investigating mysterious anomalies in living paintings at the Museum of Animated Modern Art (MaMA).

BUB
Paperfrog
USA, Italy, 2027
An adventure game about turning your memories into art whilst you still can. Made with slashes of ink and paint and thousands of small cut paper pieces, *Bub* is a deeply personal, crafted world.

UNEMPLOYMENT SIMULATOR 2018
Samuel Lehikoinen
Finland, 2026
This game is based on real experiences of unemployment and depression. Players complete mundane chores, whilst needing to manage their mental health to avoid literal death by boredom.

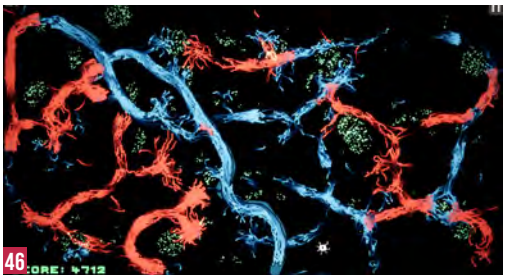
LOOT CONTRACT
Haiyan Cheng / Cheng Fang / Larry Xu
UK, 2026
This is a card-based extraction game. which is driven by a timeline resource system. It is designed to replace mana costs with a time progression to overcome the rigidity of turn-based enemy design.



DEMON SLUMBER PARTY
Whispered Eclipse
UK, 2026
A group of 2000's teenage girls summon a demon to get revenge on Brad; the newly ex-boyfriend of Rae. But their new demonic companion is more keen on taking four souls rather than just one.

LOVE & FOOLS GOLD
Games with DNA
UK, 2027
A Wild West romance narrative adventure, with a horror twist. Play as a bounty hunter, arriving in the town of Cortez Creek to chase a bounty, only to quickly discover that not everything is as it seems.

GATA GURESSI
Elliot George Mann
UK, 2026
Learn how to communicate with the people of Hierre by speaking their languages. Use translation skills to navigate Kallay Tirridor, uncovering its secrets, while solving your brother's disappearance.



HYDRA
Seokwon
UK, 2026
The aim of the game is simple: draw the line and the blue agents will follow. Stay away from the red lines at all costs, they'll infect you. Players are encouraged to develop their own strategies.

REAL VAMPIRES
Those Eyes
Denmark, Poland, 2025
Real Vampires is a darkly humorous game based on 500 years of documented vampire cases from Slavic Eastern Europe, with traces and similarities reaching as far as Canada and Denmark.

FAMILY REUNION
waibinin
Argentina, 2027
Take on the role of a young child sitting at the family dinner table, wanting to be anywhere else. Players must rely on imagination, conversation and exploration skills to make the time pass faster.

MOUSE & CRANE
Those Eyes
Denmark, Canada, 2024
Help friends Mouse and Crane to repair, build and explore their handmade world through solving small, tactile puzzles. This cute game is based in a setting inspired by real harbour environments.

THE EIGHTFOLD PATH
Friendly Llama
Chile, 2024
The path of a Buddhist monk is a path of enlightenment. Find your way through the mystical forest and encounter beautiful creatures, magical places, evil spirits and puzzling challenges.

POCKET PUTT
Field Of Vision
UK, 2026
Pocket Putt is a calm, seated mixed reality mini-golf game created for natural hand tracking. Line up precise shots, sling the ball with intuitive gestures and play compact courses right where you are.

MIDNIGHT MOMENTS
Happy Volcano
Belgium, 2026
A small, cyberpunk diorama-building game where players create cozy rain-soaked backstreets, glowing apartment blocks, or quiet neighbourhood corners. At your own pace. No goals. Just vibes.

THE HERMATIGE
One to One Development Trust
UK, 2025
Rumour says priceless treasure and the ghosts its guardian monks still linger in the locked Hermitage buried beneath an abandoned hospital Play as a paranormal investigator searching for answers.

DISCOVER OUR BRAND NEW PODCAST LOUNGE

Discover the UK's first dedicated Podcasting Lounge at Aesthetica Film Festival – an innovative space where audio storytelling takes centre stage. Curated to spotlight dynamic voices in film, art, tech and culture, this lounge offers the chance to pause and take time out to well and truly listen. It's a new chapter in how stories are shared and heard.

At Aesthetica, we embrace every way of telling stories, and podcasts are a powerful part of our daily lives. From true crime to creative deep-dives, audio is reshaping media. The Podcasting Lounge celebrates this shift, giving audiences and creators a space to engage with ideas beyond the screen.

The Podcast Lounge is in the City Screen Basement.
Free with a Festival Pass.

4-7 November 10:00-21:30
8 November 10:00-18:30

Aesthetica audible

CONNECTION
PODCAST 1

4-7 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-18:30

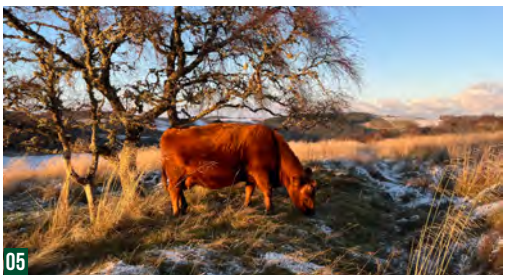
These podcasts invite us to pause and think about the ways we connect. They explore how we communicate, what it means to care for and support others and even how human prayers might look from above. The selection contains five non-fiction and one fiction podcast, each offering a different perspective on connection, compassion, and what it means to be human.

PROBLEMS WITH JULIA MASLI
Talia Augustidis and Julia Masli
UK, 2025, 27:40
There are so many problems in the world. For the past three years, Estonian clown Julia Masli – armed with a microphone taped to a mannequin leg – has been trying to singlehandedly solve them.

THE METAPHOR CONSULTANT
Falling Tree Productions
UK, 2026, 27:43
Metaphor is at the heart of how we understand our existence. In a period of huge change, are we outgrowing them? Poet Jack Underwood is offering his services as a metaphor consultant.

HOLDING THE LINE' FROM WRITTEN IN AIR ISSUE 1
Dennis Funk
USA, UK, 2025, 9:00
In Pittsburgh, many volunteers meet outside reproductive health clinics. While anti-abortion protesters harass people seeking care, these "clinic escorts" help guide those same patients safely inside.

I NEED A MIRACLE
Wireless Theatre Company for Foggy Outline
UK, 2024, 11:41
In this original audio drama podcast, every episode is a prayer. Some are granted and a granted prayer can upend the world. A miraculous yet tumultuous reality is assembled in small glimpses.



JOURNEY THROUGH A COW
Bespoken Media
UK, 2026, 28:00
A farmer, a cheesemaker, a philosopher and a scientist take us on a guided tour through a cow. Told in five acts, this programme take us on a journey from the soil to the inside of the animal.

NIGHT CHORUS
Shira Golden and Jess Shane
USA, 2026, 13:34
In *Night Chorus*, a night walk through an Illinois marsh reveals the bigness of small things. This minature epsiode is part of a wider exploration around midsummer and the summer solstice.

SELF DISCOVERY
PODCAST 2

4-7 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-18:30

Each episode in this compliation provides a portraits of people standing in their power or just trying to figure things out. These podcasts are an ode to self-expression and following your path even when it feels impossible. This series is made up of a combination of real life and fiction, creating a collection of stories about identity, resilience and finding your own way.

JOURNEYS WITH GRACE
Grace "Gig" Ogun
UK, 2024, 31:00
Journeys with Grace is an immersive and self-narrated true story of resilience, ambition and discovery, following an audacious young woman determined to build a career in music against all the odds.

SEE YOU TOMORROW
Darnell Brown
USA< 2026, 13:00
A married mother visits a corner store 27 times in a month – not for what's on the shelves, but for the clerk. A quirky, confessional fantasy about the cost of wanting something just for yourself.

TAROT AND THE ART OF CREATIVITY
Alexandra Quinn
UK, 2026, 28:00
Lean in for a live tarot reading, as four creatives hear the hidden desires driving and affecting their work, artistic output and lives, featuring Adam Martin, Ben Okri, Jessica Knappett and Lola Kirke.

THE BLACK NITE' FROM OF WRITTEN IN AIR ISSUE 1
Craig Eley
USA, 2025, 7:32
Before Stonewall there was the Black Nite, a Milwaukee gay bar where members of the LGBTQ community brawled with a group of homophobic sailors in 1961. This is an audio ode to the location.

SIREN SONG
Kalli Anderson with music by melancholydi
USA, Ukraine, 2024, 7:27
A singer in Ukraine turns traumatic shared experiences into music. During late night strolls in Kyiv, they harmonise to air raid sirens in order to reflect on the role of art and artists during wartime.

MEMORY
PODCAST 3

4-7 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-18:30

Our minds all hold onto experiences, places and people differently – individually shaped by our pasts and how we view the world. These podcasts look to preserve, challenge and change memories, and in one particular case, to use them to bring back the dead. In this selection four non-fiction narratives, asking the vital question: how do memories shape us?

01

DIGITAL GHOST' FROM WRITTEN IN AIR ISSUE 1
Rebecca Nolan, Dennis Funk
USA, UK, Canada, 2025, 28:00
Rebecca's dad died when she was a child and she has attempted to connect with him ever since. She uses his favourite myth, *Orpheus and Eurydice*, to try and bring her dad back from the underworld.

02

THE FOIL
Lil Bit Productions, iHeartPodcasts
USA, 2026, 38:06
When journalist Maya Kroth discovers her father has amassed a sizable YouTube following based on his newfound belief in aliens, it throws her relationship – and her beliefs – into chaos.

03

ANGLIA SQUARE: THE LITTLE CITY (EPISODE 1: THE ART OF THE DEAL)
Sarah Herman
UK, 2025, 32:40
In Norwich, a dilapidated 1960s development is facing demolition and regeneration. But what about the residents, the local artists losing their studio and the businesses forced to shut their doors?

04

ONE MINUTE REMAINING - STORIES FROM THE INMATES
Jack Laurence
Australia, 2025, 32:00
Dwight Bergeron has spent 30 years in prison for child abuse, despite there being no physical evidence. His now adult children have withdrawn their statements, claiming they were coerced.

AESTHETICA FILM FESTIVAL 2027

SUBMIT PODCASTS

OPENS 1 DECEMBER 2026

Find out more: **asff.co.uk**

MYSTERY
PODCAST 4

4-7 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-21:30

8 NOVEMBER
City Screen Basement
10:00-18:30

From musicals to horror, with a stop off at true crime along the way, these podcasts have a tale to tell, inviting you into their worlds and keeping you curious about what will happen next. The acclaimed *City of Lights* is about the reality of life after a crime, whilst Mark Ramsey's *Detour* takes inspiration from the likes of Stephen King, Guillermo del Toro and James Wan.

01

THE REALITY SHAPER: A MUSICAL PODCAST
Sair Kaufman
UK, 2026, 34:00
Guardsman Boris Dragonheart and his best friend Travis are dispatched with the goal of stopping a robbery, but Boris' world is upended when the 'robber' unearths something unexpected.

02

WINE NIGHT
Julia Hoff & Katarina Hughes
USA, 2025, 31:04
At a wine night, Kelen Brooks and her three besties stumble upon a murder mystery. It leads them on a Chardonnay-soaked quest, uncovering secrets about the town they thought they knew well.

03

TALES FROM THE SINGING PORCH: THE SALESMAN
Joe Blanchard and Maya Reter
USA, 2026, 19:30
Little Klaus Apero knows that it'll be a hard winter for his village. Animals are going missing and villagers are looking for answers. When a charming salesman comes to town, everything changes.

04

CITY OF LIGHTS
Willy Nast
USA, 2026, 37:34
In the first instalment of this six-part, three-hour long series, host Willy Nast visits Aurora, Illinois, to interview the parents of Jeff Signorelli, who was murdered in 2002 in a random act of violence.

05

THE DRAGONING
Willy Nast
USA, 2025, 22:38
Amanda describes multiple scenarios featuring dragon attacks by women. She's pitching them as part of a television series that wants to hire the boyfriend of the world's most famous dragon.

06

DARK SANCTUM: DETOUR
Mark Ramsey Media
USA, 2024, 19:00
A man racing home to repay a debt is detoured, risking the lives of his wife and young daughter. Can he save them before time runs out? Part of *Dark Sanctum*, the award-winning audio fright-fest.

GUEST PROGRAMME

Cinema provides a unique space where we can step into the lives and perspectives of others. In this strand, we invite curators from around the globe to connect with audiences and share their viewpoints through specially crafted programmes.

This year, we're thrilled to feature major organisations including Aardman and *The Guardian*. These true trailblazers in contemporary filmmaking present narratives that expand cinematic representation, sharing stories from multiple walks of life and reflecting the human experience from new angles.

These films provide a powerful opportunity to see the world through someone else's eyes, immersing you in perspectives that challenge your own. In doing so, you'll explore new cultures, ideas and landscapes. Sit back and enjoy the journey.

CLASSICS FROM THE AARDMAN ARCHIVE

Generations of people have grown up with Aardman's colourful creations, from Wallace and Gromit's first foray to the moon, to the daring escapades of *Chicken Run* or the hilarious animal interviews in *Creature Comforts*. This programme brings together the most beloved characters from over the years, spotlighting everything that makes Aardman's films so beloved. Curl up with some pets to debate whether dogs or cats are superior; follow Shaun's flock as they fight to save their beloved tree; and dive into the thrilling heist of Feathers McGraw.

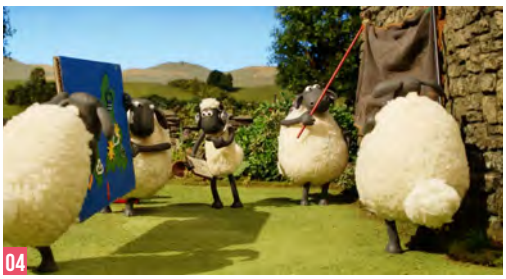
THURSDAY 5 NOVEMBER
York Theatre Main House
10:00-11:00

AARDMAN

CREATURE COMFORTS: CATS OR DOGS
Richard Goleszowski
UK, 2003, 9:00
What do dogs think about Crufts? Do cats like cuddles, and who makes the better burglar alarm? Take a ringside seat as the two most popular pets take part in a battle that's raged for centuries.

CREATUE COMFORTS: PETS AT THE VETS
Richard Goleszowski
UK, 2003, 9:00
A Piranha with toothache, a pig with sunstroke, a dog with a bad aversion to feet and a monkey who loves injections. Take a peek behind the door at under the weather pets in the waiting room.

SHAUN THE SHEEP: SAVE THE TREE
JP Vine
UK, 2007, 7:00
Shaun's flock lives a peaceful life on a farm. But the farmer wants to turn the tree in their field into firewood, and the flock must take desperate measures to stop their beloved tree getting the chop.



SHAUN 3DTV
Lee Wilton
UK, 2014, 7:00
The Farmer is excited by his new purchase. He calls on sheepdog Bitzer to set up his new TV, while he readies himself to watch life in 3D. To his surprise, it's more 3D than he could ever have imagined.

WALLACE & GROMIT TWT
Nick Park
UK, 1993, 30:00
Wallace rents their spare room to a mysterious penguin named Feathers McGraw, who quickly frames Gromit, and uses Wallace's automated "Techno Trousers" to commit a diamond museum heist.

50 YEARS OF AARDMAN ANIMATION

This year, legendary British animation studio Aardman celebrates five decades of claymation storytelling. To mark the milestone, enjoy shorts that feature some of the studio's most beloved characters – including Wallace and Gromit and Feathers McGraw – as well as iconic series like *Creature Comforts*. These beloved works are joined by newer projects from its Stop Motion Foundation, a development programme led by award-winning talent. This programme is a tour through the wonderful world of stop motion, led by the very best in the field.

FRIDAY 6 NOVEMBER
York Theatre Main House
11:30-12:30

AARDMAN

GOING EQUIPPED
Peter Lord
UK, 1990, 5:20
A young man, who has spent half of his life in penal institutions, reflects on life inside and outside prison. In an articulate interview he speaks with clarity, irony and humour about his criminal career.

IDENT
Richard Starzak
UK, 1990, 5:03
A couple sit in their living room and watch an advertisement for a silly vegetable soup company called Shuperts, informing them of a wacky sweepstake involving a vegetable-themed cruise.

ADAM
Peter Lord
UK, 1991, 6:15
When God realises that the first man he ever created is lonely, he makes him a friend. Adam, expecting it to be Eve, gets himself ready as if for a date only to find out his new friend is a penguin.

OFF BEAT
Will Becher
UK, 2006, 3:17
When a news report about a police holiday causes a big stir, one viewer considers this the perfect opportunity for a crime without punishment and sets off on a mission to steal his neighbour's TV.

CREATURE COMFORTS
Nick Park
UK, 1990, 5:05
A series of interviews with the various global animals in an English zoo. Used to open spaces and sunnier climates, they all comment on accommodation, diet and, of course, the grey English weather.

PREY
Pax Nelson
USA, 2025, 3:25
Following an unfortunate car accident, Devin suddenly finds himself face-to-face with a vengeful moose on an unstoppable rampage, who will go to any lengths to try and hunt him down.

BLIND DATE
Carter Bazar
USA, 2022, 1:28
Blind Date offers a glimpse into the complex and ever-changing world of dating. The process is made all the more complicated when you are an insect navigating instinct, survival and attraction.

BEFORE LONG
Julia Schmidt
Germany, 2025, 4:11
A young mother sets off to flee her country. After a dangerous escape with a baby in tow, she starts settling in but is soon faced with having to decide between her son's and her parents' future.

GLOWBERRY
Jessica Fisher
USA, 2025, 4:44
In the Raspberry Village, creatures camouflaged as raspberries have the special ability to glow – except for Rubus Baneberry. The young mischevious berry sets off to discover how to glow.

MRI
Dougal Vecqueray
UK, 2025, 3:46
A patient named Tom goes for an MRI scan only to be transported into a wild psychedelic space odyssey halfway through, after the contrast dye he was injected with begins to spread across his body.

SILICONE MURPHY VS THE ORB
Ben Nightingale
UK, 2025, 1:08
Somewhere in deep space, a down-and-out bounty hunter briefly stops on an unknown planet to fix his rust-bucket ship, again. There he suddenly stumbles upon the opportunity of a lifetime.

CARPE
Amelia Dickson
USA, 2025, 3:38
When a woman returns home with her groceries, she receives an unwanted surprise from the fish she brought home for her supper. Before long, she's forced to take matters into her own hands.

13

GONE QUACKERS
Annie Buckeridge
UK, 2026, 4:22
An oddball farmer with a passion for taxidermy encounters three orphaned ducklings. Following some initial resistance he decides to take them into his home, only to meet a twisted end.

14

PITMATIC
Ben Nightingale
UK, 2026, 0:32
Pitmatic takes place 100 years ago in one County Durham coal mine, where miners speak in a distinct dialect. One man imagines the future of energy with his pit pony and canary co-workers.

15

WALLACE & GROMIT'S CRACKING CONTRAPTIONS: THE SNOOZATRON
Merlin Crossingham, Andy Symanowski, Ian Whitlock
UK, 2002, 2:10
Getting to sleep can be a challenge when you eat as much cheese as Wallace. His solution is the "Snoozatron." For Gromit, his part in the machine's running is a regular chore he could do without.

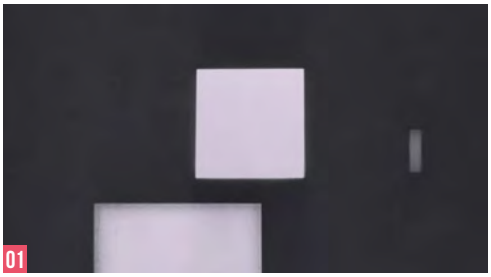
MASTERCLASS: CELEBRATING 50 YEARS WITH AARDMAN ANIMATION

Enjoyed this exclusive opportunity to look back on 50 remarkable years of Aardman Animation? Now is your opportunity to join Will Becher, Director and Creative at Aardman, in a masterclass that celebrates five decades of beloved characters – from Wallace and Gromit to Shaun the Sheep and Feathers McGraw.

6 November, 13:00 | **York Theatre Royal Main House** Register for a place | asff.co.uk

RADICAL LISTENING: NEW SCORES TO SILENT FILMS

Silent cinema was never truly silent. Early film screenings were often accompanied by live musicians, improvised sound and audience participation. With this commission, Aesthetica and Audible invite composers and sound designers to rediscover that tradition and bring it into the modern era. As part of the Listening Pitch 2026: Radical Listening, this open call asked artists to create inventive new scores for pre-1925 silent films. Each selected artist received a £1,000 grant to create their score, transforming early cinema into something for the contemporary age that celebrates the harmony of film and music.

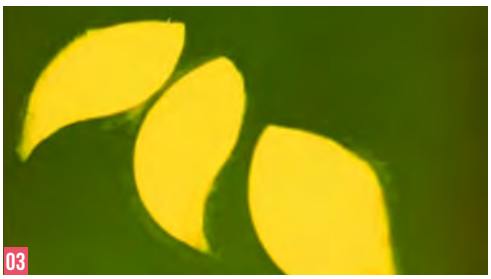


RYTHMUS 21
Bowen Wu
UK, 2026, 2:59

Rythmus 21 is a black-and-white silent film from Dadaist Hans Richter. It centres around the movement of forms across space, rhythm, and the relationship that is created by that movement.

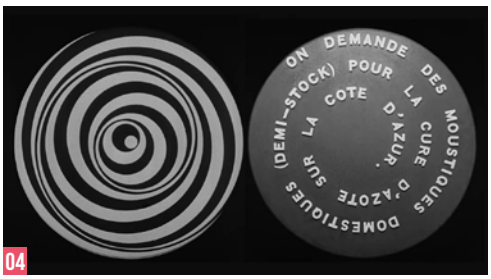
SYMPHONIE DIAGONALE
Théo DG
UK, 2026, 7:28

Taking inspiration from electronic, neoclassical and cinematic music, this reimagined score creates a unique soundscape that follows the subtle changes of shape and mood of the visuals.



OPUS I II III IV
Amelie Lingard
UK, 2026, 11:43

Lingard's experimental sound design brings together sampled pianos and violins that work alongside the visual movement of the 1921 film, *Lichtspiel Opus*, made by Walther Ruttmann.

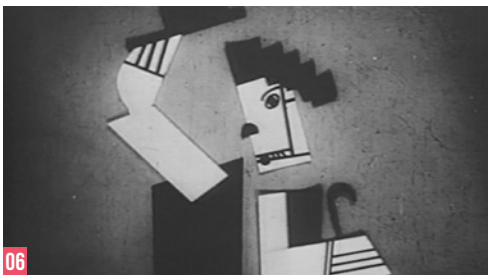


ANÉMIC CINÉMA
Chloe Simmons
UK, 2026, 6:23

Anémic Cinéma is a 1926 surrealist French experimental film from Marcel Duchamp, constructed by filming nine rotating cardboard disks with spirals drawn on them inscribed with puns.

THE GREAT TRAIN ROBBERY
Aidan Steele
UK, 2026, 13:44

Live instrumentals and found sounds are blended together to accompany what is considered to be the first ever narrative film, *The Great Train Robbery*, directed by Edwin S. Porter in 1963.



BALLET MÉCANIQUE
Fintan O'Hare
UK, 2026, 16:30

A self-playing mechanical instrument, consisting of sixteen motors on a free standing vertical frame, will perform a live score to the 1924 film by Fernand Léger, *Ballet Mécanique*.

LISTENING PITCH: FILM PREMIERES

Now in its sixth year, Aesthetica x Audible's The Listening Pitch is a cinematic exploration of what is unheard. For the 2026 edition, we are considering listening as a radical act. Funding was awarded to three visionary filmmakers: Duncan Cowles, Hermione Spriggs and Tobi Kyeremateng & Sofia Cissé Akel. We will also screen one of the previous winning projects from last year, *Voice Shift* by Roberto Duque. A filmmaker Q&A will follow the screenings.

Friday 6 November. Venue: City Screen, YO1 9QL.

- **Arrival from 18:45 I Screening starts at 19:00**
- **Free with Festival Pass, but booking is essential**
- **DJ, Drinks and Networking from 21:00**

VOICE SHIFT

Roberto Duque
UK, 2025

2025 Listening Pitch winner *Voice Shift* follows trans femme individuals as they seek a voice that reflects their gender identity. Guided by a trans vocal coach, the film weaves together stories from different stages of their journeys. This is a story of identity, resilience and the wider social and political weight of a person's voice.

WORM GRUNTING

Hermione Spriggs
UK, 2026

"Charming", "grunting", "fiddling" or "rooping" is a method of luring earthworms up from the ground using sound and vibration. In the UK, the practice has taken a competitive turn. *Worm Grunting* plunges the audience into the sensory world of worms, who have no eyes or ears but listen instead through their whole-body cochlea.

FRIDAY 6 NOVEMBER
City Screen 2 YO1 9QL
19:00-23:00

Aesthetica audible

NIBCLOUT

Duncan Cowles
UK, 2026

A filmmaker discovers a 1964 casette recording of his great-grandfather reciting a Scots poem, but the thick Scots dialect makes it difficult to understand. Curious to decipher the audio, he travels to Blyth Bridge, where the poem was first written. There, he plays the cassette to residents, who are invited to interpret what they can hear.

CISSÉ-CEESAY

Tobi Kyerematenge, Sofia Cissé Akel
UK, 2026

Historian Sofia Cissé Akel travels to Southern Senegal to trace her family through traditional musical storytelling. Touré, a village elder, introduces Sofia to a Griot who can help her recall the lineage of her family name, Cissé. The process reconnects a family that was once disconnected across historic colonial borders.

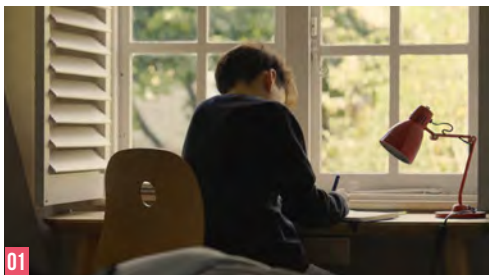
LIVE DJ PERFORMANCE

Sound & Beats
City Screen

Prepare to be swept away by a wave of sonic magic as a live DJ turns City Screen into a pulsating playground of rhythm and movement. This immersive experience invites you to dive deep into a rich tapestry of sound where every beat, drop and melody will awaken your senses and elevate your night to unforgettable heights.

CELEBRATING 10 YEARS OF GUARDIAN DOCUMENTARIES

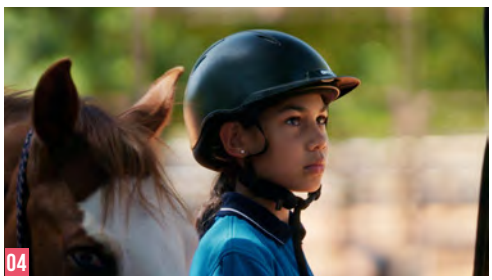
To mark 10 years of its award-winning strand, Guardian Documentaries presents a screening of four coming-of-age films. Spanning the UK, US and Australia, they follow young people grappling with the world they've inherited – from the climate emergency and social media exploitation to mental health and caring responsibilities – placing their lived experience at the centre of the story. In a current moment when young people often receive negative headlines, these films are vital in placing authentic voices at the centre of this narrative.



PRISON LETTERS
George MacCallum
UK, 2026, 19:00
Teenager Max struggles with climate anxiety, and writes to imprisoned activists. He's eager to know the people behind direct action, and why so many climate protesters are in prison.

IS MUM OK?
Rosie Morris
UK, 2026, 15:00
Aiden has been a carer for his mum for over half his life. Every few weeks, Aiden and other young carers like him get to enjoy a rare night off thanks to tenacious council worker, Satvinder.

GIVE ME SHELTER
Tom Silverstone
USA, 2025, 19:00
Tina Frundt is a top specialist in protecting children from sex trafficking. She works with law enforcement, social workers and parents to help America's vulnerable children to feel safe again.



PRESSURE AND RELEASE
Pete Ward
Australia, 2024, 27:00
An Australian community has been devastated by the suicides of several young Aboriginal people. Professor Juli Coffin uses her horses to create connections between animal and human.

SIX STORIES OF SELF-DISCOVERY

We all look for answers to questions big and small: from what we'll eat for dinner to the meaning of life. Sometimes, travelling through the world or reflecting on our own experiences can lead us towards the solutions – but they may not be the ones we hope to find. This conundrum is at the centre of these six films, which examine what it means to look inwards and ask ourselves who we are, what we value and what we want from life. Each one is a profound opportunity to step into another person's shoes and see the world from a entirely different perspective.

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01

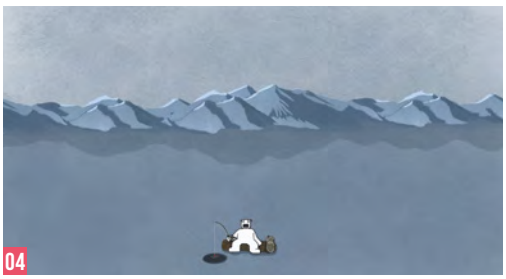
IDIA
Winifred Iguwa
UK, 2026, 22:16
After being ridiculed for wanting the principal role in a dance performance, an aspiring dancer tries turning to her cultural heritage to find the full strength needed to pursue her dreams.

02

REALITY
Kiera Atkinson
UK, 2026, 2:53
Join May in an animated interview that explores derealisation, taking viewers on a deeply personal visual journey through her mind, revealing the emotional realities behind the experience.

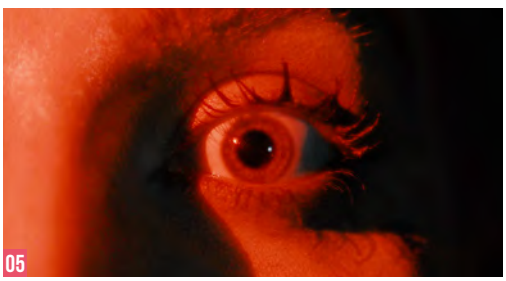
03

RACING THE ODDS
Matthew Birtles
UK, 2026, 12:20
Former professional cyclist Harry Tanfield shares his journey to the elite level of the sport, and how British Cycling both did and didn't help, with calls for change often falling on deaf ears.



04

HOOK, LINE AND SINKING
Naomi Younger
UK, 2026, 5:36
Left alone in the vast expanse of the Arctic, a lonely polar bear embarks on a pilgrimage across frozen landscapes in search of something he cannot find beneath the endless ice sheets – fish.



05

FACES
Luke Headland
UK, 2026, 10:01
A young girl retreats to the English countryside to escape her troubled past, only to find that her trauma comes back to haunt her in more ways than one, with truly unsettling consequences.

06

THE LAST PLACE ON EARTH
Harley Gregory
UK, 2026, 5:42
Ellie faces the horrors of living through her 20s. Her relationships with the people around her are pushed to their very limits, whilst she attempts to break free from the confinements of mundanity.

IT'S TIME TO MAKE A CHOICE

In these thought-provoking, funny and visually striking short films, students at Regent's University London present their characters with pivotal choices. Some decisions might make their lives better – others, worse. There are individuals who must choose whether get out of a difficult situation, or get into a stickier one. Others are picking between career advancement, or a job change. Some have the bright idea to cover up a terrible mistake. Or perhaps they should do deal with a demon? Sometimes the best option isn't the most obvious one.

THURSDAY 6 NOVEMBER
City Screen 2
12:00-13:00

REGENT'S
UNIVERSITY LONDON

APARTMENT 666
Joey Blanco
UK, 2026, 13:50

Down, depressed and double-crossed, Jamie is given a book that summons Dylan, a demon who will smite anyone Jamie pleases. The two become embroiled in a toxic relationship.

NINO
Aurelien Attinger
UK, 2026, 5:20

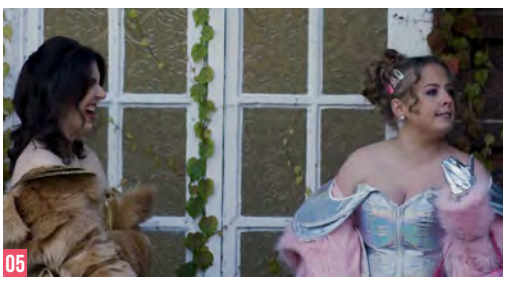
A troubled but talented young songwriter decides to battle his Obsessive Compulsive Disorder through music, but as the song develops his compulsive behaviours begin to take over.

DEAD SILENT
Simão Baroseiro
UK, 2026, 11:15

When their infant daughter is found dead in her cot, Christian and Daisy face unrelenting grief. As the truth surfaces, it becomes clear that the tragedy may not be as accidental as first appeared.

MORYOW
Ted Wilkes
UK, 2026, 15:23

A recovering addict, desperate to escape her past, finds herself on a cursed fishing boat headed into a Lovecraftian nightmare, where the depths of the ocean feast upon her darkest sins.



SOFT BLOWS
Lucia Diaz Losantos
UK, 2026, 13:00

Porn actress Lola injures her co-star in a pillow-fighting scene. She has to attend a health and safety class, where the instructor sees potential for Lola to become a champion pillow-fighter.

MASTERCLASSES & PANEL DISCUSSIONS

HEAR FROM WORLDCLASS INDUSTRY SPEAKERS.

This year's festival features an exciting selection of thought-provoking panel discussions and masterclasses. All sessions take place in person from 4-7 November. Masterclasses are included with your In Person Festival Pass, but **online pre-booking is required for all events**. Please note: single screening tickets do not grant access to masterclasses. To ensure you don't miss out, we recommend booking your masterclasses in advance due to high demand and limited availability. Book at **asff.co.uk/events**. Education group tickets are valid only for specific, pre-booked itineraries.

VFX WITH ACADEMY AWARD-WINNING FRAMESTORE

Framestore is an Academy Award-winning visual effects house that has worked on some of the biggest film releases of recent times. Their recent credits include titles such as *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*, *Wicked* and the upcoming *Avengers: Doomsday*. In this masterclass, Virtual Production Supervisor Connor Ling and Realtime Supervisor Michael Zaman will take a deep dive into the 1,100 visual effects shots Framestore produced for Project Hail Mary. This is a chance to learn about Framestore's signature style of character animation – a delightful blend of CG and puppetry.

FRAMESTORE

Date & Time:
4 November | 10:30

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

MICHAEL ZAMAN / CONNOR LING

FINDING YOUR DIRECTORIAL VOICE: FILMMAKERS IN CONVERSATION

Our favourite directors all have a signature style. Whether it's colour palettes, framing, soundtrack choices, or the way they handle genre. So, how do you find your own unique voice? Meet Aisha Boudjillouli, Benedict Cohen, Chi Thai, Lisa Kenney and Varun Raman as they talk about the process of cultivating a unique filmmaking identity that sticks. Learn how they have honed their own style over multiple projects. Plus, gain key advice across shorts and features. This panel is chaired by Professor Steve Rawle, from York St John University.

Est. 1841 YORK ST JOHN UNIVERSITY

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
4 November | 10:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

STEVE RAWLE / LISA KENNEY / BENEDICT COHEN
CHI THAI / AISHA BOUDJILLOULI / VARUN RAMAN

IN OTHER WORLDS: FILM AND FUTURE WORLD-BUILDING

Join curator Luke Kemp for a masterclass exploring *In Other Worlds*, Liam Young's ambitious immersive exhibition at the Barbican that brings together film, speculative design, climate science and future-thinking. The session will unpack how world-building can become a powerful storytelling tool, shaping perspectives on technology, society and the environment. Discover how cinematic narratives, soundscapes and speculative futures can inspire creatives to move beyond dystopian thinking and imagine possibilities for tomorrow.

barbican

Date & Time:
4 November | 12:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

LUKE KEMP

THE ROLE OF THE CAMERA OPERATOR

Andor. The Mandalorian. The Night Manager. Wuthering Heights. The Association of Camera Operators works across feature film, TV drama and commercial production. Here, five members come together to explore what it takes to work behind the camera. The session focuses on various aspects of cinematography, such as staging action, choreographing complex scenes, composition and framing. They will also examine the organisational side of the role, plus technological developments that are reshaping the industry.

ACO
association of camera operators

Date & Time:
4 November | 12:00

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

ASSOCIATION OF CAMERA OPERATORS

A LEGACY ON FILM
THE STORY OF RIDLEY SCOTT ASSOCIATES

Alien. Blade Runner. Gladiator. Ridley Scott Associates (RSA) was founded by Ridley and Tony Scott in 1968 and is the creative force behind iconic films. Meet Luke Scott, a multi-award-winning director and the CEO of the Ridley Scott Creative Group. Scott's feature debut *Morgan* starred Anya Taylor-Joy and Kate Mara. Recently, he was second unit director for *Gladiator II*. He will explore how RSA has navigated five decades of change across film, TV and advertising, and how its is shaping the next generation of young storytellers.

RSA

Date & Time:
4 November | 12:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Main House

LUKE SCOTT /JIM CAMPBELL

FROM BROADCAST TO STREAMING:
PRODUCING TV IN THE UK TODAY

The way we watch TV has shifted, from appointment-based viewing to on-demand streaming. Meet the producers of the most-watched shows of recent times, on Apple TV, Disney+, and Netflix. Rachelle Constant joins us from Clerkenwell, the company behind *Baby Reindeer*. She speaks with Sam Tipper-Hale, of Raw (Trainwreck), Eileen Flanagan at Big Talk Studios (Ludwig) and Tom Thorpe-Moran, Freelance Production and Post Production Manager (Sex Education) joined in discussion by Chris Curley from Pact.

raw CF bigtalk pact.

Date & Time:
4 November | 13:30

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

AILEEN FLANAGAN / RACHELLE CONSTANT
CHRIS CURLEY / SAM TIPPER-HALE / TOM THORPE-MORAN

STORYTELLING IN GAMES: CRAFTING NARRATIVE ACROSS PLATFORMS

The line between films and games is becoming increasingly blurred. But developing interactive stories needs a specific skillset, including anticipating diverging narrative pathways and the player's decisions. In this session, you'll discover how indie gems and AAA titles are redefining storytelling. This masterclass features Jamie Stefton from Game Republic; Adonis Emmanuel, Rocksteady Games (*Batman: Arkham Asylum*); Alrissa Sia, Lucid Games (*Star Wars Jedi: Survivor*) and Katherine Bidwell, from State of Play Games (*Lumino City*).

GAMEREPUBLIC · rocksteady · Est. 1841 YORK ST JOHN UNIVERSITY · STATE OF PLAY. · Lucid

Date & Time:
4 November | 13:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

ADONIS EMMANUEL / MATT COWARD-GIBBS
ALRISSA SIA / KATHERINE BIDWELL / JAMIE SEFTON

FILM4: FROM SHORTS TO FEATURES

Film4 is Channel 4's feature film division, dedicated to developing and co-financing bold, original work from the most distinctive voices in UK and international cinema. Across four decades, it has supported many of the most ground-breaking and successful UK films, including *Poor Things, Zone of Interest, The Banshees of Inisherin* and *All of us Strangers*. Join Development Executive Alice Whittemore in conversation with Sion Thomas (*Mauled by a Dog*), as they discuss the process of taking films from short to feature-length.

FILM4

Date & Time:
4 November | 13:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Main House

ALICE WHITTEMORE / SION THOMAS

MEET COMMISSIONERS FROM BBC, CHANNEL 5, ITV AND SKY

What are commissioners really looking for? This is an opportunity to get insights from the UK's leading broadcasters, who create, fund and distribute TV shows, films, documentaries and entertainment. They will explore what it takes to get a "green light", from delivering a standout pitch to understanding the trends driving the industry forward. Hear fascinating insights from Benedetta Pinelli (Sky), Paul Testar (Channel 5), Alice Ramsey (BBC) and Callum Dziedzic (ITV). Session chaired by Caroline Cooper Charles of Screen Yorkshire.

Date & Time:
4 November | 15:00

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

CAROLINE COOPER CHARLES / PAUL TESTAR
CALLUM DZIEDZIC / ALICE RAMSEY / BENEDETTA PINELLI

DRIVING INCLUSION AT ITV: DIVERSITY, EQUITY AND REPRESENTATION

How do you turn commitment to inclusion into industry change? Nahrein Kemp, DEI & Talent Lead at ITV, has spent over 20 years doing exactly that. She leads on pioneering programmes such as Amplify, Step Up 60 and Fresh Cuts – the BAFTA-nominated strand giving underrepresented creatives their first broadcast credits. In this masterclass, Kemp unpacks how these initiatives are built, what meaningful structural change looks like, and what it takes to move from intention to measurable impact within a major broadcaster.

Date & Time:
4 November | 15:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

NAHREIN KEMP

MAKING *PUFFIN ROCK*: CRAFTING ANIMATION FOR YOUNG AUDIENCES

The animated children's series *Puffin Rock* was streamed on Netflix for more than 26.7 million hours in 2024. It follows a young puffin named Oona and her brother Baba. Narrated by Chris O'Dowd, and set on a beautiful Irish island, the show explores nature, friendship and family. We are joined by John McDaid, Creative Director at Dog Ears and Producer of the programme, for a masterclass in making animation for young viewers. Learn more about *Puffin Rock*'s lush visual style, gentle storytelling and roots in Kilkenny and Derry.

Dog Ears

Date & Time:
4 November | 16:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

JOHN MCDAID

INSIDE PODCASTING: CUTTING THROUGH THE NOISE

Global podcast listenership is rising, with audiences expected to reach over 650 million by 2027. Yet with around 4.5 million podcasts available the landscape is more competitive than ever. So how do you cut through? Our panel of industry experts – award-winning producer Meera Kumar, Nicky Anderson (Stak) and Millie Chu (Mindhouse) – will be joined by chair Holly Newson to discuss the current state of podcasting: where it's headed, how to develop an idea, what makes an engaging host, and how to grow an audience.

MINDHOUSE Stak.

Date & Time:
4 November | 16:30

Venue:
City Screen Basement

HOLLY NEWSON / MEERA KUMAR
MILLIE CHU / NICKY ANDERSON

TRUTH ON SCREEN: HOW TO MAKE A STANDOUT DOCUMENTARY

Demand for documentaries skyrocketed 44% between 2021 and 2023. In a world of misinformation, nonfiction films and docu-series cut to the truth, giving access to people and places often off-limits. Chaired by Hannah Bush Bailey, Doc Society, this panel welcomes Poonam Odedra (Blast Films), Steff Boulton (DSP Films), Samantha Fernandes (Nutopia) as well as Tom Porter (Britespark). They discuss: what makes a great piece of non-fiction media? Why do viewers keep coming back for more? Have we now reached the saturation point?

Date & Time:
5 November | 10:00

Venue: York
York Theatre Royal Studio

HANNAH BUSH BAILEY / POONAM ODEDRA
SAMANTHA FERNANDES / STEFF BOULTON / TOM PORTER

NEAL STREET PRODUCTIONS: THE MAKING OF AWARD-WINNING STORIES

Neal Street Productions is one of the UK's most respected production companies, set up by Sam Mendes (*1917, Skyfall*), Pippa Harris and Caro Newling. This session is about how to bring a film to life. Chaired by Director Nick Brown, and drawing on their adaptation of Enid Blyton's *The Magic Faraway Tree,* the panel features producer Danny Perkins (Former CEO of Studiocanal UK), Ann Maskrey (Costume Designer) and Ruslan Borysov (VFX Supervisor). They will speak on everything from the creative process to development and finance.

Date & Time:
5 November | 10:00

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

ANN MASKREY/ DANNY PERKINS
RUSLAN BORYSOV / NICK BROWN

A SHARED VISION: THE CRAFT OF COLLABORATIVE FILMMAKING

We've all heard the phrase "no man is an island", and it's as true of film as it is any other creative discipline. Every shot is the product of collaboration, exchange and compromise. This panel features five Official Selection filmmakers Ian Bruce, Kofi Ntiforo, Makenna Guyler, Millie Chen and Tom Oliver. They will speak about how to balance your vision with the practicalities of getting the job done: when to say yes, when to say no, and how to meet in the middle. Chaired by award-winning artist, director and actor Pamela Jikiemi.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
5 November | 11:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

PAMELA JIKIEMI / MILLIE CHEN / KOFI NTIFORO
MAKENNA GUYLER / TOM OLIVER / IAN BRUCE

IDEA TO GREENLIGHT: BRINGING YOUR STORY TO LIFE

How do you take your project from a script to screen? This panel discussion breaks down the process of getting your film off the ground. You will hear from four of the UK's leading production companies, working across both film and TV. This session brings together Channel 4's Danyele Seigornet; Lola Oliyide of Neal Street Productions (*Hamnet*, *1917*, *Revolutionary Road*) and Laura Timms from Studio Lambert (*The Traitors, Gogglebox, Race Across the World*). Chaired by Chris Curley (Head of Nations and Regions, Pact)

NEALSTREET
4 pact.

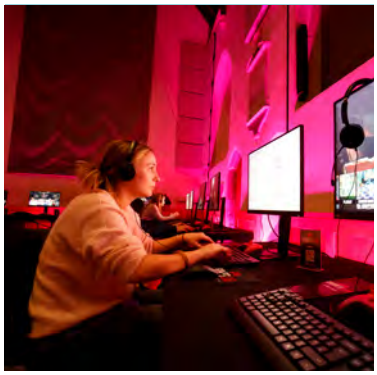
Date & Time:
5 November | 11:30

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

CHRIS CURLEY / LAURA TIMMS
DANYELE SEIGORNET / LOLA OLIYIDE

GAMES IN FOCUS: INSIDE A RAPIDLY EVOLVING INDUSTRY

Ubisoft, EA, Altered Gene and Activision are two of the most recognisable companies in gaming, whilst BFI is a key name in film – now embracing video games as screen culture. Aesthetica brings them together, for a discussion with York St John University's Jack Denham. Hear from Tom Knights (Senior Narrative Design, Ubisoft Reflections), Des Gayle (Founder of Altered Gene), Caroline Trujillo of Criterion (Battlefield 6) and Anna Mansi (Director of Video Games & Certification, BFI), as they discuss the evolving world of games.



Date & Time:
5 November | 13:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

ANNA MANSI / JACK DENHAM
CAROLINE TRUJILLO / TOM KNIGHTS / DES GAYLE

BBC FILM: THE NEXT GENERATION

BBC Film is known for making distinctive British films with range and ambition, including recent releases such as *Hamlet*, *My Father's Shadow* and *Sentimental Value*. As well as collaborating with some of the industry's most revered writers and directors, BBC Film is committed to finding, nurturing and developing new talent. Radha Bhandari, Development Executive, sits down with rising directors Karima Sammout-Kanellopoulou and Lisa Kenney to discuss their inspirations, ideas, current projects and hopes for the future.

Date & Time:
5 November | 13:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Main House

RADHA BHANDRI / LISA KENNEY
KARIMA SAMMOUT-KANELLOPOULOU

THE PRODUCER'S ROLE: SHAPING STORIES BEHIND THE CAMERA

Join us for a peek behind the curtain, and discover what producers do to make projects happen – creatively, logistically and financially. Learn from four industry experts who will guide you through their roles. Meet Damian Jones, DJ Films (*The Iron Lady*, *Lady In The Van*); Joy Gharoro-Akpojotor, Joi Productions (*Dreamers*, *Blue Story*); Lucy Drury (Senior Production Executive, Element Pictures); and Pinky Ghundale, Producer of Academy and Turner Prize-winning artist and director Steve McQueen. Chaired by Lorianne Hall, University of York.

Date & Time:	Venue:	
5 November	13:00	Yorkshire Museum	DAMIAN JONES / LUCY DRURY / LORIANNE HALL JOY GHARORO-AKPOJOTOR / PINKY GHUNDALE

A DIRECTING MASTERCLASS: IN CONVERSATION WITH MARK JENKIN

Mark Jenkin's 2019 breakout, *Bait* – hailed by Empire Magazine as "a rare find that is a truly original feature by a British director" – established him as a defining voice in contemporary cinema. Since then, the director has released two further features, developing his own strand of haunting folk horror in *Enys Men* and this year's *Rose of Nevada*. A prolific maker of short films, he often serves as cinematographer and editor on his own projects. The session will be chaired by director and 2026 Aesthetica award winner, Bec Evans.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:	Venue:	
5 November	14:30	York Theatre Royal Mainhouse	MARK JENKIN / BEC EVANS

THE FUTURE OF XR: ENTERTAINMENT AND BEYOND

When VR headsets arrived in the mid-to-late 2010s, it was believed they would be as common as TVs. Whilst that hasn't happened, we are seeing XR technologies being adopted for a number of equally mindblowing purposes – not only in gaming and entertainment, but in education and healthcare sectors too. Join experts Richard Nockles (Sky), Alia Sheikh (Freelance Immersive Experiences Consultant) and Max Dennison (Cinesite) in discussion. This session is chaired by Professor Ana-Despina Tudor (London College of Communication).

Date & Time:
5 November | 14:30

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

MAX DENNISON / ANA-DESPINA TUDOR / ALIA SHEIKH / RICHARD NOCKLES

SYNC LICENSING: A CREATIVE AND PRACTICAL GUIDE

An introduction to the world of sync licensing from Beggars Group, one of the world's largest independent label groups. Sync enables creatives to use copyrighted music across commercials, film, video games and television. Hosted by Cat Corrigan, Sync Manager at Beggars' Group, this panel welcomes Tammy Tinawi (Director, Creative Licensing & Producer at Cavendish Music), Karanvir Dayal (Director of Creative Sync for Film & TV) and Kaylee Siegfried (Synchronisation Licensing Manager, Domino Publishing).

Date & Time:
5 November | 14:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

CAT CORRIGAN / KAYLEE SIEGFRIED KARANVIR DAYAL / TAMMY TINAWI

THE ART OF THE SHORT WRITING FOR SCREEN WITH JUSTINE HART

Script consultant Justine Hart has worked with filmmakers and writers across the development process. In this practical masterclass, Hart shares what makes a strong short film concept, and how to chart convincing character shifts within a limited time frame. She will also rethink the traditional feature-length three-act structure for a mini-movie format. The session introduces The Pitch's new paid writing opportunity, offering five writers £2,500 each to develop a short film screenplay. Attend to sharpen your screenwriting.

The Pitch

Date & Time:
5 November | 16:00

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

JUSTINE HART / LUKE WALTON

INTRODUCING THE NEW WAVE OF BRITISH CINEMA

We are excited to welcome back four Aesthetica Film Festival alumni for a celebration of emerging filmmaking talent. This panel includes BAFTA, BIFA and Emmy winners and nominees: Baz Sells (*Two Black Boys in Paradise*), Manjinder Virk (*Out of Darkness*), and Matt Houghton (*This Is Endometriosis*). They will discuss what it took to make their acclaimed projects, which span animation, comedy, drama and documentary. Hear the lessons they learned along the way and what's next for a new generation of British talent.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
5 November | 16:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

BAZ SELLS / MATT HOUGHTON
MANJINDER VIRK / PENNY LEE TAYLOR-BROWN

AI IS HERE: WHAT HAPPENS NEXT?

AI has arrived. What happens next? The use of Artificial Intelligence in the creative industries is a major talking point, raising questions around authorship, ethics as well as environmental impact. In this exclusive session, hear from Hugo Riley, Executive Director of The AI in Media Institute, the UK's independent, sector-led organisation advancing responsible, human-centred AI adoption across media. He will explore answers to: How will AI impact filmmaking? What role should it play, if any at all? And where should the boundaries lie?

AI IN MEDIA INSTITUTE

Date & Time:
5 November | 17:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

HUGO RILEY

GLOBAL TV, REGIONAL CONTEXT: HEAR FROM DERRY GIRLS PRODUCER BRIAN J. FALCONER

Derry Girls is a history-making TV show. The comedy from Lisa McGee follows five students during the Troubles in the early 1990s. It was Channel 4's biggest comedy series premiere in 14 years, and the winner of numerous awards, including multiple BAFTAs and an Emmy. In this talk, hear from the Producer, Brian J. Falconer, whose other credits include *How to Get to Heaven from Belfast* and *Ordinary Love*. He will discuss what it takes to bring regional stories like these to life, in a way that resonates with massive audiences far and wide.

OUT OF ORBIT

Date & Time:
6 November | 10:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

BRIAN J. FALCONER

BOHEMIAN RHAPSODY TO *WUTHERING HEIGHTS*: A MASTERCLASS IN SOUND DESIGN

Film might be a visual medium, but sound is equally vital in shaping narrative and emotion. From dialogue and score to sound effects and foley, carefully crafted audio builds immersion and guides the audience through a story. Academy Award-winning Nina Hartstone and Emmy-winning Louise Burton are both sound editors who have collaborated on major productions including *Bohemian Rhapsody*, *Saltburn* and *Wuthering Heights*. Here, they will draw on their shared experience to explore how audio can be used to bring stories to life.

UKRI Innovate UK Aesthetica

Date & Time:
6 November | 10:00

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

NINA HARTSTONE / LOUISE BURTON

WRITING THE FUTURE: INSIDE THE PITCH'S £2,500 WRITING COMMISSION

The Pitch's new paid writing commission offers five writers £2,500 each to develop an original short film screenplay responding to the question: how is AI changing the way we relate to one another? Join AI ethics researcher Nathan Mladin, alongside Rob McLellan (Virtual Production Supervisor, DNEG), Karol Griffiths (Script Development Consultant), Chine McDonald (Author & Broadcaster) and Nev Pierce (Journalist, Writer & Director) to explore the ideas behind the brief, from intimacy and grief to morality, identity and human nature.

The Pitch

Date & Time:
6 November | 11:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

NATHAN MLADIN / ROB MCLELLAN
KAROL GRIFFITHS / CHINE MCDONALD / NEV PIERCE

A LOOK INSIDE THE ACTOR-DIRECTOR RELATIONSHIP

Some of the most genre-defining films of all time are remembered for their standout performances. This session will explore how the foundations of such work are built, and how collaboration between actor and director shapes unforgettable screen moments. Meet Pamela Jikiemi, an award-winning actor, artist and director who has appeared in shows such as *Ted Lasso* (Apple TV) and *Supacell* (Netflix). She will explain how actors and directors establish trust, navigate feedback and work together to build believable characters.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
6 November | 11:30

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

PAMELA JIKIEMI

THE FINAL CUT: WHAT HAPPENS IN THE EDIT

Step inside the cutting room with two acclaimed editors. Hear from Mick Audsley, a BAFTA-winner whose projects include *Harry Potter and the Goblet of Fire*, *Murder on the Orient Express*, *Twelve Monkeys*, *Allied* and *Dangerous Liasons*. He has 50 years of cinema-defining films in his portfolio. Audsley is joined by Ash White, whose work across film and TV includes *Dreaming Whilst Black*, *Stath Lets Flats* and *Boarders*. In this talk, chaired by Holly Newson, they will offer a behind-the-scenes look at how these standout stories are crafted.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
6 November | 13:00

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

ASH WHITE / HOLLY NEWSON / MICK AUDSLEY

CELEBRATING 50 YEARS: BEHIND THE SCENES AT AARDMAN

2026 is Aardman's 50th anniversary. In 1976, Co-Founders Peter Lord and David Sproxton moved to Bristol to work on their very first professional production, for which they created Morph. They never left the city. Since then, the studio has become synonymous with stop-motion – and a cast of characters who have entertained and charmed the world. Join Will Becher, Director and Creative at Aardman to celebrate five decades of beloved characters – from Wallace and Gromit to Shaun the Sheep and Feathers McGraw.

AARDMAN

Date & Time:
6 November | 13:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Main House

WILL BECHER

BRIEF TO SCREEN: WORKING WITH MAJOR BRANDS

We are surrounded by branded content every day – on social media, TV and in cinemas. Our attention is pulled in countless directions. What makes a campaign truly stick? We welcome Patrick Craig of Blink Productions (Microsoft, Toyota, Vodafone); Laura Abrahams of BBC Storyworks; Pete Fergusson (IPX) and Erin Graham (Freelance Strategist) to answer these questions. Chaired by Penny Lee Taylor-Brown, the discussion will examine how creatives can stay true to a brand's brief whilst still crafting meaningful stories that resonate.

blink somesuch BBC StoryWorks Commercial Productions

Date & Time:
6 November | 13:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

ERIN GRAHAM /PATRICK CRAIG
PETE FERGUSSON / LAURA ABRAHAMS

CALLING THE SHOTS: WOMEN DRIVING PRODUCTION

Meet the women shaping the future of media production. This panel foregrounds trailblazing professionals working across film and TV, including BAFTA-winning Fiona Lamptey, Angela Moneke (Vice President Film Production, Working Title), Gail Egan (Founder, Potboiler Productions) and Rupinder Downie (Filmnova). They join Annabel Grundy (Independent Consultant) to discuss how they broke into the industry and built careers. Find out how they manage teams, make big decisions and the lessons learned along the way.

POTBOILER PRODUCTIONS FILMNOVA WORKING TITLE

Date & Time:
6 November | 14:00

Venue:
YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre

ANNABEL GRUNDY / ANGELA MONEKE
GAIL EGAN / FIONA LAMPTEY / RUPINDER DOWNIE

MAKING UK TELEVISION: IN CONVERSATION WITH HEAD OF DEVELOPMENT AT SCOTT FREE

Heather Salter is Head of Development at Scott Free UK, the film and TV production company of acclaimed directors Ridley and Tony Scott. Since its establishment in 1995, Scott Free's television projects have earned over 100 Emmy nominations with 22 wins and 28 Golden Globe nominations. Current and upcoming projects include *Alien: Earth* (FX) and *Blade Runner 2099* (Amazon). In this talk, Salter discusses the process of TV development in the UK, what the role of a Head of Development involves, with time for audience questions.

SCOTT FREE

Date & Time:
6 November | 14:30

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

HEATHER SALTER / JIM CAMPBELL

WRITING FOR TELEVISION: NEIL FORSYTH IN CONVERSATION

Attend a screenwriting masterclass with BAFTA and Royal Television Society Award-winner Neil Forsyth. His most recent project, Netflix's *Legends*, stars major actors Tom Burke, Steve Coogan and Hayley Squire. Previous credits include *Guilt*, widely regarded as one of the greatest Scottish TV dramas of all time; BBC hit *The Gold*, one of the broadcaster's biggest drama launches of 2023; and *Eric, Ernie and Me*, about writer Eddie Braben. In conversation with fellow writer Alex Mathias (BBC Pilot Scheme), Forsyth reveals the craft of TV drama.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
6 November | 13:30

Venue:
City Screen Cinema Screen 2

NEIL FORSYTH / ALEX MATHIAS

ICONS OF TELEVISION MEET THE BBC COMEDY TEAM

BBC Comedy is the home of British humour, commissioning more across more platforms than anyone else in the UK. The team has been making people laugh for generations, developing new creative voices and working with household names on the likes of *Amandaland* and *Am I Being Unreasonable?*. This panel, chaired by Commissioning Editor Navi Lamba and featuring Roya Eslami (Head of Development) and Nick Coupe (Producer), reveals how comedies get made, and how these stories hold up a mirror to the nation.

BBC Comedy

Date & Time:
6 November | 16:15

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

ROYA ESLAMI / NICK COUPE / NAVI LAMBA

HOW TO MAKE A SHORT: INSIGHTS FROM FILMMAKERS

How does a great short film come together? In this session, you'll meet Charlie Dennis, Jona Headon, Luke Bather, Sara Jade Alfaro-Dehghani and Sophia McDonnell, whose short-form projects are screening as part of this year's festival programme. They'll break down what it takes to make the most of a limited timeframe. From a clear script to a tight edit, this is a craft that requires laser-focused vision, scheduling and resource management. Chaired by Danyele Seignoret, Development and Production Executive at Channel 4.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
6 November | 17:00

Venue:
YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre

CHARLIE DENNIS / LUKE BATHER / JONA HEADON
SARA JADE ALFARO-DEHGHANI / SOPHIA MCDONNELL

BBC WRITERS: WHAT MAKES A GREAT SCRIPT

Development Executive Simon Nelson has over 20 years' experience as an editor, storyliner and producer. He's part of BBC Writers, which provides advice, resources and development opportunities for emerging and established writing talent across the UK. Nelson supports new figures as they develop their voice and navigate the demands of the small screen. Embedded within the BBC's Television Drama Commissioning department, the initiative has helped launch writers on series such as *Daddy Issues*, *Ludwig* and *The Responder*.

BBC WRITERS

Date & Time:
6 November | 17:30

Venue:
Yorkshire Museum

SIMON NELSON

MUSIC SUPERVISION: HOW TO CRAFT A FILM SOUNDTRACK

Jen Moss is an award-winning music supervisor with over 15 years' experience in the industry. Her credits include the acclaimed *I, Tonya* and *Saint Maud,* with four films due for release this year, including award-winning documentary *The Siege of Paradise*. In conversation with Helena Gee (Creative Director, Sync at Warp Records & Founder of Hit The North Music Supervision), Moss shares her passion for storytelling through music by breaking down her role, offering a look at the relationship between film and sound.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
6 November | 17:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

JEN MOSS / HELENA GEE

TELLING SOMEONE'S STORY: DOCUMENTARY PRODUCERS IN CONVERSATION

What does 'truth' really mean in non-fiction filmmaking? To what extent are documentaries influenced by the person behind the camera? And how do we balance storytelling with responsibility? This panel brings together The Guardian's Head of Documentaries Lindsay Poulton; Irene Carter, formerly of Mindhouse, Marguerite Gaudin, AMOS Pictures and Dan Kendall from Windfall Films. They will join chair Lorianne Hall, University of York, to explore the ethics of representation, authorship and accountability in documentary.

windfallfilms

The Guardian DOCUMENTARIES

AMOS PICTURES

Date & Time:
7 November | 10:30

Venue:
YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre

IRENE CARTER / LINDSAY POULTON
DAN KENDALL / LORIANNE HALL / MARGUERITE GAUDIN

SCORING TO PICTURE: IN CONVERSATION WITH ANNA RICE

Multi award-winning composer, lyricist, arranger and producer Anna Rice has worked with acclaimed performers including Lang Lang and Ronnie Wood (The Rolling Stones), and has experience across film (*Re-Creation, Our Blue World*), TV and games. Rice is joined by Kathryn Rodger, Head of Film & TV at Wise Music, who also has nearly 20 years in the industry, pitching and clearing composers and catalogue music for projects such as *Day of the Jackal*, *Amy* and *The Crown*. A chance to hear two experts dissect their field.

Wise Music Group

Date & Time:
7 November | 10:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

KATHRYN RODGER / ANNA RICE

HOW TO MARKET YOUR FILM: PUBLICITY FOR FILM AND TV

There's more than one way to market a film. From *Smile's* unsettling real-world stunts, to *Barbie's* high-end brand partnerships and the viral campaign that launched *The Blair Witch Project*, smart publicity can go a long way in shaping a release's reputation. This session, led by Julie La'Bassiere of DDA Global, focuses on what happens after a film is finished. How do you get people to watch it? La'Bassiere will offer promotion advice, from trailers, posters and press kits, to securing reviews and using social media to get audiences talking.

DDA

Date & Time:
7 November | 12:00

Venue:
YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre

JULIE LA'BASSIERE

MEET ANNE RUDD: COSTUME DESIGNER FOR SCREEN

Join Anne Rudd as she breaks down the key elements of costume design for screen. Rudd's credits include *Father Brown* for the BBC, as well as *Casualty*, *Girlfriends*, *Silent Witness* and *Waterloo Road*. Explore the processes designers use to create iconic looks. Rudd will also discuss the role of clothing in worldbuilding, showing how garments can immerse audiences within a particular time and place. Plus, gain an insight into the collaborative process of working with actors, directors and producers to bring a character or story to life.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
7 November | 12:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

ANNE RUDD

FUNDING YOUR FILM: HOW TO FINANCE A PROJECT

This panel hosts Chloe Charles, Harvey John, Naomi Abel-Hirsch, Paul Oh and Raphaela Wagner from this year's Official Selection. They'll talk about funding sources: where you can find them, and how they might influence factors like ownership rights or future opportunities. They'll give their accounts of how to get your work in front of wider audiences – whether that's working with a sales agent, handling self-distribution, or exploring newer models like online releases. Session chaired by Alex Crowton, York St John University.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
7 November | 13:30

Venue:
YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre

ALEX CROWTON / CHLOE CHARLES / HARVEY JOHN
RAPHAELA WAGNER / PAUL OH / NAOMI ABEL-HIRSCH

THE FUTURE OF VFX: TECHNOLOGIES SHAPING THE INDUSTRY

What does the future of visual effects look like? In this masterclass, leading creatives will explore the tools, technologies and workflows transforming the industry. Chaired by Ben Louden, Viridian FX (House of the Dragon), this conversation welcomes Jen Filchenkova, Dimension Studios (Wicked); Tiago Faria, BlueBolt (Wuthering Heights, Nosferatu) and Mattieu Sinisi, Dupe VFX (Sentimental Value). Together, they will examine the new developments shaping the worlds of filmmaking and commercial content production.

BLUEBOLT visual effects VIRIDIANFX

dupe DIMENSION

Date & Time:
7 November | 13:30

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Studio

BEN LOUDEN / JEN FILCHENKOVA
MATTIEU SINISI / TIAGO FARIA

SECRETS FROM PROGRAMMERS: HOW TO GET YOUR FILM INTO FESTIVALS

Thinking about launching your film on the festival circuit? This is your go-to guide to submissions. Learn what festival programmers are looking for when selecting films for the UK's biggest events. This panel features programmers from Aesthetica Film Festival (MarBelle), BFI Flare (Diana Cipriano), Reclaim the Frame (Melanie Iredale) and London Short Film Festival (Philip Ilson). They provide an insider's look at how to get your film noticed and what it takes to put together a stellar festival line-up. Chaired by Ted Wilkes, UCA.

BFI UCA University for the Creative Arts

RECLAIM THE FRAME LONDON SHORT FILM FESTIVAL Aesthetica

Date & Time:
7 November | 15:00

Venue:
YSJU De Grey Lecture Theatre

DIANA CIPRIANO / MARBELLE
PHILIP ILSON / MELANIE IREDALE / TED WILKES

MEET THE AESTHETICA NEW MUSIC STAGE JURY

Welcome to the New Music Stage. This panel featuring Jury members Rob Cannell (Beggars Group), Sally Bryant (Futuresound Group), Nicolas Tyrell (Culture and Music Journalist), Arusa Qureshi (Writer and former Editor of The List) and singer Rachel Croft will take a dive into the music industry, unpacking the structures that shape how emerging talent is discovered and supported. The Jury will discuss the practical realities of working in music today and the roles of labels and publishers inbreaking acts to wider audiences.

Date & Time:
7 November | 12:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Main House

ARUSA QURESHI / ROB CANNELL
SALLY BRYANT / NICOLAS TYRELL / RACHEL CROFT

BBC INTRODUCING: CHAMPIONING BREAKTHROUGH ARTISTS

Every week, thousands of listeners across the UK tune in to BBC Introducing on Radio 1 – a show hosted by Jess Iszatt, dedicated to championing brand new artists that are breaking through across the nation. It gives up-and-coming names broadcast opportunities alongside the chance to perform at major festivals. Ed Sheeran, Lewis Capaldi, Raye, Sam Fender, Aitch, Olivia Dean and Tom Grennan all received BBC Introducing support. In this session, Iszatt speaks about her career, and the importance of nurturing new talent.

Date & Time:
7 November | 17:00

Venue:
York Theatre Royal Main House

JESS ISZATT

imagesound.com

INDUSTRY WORKSHOPS

TEST OUT YOUR IDEAS. LEARN SOMETHING NEW.

This year we are running a series of practical workshops designed to help you expand your skills and understanding of film, television and VR, in collaboration with world-leading organisations including BBC Writers, Film London, RADA, The Pitch Film Fund, Film Hub North, Spotlight as well as Scottish Games Network and Rocksteady. These sessions are essential for anyone looking to experiment with cutting-edge technologies and learn directly from leading industry experts in person. Hone your writing skills, learn how to adapt historical materials or take a first step towards a career in interactive media.

Sessions last between 60-120 minutes.
Free with Festival Pass. Pre-booking is essential.

THE POWER OF PLAYFUL THINKING WITH THE SCOTTISH GAMES NETWORK

Scottish Games Network is the focal point and community for the rapidly evolving games industry in Scotland. Its More Than Games initiative connects with other creative sectors, from film, TV and animation to theatre, publishing, music, visual arts and fashion. In this session, you'll explore how the tools, technologies and "playful thinking" of the games world can offer innovative solutions for real-world challenges. Discover how cross-sector collaboration opens up new audiences and opportunities – whatever your background.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
4 November | 10:30-11:30

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

SCOTTISH GAMES NETWORK

FILMMAKERS' WORLD CAFÉ: WITH THE VISIONARIES OF OUR OFFICIAL SELECTION

The Filmmakers' World Café is a space for dialogue, connection and practical guidance. Participants move between six round tables, each hosted by a representative from a different area of the industry. Ben Price of Motion Post will lead conversations around Postproduction, whilst Dartmouth Films' Matt Hird brings expertise in Distribution. Steff Boulson of DSP Films will offer advice on Development, and Screen Yorkshire's Jo Schofield and Charlotte Carrick will share insights into Production & Talent. Ted Wilkes (UCA) dives into all things writing.
Please note, this event is by invitation only.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
4 November | 12:00-13:30

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

OFFICIAL SELECTION FILMMAKERS

THE PITCH: LEARN ABOUT ADAPTATION

Join us for an enlightening workshop about adaptation in filmmaking, designed for writers, directors and film lovers interested in the art of transforming source material into screen stories. This session will delve into the intricate process of adapting books and real-life events into films. Through case studies, discussions and exercises, you will gain insights into the delicate balance between fidelity and innovation. In this session The Pitch will focus on the ancient text of The Bible – an enduring source of inspiration – as an example.

Date & Time:
4 November | 14:00-15:00

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

THE PITCH FILM FUND

ROUNDTABLE: FILM HUB NORTH

Got a burning question about filmmaking, production, or career development? Put it to BFI Talent Executives and the filmmaking team behind a BFI-supported short. This is an opportunity to get guidance and exchange ideas with industry and fellow filmmakers. **This event requires prior registration via the Film Hub North website, but there also may be a chance for sign-ups on the day. The session is free to book on to and does not require a valid festival pass. Places are limited so please only sign up if you can attend.**

Date & Time:
4 November | 16:00-17:00

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

FILM HUB NORTH

HOW TO ATTRACT TOP ACTORS TO YOUR SHORT OR FEATURE PROJECT

How do you find the perfect actors to bring your script to life? And how do you get them to say yes? The session is ideal for directors and producers looking to navigate the casting process. Whether you're trying to attract established talent to a short film, or wondering how the casting playbook changes when scaling up to a feature, this workshop has the answers. Hosted by Spotlight and led by Sam Claypole, a Casting Director with credits including the award-winning and BAFTA-nominated BBC comedy *Smoggie Queens*.

SPOTLIGHT

Date & Time:
5 November | 11:30-12:30

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

SAM CLAYPOLE

BBC WRITERS PILOT SCHEME: BREAKING INTO SCREENWRITING

BBC Writers is known for discovering, developing and championing new and experienced writing talent across the UK. As part of this, its Pilot Scheme gives promising screenwriters the opportunity to write the first episode of a potential original series for the BBC. We welcome Alex Mathias and Danny & Lauren McNamara – members of this year's scheme – to deliver an insight into what they have learned. This is a practical session filled with advice on how to come up with original ideas, navigate the industry and take the next steps in your career.

BBC WRITERS

Date & Time:
5 November | 13:00-14:00

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

BBC NEW WRITERS MENTEES

THURSDAY

ROUNDTABLE: CAREERS IN INTERACTIVE MEDIA

Discover the creative possibilities of new, interactive media in this roundtable all about the gaming industry. The session will be led by Adonis Emmanuel (Rocksteady Games), as well as representatives from Investigate.Games as well as our Official Selection developers. Hear how these creatives began their journeys, what skills studios are seeking from new talent, and how you can navigate a path into this fast-evolving field. With space to ask your own questions, you'll gain insight into one of the most compelling art forms of our times.

rocksteady IG Est. 1841 YORK ST JOHN UNIVERSITY

Date & Time:
5 November | 14:30-15:30

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

ADONIS EMMANUEL
INVESTIGATE.GAMES

FRIDAY

FINDING ADAPTABLE IP: FROM IDEA TO SCREEN

This workshop, delivered by Film London, explores how to identify "adaptable IP" and assess whether a concept could become a film, TV series, game, or podcast. Participants will examine commercial viability and what makes a story market-ready across different platforms. The session also unpacks the fundamentals of development, including how ideas evolve into compelling pitches and how projects are shaped from early concept to optioning. You'll gain clarity on IP ownership in collaborations – who owns what and why it matters.

FILM LONDON

Date & Time:
6 November | 10:00-11:00

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

FILM LONDON

INSIDE THE VIRTUAL STUDIO: VOICES FROM THE CREATORS OF OUR OFFICIAL VR SELECTION

Step inside the minds shaping VR at our Official Selection Roundtable. Hear directly from the creators behind this year's standout interactive experiences as they share insights into their process, how they got started and the challenges of building immersive worlds. Whether you're a curious newcomer or seasoned creator, you'll gain fresh perspectives on virtual storytelling – from innovative interaction models to pushing boundaries in XR. Join a dynamic conversation with the voices driving the next wave of immersive media.

Aesthetica

Date & Time:
6 November | 11:30-12:30

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

OFFICIAL SELECTION FILMMAKERS

DIRECTING/WORKING WITH ACTORS FOR SCREEN

This dynamic workshop, led by acclaimed director and RADA tutor Victor Villar-Hauser, offers a rare opportunity to explore the interplay between actor and director in screen storytelling. Focusing on technique, communication and creative vision, the session is designed for those interested in both sides of the camera. Participants will gain insight into the nuances of performance, blocking, and scene interpretation, while developing a deeper understanding of the collaborative language that brings scripts to vivid life.

RADA

Date & Time:
6 November | 13:00-14:30

Venue: Spark
Capacity: 60

VICTOR VILLAR-HAUSER

KIDS' MEDIA WORKSHOPS

FOR THE NEXT GENERATION

We believe in the transformative power of film, both for today's generation and those to come. York is a UNESCO City of Media Arts, and we're passionate about encouraging children and young people to create and explore their own potential. That's why we're offering 7-14 year olds the opportunity to learn how to direct their own films, develop their own games, create animated shorts and act in their own stories. They'll have the chance to be both in front of and behind the camera, gaining insights into the magic of filmmaking and games design. Led by the expert teams at Animation Nation, Computer Xplorers, Investigate.Games and Pauline Quirke Academy. **Pre-booking is essential. All workshops take place at YSJU Creative Centre.**

Book your place at: **asff.co.uk/tickets.** Sessions £20.

WORKSHOP	SATURDAY 7 NOVEMBER	SUNDAY 8 NOVEMBER
Do You Want to Be a Filmmaker **(7-10yrs)**	10:00-12:00	14:00-16:00
Do You Want to Be a Filmmaker **(11-14yrs)**	14:00-16:00	10:00-12:00
How to Make a Game **(7-10yrs)**	10:00-12:00	14:00-16:00
How to Make a Game **(11-14yrs)**	14:00-16:00	10:00-12:00
Screen Acting for Kids **(7-10yrs)**	14:00-16:00	10:00-12:00
Screen Acting for Kids **(11-14yrs)**	10:00-12:00	14:00-16:00
How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation **(7-10yrs)**	14:00-16:00	10:00-12:00
How to Make a Stop-Motion Animation **(11-14yrs)**	10:00-12:00	14:00-16:00

Aesthetica | PAULINE QUIRKE ACADEMY OF PERFORMING ARTS – BE YOURSELF BE AMAZING | ComputerXplorers | IG | Animation nation

DO YOU WANT TO BE A FILMMAKER?

Discover the magic of cinema behind the scenes in our hands-on workshop for kids. Through engaging activities and practical experience, budding directors will begin developing a comprehensive understanding of how the filmmaking process works. Those taking part will learn the fundamentals of camera operation, sound design and direction. By the end of the workshop, each child will have the exciting opportunity to plan, direct and shoot their very own short film.

7-10yrs
7 November | 10:00-12:00
8 November | 14:00-16:00

11-14yrs
7 November | 14:00-16:00
8 November | 10:00-12:00

YSJU Creative Centre

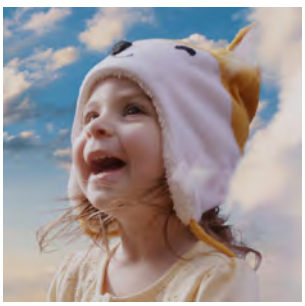
HOW TO MAKE A GAME

Join ComputerXplorers instructors – who are passionate about gaming and nurturing young talent – in a workshop that will introduce children to coding software. Participants will be guided through the whole process, given support and reassurance throughout the session. This is the perfect place to start with coding, enabling children to create their own digital stories, games and animations.

7-10yrs
7 November | 10:00-12:00
8 November | 14:00-16:00

11-14yrs
7 November | 14:00-16:00
8 November | 10:00-12:00

YSJU Creative Centre



SCREEN ACTING FOR KIDS

In this practical workshop, participants devise and create an original super short film from scratch, combining scripting, acting, choreography and filming. Young storytellers explore development and performance on camera, brainstorming imaginative plots and crafting compelling characters while working collaboratively in groups. They learn what it takes to bring an idea to life behind the camera.

7-10yrs
7 November | 14:00-16:00
8 November | 10:00-12:00

11-14yrs
7 November | 10:00-12:00
8 November | 14:00-16:00

YSJU Creative Centre

HOW TO MAKE A STOP-MOTION ANIMATION

Dive into the enchanting world of stop-motion animation in our engaging workshop for kids. Working in pairs or small groups, depending on whether they attend alone or with friends, children will learn the essentials of stop-motion animation. Each group will work together to brainstorm ideas, create their own models, characters, and props using modelling clay, before bringing their creations alive.

7-10yrs
7 November | 14:00-16:00
8 November | 10:00-12:00

11-14yrs
7 November | 10:00-12:00
8 November | 14:00-16:00

YSJU Creative Centre

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NETWORKING

Build relationships, seek out collaborations and make lasting memories. Our Networking and Pitching Sessions make up a key part of the festival, and are places where connections are made and opportunities discovered.

The 2026 Networking events are attended by leading organisations who will advise you on how to master visual effects on a budget, pitch to distributors, and connect with audiences through powerful screenwriting.

Here, we offer in-person attendees the opportunity to meet and interact with representatives from some of the world's leading organisations, from Viridian VFX, Film Hub North and The Pitch.*

Read more about these events in the following pages, and be sure to book where necessary. ***Guests are subject to change at any time.**

NETWORKING SESSION 1

VFX FOR INDIE FILMMAKERS: MAKING THE IMPOSSIBLE WORK ON ANY BUDGET

4 November | 12:00-13:30 | York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer

Visual effects often feel like something reserved for big-budget productions, yet they play a crucial role in bringing stories to life. York-based Viridian FX is a collective of VFX artists and storytellers focused on developing practical, creative workflows that scale to any production size. Their experience ranges from supervising effects on independent shorts to contributing to major productions such as HBO's *House of the Dragon, Now You See Me: Now You Don't*, and Amazon's *Citadel*. Join them for this informal session to explore how to plan VFX, integrate them into production, and use them as a storytelling tool.

VIRIDIANFX

NETWORKING SESSION 2

STORY EXCHANGE: IDEAS IN MOTION WITH FILM HUB NORTH

5 November | 12:00-13:30 | York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer

A relaxed networking session, lead by Film Hub North, which brings together creatives working with narrative across film, television and digital media. Story Exchange: Ideas in Motion is designed as an open space for conversation around storytelling, scripts, and early-stage concepts. Whether you're developing a feature, shaping a short, or exploring a new idea, this session invites you to meet others working with story in all its forms and stages. There are no panels or formal structure – just an opportunity to talk through ideas, share creative interests and discover potential collaborators in an informal setting.

Film Hub North

NETWORKING SESSION 3

BRING YOUR IDEAS: MEET THE PITCH COMMISSIONING TEAM

6 November | 13:00-14:30 | York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer

The Pitch is commissioning five writers to develop new original short film scripts responding to AI, human relationships and what it means to be human. Join The Pitch team following their commission briefing at York Theatre Royal Studio to ask questions, share early ideas and find out more about the paid writing and development process. This informal networking session is open to screenwriters, writer-directors, producers and filmmakers at every stage. You do not need to have a finished pitch. Come and start the conversation.

NETWORKING SESSION 4

POWERING CREATIVITY: PUSHING THE CREATIVE INDUSTRIES FURTHER

6 November | 16:00-18:00 | De Grey Rooms, then York Theatre Royal

This event, held in partnership with York Business School, bridges creativity and commerce, welcoming professionals from diverse sectors. Meet outside the De Grey Rooms (YO1 7HB) at 16:00 and experience the highlight of the year – the UNESCO City of Media Arts EXPO – where businesses from design, film, games and media across the region come together. Then, at 17:00, head to York Theatre Royal and enjoy a free drink, whilst exploring fresh strategies for innovation, expansion and sustainable growth. Gain valuable insights and build collaborations that will help to drive the creative industries forward.

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Aesthetica

NETWORKING SESSION 5

SYNC IN FOCUS: CONNECTING MUSIC AND MOVING IMAGE

7 November | 15:45-16:45 | York Theatre Royal Upper Foyer

This session is an introduction to sync licensing and the power of creative collaboration between sound and screen, bringing together three talks from leading figures across the industry, including representatives from Universal Music, Rough Trade Records and composer Rachel Croft. Together, they'll share insights into how music is placed within film and television. Following the talks, attendees will have the opportunity to connect in an informal networking session to spark conversation, exchange ideas and explore potential collaborations. Taking place as part of the Music at Aesthetica programme.

Aesthetica

NETWORKING SESSION 6

LAST CHANCE ENCOUNTERS WITH AESTHETICA

8 November | 11:00-12:00 | City Screen Basement

As the festival draws to a close, Last Chance Encounters offers a final moment to connect with filmmakers, creatives and professionals. Hosted in the Podcast Lounge at City Screen, this session provides a welcoming space to reflect on the week and continue conversations sparked during Aesthetica Film Festival. Whether you're developing a new project, looking to meet potential collaborators, or extending the relationships formed during the festival, this session is designed to support meaningful exchange. It's a chance to look back on your highlights from Aesthetica, whilst opening the door to what comes next.

Aesthetica

PITCHING SESSIONS

SHARE YOUR NEXT BIG IDEA.

Have a bold film idea? Pitch your project to the people who can make it happen, and bring your story to the screen. Selected participants have been matched with a Development Executive from a leading production company for a 20-minute, one-to-one session. Applications were open to Unlimited Access Pass holders. The focus of these sessions is on development and professional advice, and **funding is not guaranteed.**

CHANNEL 5 (SCRIPTED TELEVISION DRAMA)

Channel 5 Commissioning is responsible for developing and commissioning distinctive, accessible programming across drama, factual and entertainment. Working with a range of both UK and international producers, the team champions popular, character-led storytelling with strong audience appeal. Recent projects include *The Inheritance*, *The Feud*, *All Creatures Great and Small*, and *Riches*.

Date
4 November
Malmaison

Time
12:00-14:00
Invite Only

FILM4 (NARRATIVE FEATURES)

Film4 is Channel 4 Television's feature film division, developing and co-financing bold and original films from the UK and around the world. Their Academy Award-winners include Yorgos Lanthimos' *Poor Things*, Jonathan Glazer's *The Zone of Interest* and Martin McDonagh's *The Banshees of Inisherin*. Recent acclaimed releases include *All of Us Strangers, Saltburn, The Kitchen, Rye Lane* and *Femme*.

Date
4 November
Malmaison

Time
15:30-17:30
Invite Only

RIDLEY SCOTT ASSOCIATES (NARRATIVE SHORTS)

RSA Films is a global production company founded by visionary directors Ridley and Tony Scott. Celebrated for its creative excellence, craft and production expertise, RSA has consistently delivered award-winning campaigns for leading brands and agencies for over 50 years. Its acclaimed short films include distinctive, Oscar-winning work from bold voices across narrative, commercial and experimental film.

Date
4,5 & 6 November
Malmaison

Time
4 Nov: 15:00-17:00
5 Nov: 10:00-12:00
6 Nov: 10:00-12:00
Invite Only

BBC FILM (NARRATIVE SHORTS)

BBC Film is at the forefront of UK independent filmmaking, developing and co-producing distinctive feature-length productions. By championing emerging voices, as well as collaborating with leading writers and directors, it continues to shape the future of British cinema. BBC Film holds a BAFTA for Outstanding British Contribution to Cinema. It has an ambitious slate featuring today's most exciting names.

Date
5 November
Malmaison

Time
10:00-12:00
Invite Only

ITV (SCRIPTED TV DRAMA)

ITV's commissioning teams shape some of the UK's most widely watched original programming, spanning drama, factual, entertainment and comedy. With a main focus on emotionally resonant, high-profile storytelling, they work with both established and emerging producers. Recent commissions include *Mr Bates vs The Post Office*, *The Tower*, *Liar* and *Trigger Point*, reflecting ITV's scale and impact.

Date
5 November
Malmaison

Time
12:00-14:00
Invite Only

THE PITCH (NARRATIVE SHORTS)

The Pitch specialises in narrative stories that reimagine and reinterpret classical narratives. They offer financial support for emerging talent in the film industry, providing unique training and development opportunities. Each year, The Pitch have also awarded production funds of up to £35,000 to short films that adapt the timeless stories from one of cinema's most enduring sources of inspiration – The Bible.

Date
5 November
Malmaison

Time
12:00-14:00
Invite Only

DOC SOCIETY (DOCUMENTARY SHORTS)

The BFI Doc Society Fund supports and develops storytellers across the UK, backing documentaries with bold cultural and social ambitions. Founded in 2005, it is committed to supporting fact-based films and connecting them to audiences worldwide. Recent projects include Kim Hopkins' *Still Pushing Pineapples*, Shiori Itō's *Black Box Diaries*, and the Berlinale-winning *Dahomey* by Mati Diop.

Date
6 November
Malmaison

Time
10:00-12:00
Invite Only

NEAL STREET PRODUCTIONS (NARRATIVE SHORTS)

Neal Street Productions is one of the UK's most respected production companies, known for acclaimed film (*Empire of Light, 1917*), television (*Informer, Britannia, The Third Day*) and theatre. Founded in 2003 by Sam Mendes, Pippa Harris and Caro Newling, it recently celebrated over 20 years of storytelling excellence. Neal Street continues to create distinctive, award-winning projects with international impact.

Date
6 November
Malmaison

Time
14:30-16:30
Invite Only

BBC WRITERS (SCRIPTED TELEVISION DRAMA)

Simon Nelson is a Development Executive at BBC Writers, who oversees writer development across TV, radio and digital platforms. He leads various UK-wide initiatives, programmes and events to discover and nurture emerging screenwriting talent. With extensive experience in scripted development across multiple genres, Simon specialises in helping to shape the future of storytelling across the BBC.

Date
6 November
Malmaison

Time
15:00-17:00
Invite Only

OUT OF ORBIT (NARRATIVE SHORTS)

Out of Orbit is a production company behind distinctive, character-driven storytelling for TV and film. Best known for the cultural phenomenon *Derry Girls*, the company has helped bring sharply observed, irreverent comedy-drama to global audiences. It continues to develop bold scripted projects with writers across the UK and Ireland, focusing on originality, strong voices and stories with humour and heart.

Date
7 November
Malmaison

Time
11:00-13:00
Invite Only

INK FACTORY FILMS (SCRIPTED TELEVISION DRAMA)

The Ink Factory is an independent studio founded by Stephen and Simon Cornwell to produce bold, authored stories for global audiences. With a focus on high-end film and television, the company is best known for adapting the work of English author John le Carré, including *The Night Manager, The Little Drummer Girl* and *The Pigeon Tunnel*. A recent title is *The Plotters*, a Korean-language thriller.

Date
7 November
Malmaison

Time
11:00-13:00
Invite Only

GUARDIAN DOCS (DOCUMENTARY SHORTS)

The Guardian Documentaries is an award-winning strand showcasing short films by independent filmmakers worldwide. Recent highlights include *Fox Chase Boy*, exploring trauma through stand-up comedy, and *No Man Is an Island*, chronicling the UK's gay rights movement. These films exemplify *The Guardian*'s commitment to impactful storytelling that resonates with global audiences.

Date
7 November
Malmaison

Time
15:30-17:30
Invite Only

GOLDFINCH (DOCUMENTARY SHORTS)

First Flights is an incubator for debut feature directors and producers, empowering emerging creatives to craft commercially viable films and build international careers. With a sharp eye for new talent, the First Flights team supports each filmmaker from script to screen. The initiative has collaborated with Anjelica Huston, Bill Nighy, Gary Oldman, Sam Riley and rising talents across the indie screen.

Date
7 November
Malmaison

Time
15:30-17:30
Invite Only

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STAK (PODCASTING)

Stak is a UK-based podcast production company creating original, host-led audio series across sport, culture, comedy, and entertainment. Its slate includes *The Big Cruise Podcast*, *The Football Ramble*, and *F1: Beyond The Grid*, with a focus on personality-driven formats, long-term audience growth.

Date
4 November
Malmaison

Time
12:00-14:00
Invite Only

DARTMOUTH FILMS (DOCUMENTARY FEATURES)

Dartmouth Films is a pioneer of independent documentaries, championing socially engaged storytelling through innovative funding and distribution models. Recent releases include *The Stimming Pool*, *Big Star: The Nick Skelton Story*, *Children of the Cult* and *The Sinking of the Lisbon Mauru*.

Date
4 November
Malmaison

Time
15:00-17:00
Invite Only

DOG EARS (ANIMATION)

Dog Ears focuses on strong design, humour and emotionally engaging narratives for family and younger audiences with global reach and appeal. Best known for the internationally successful series *Puffin Rock*, the company develops character-led storytelling with a warm, playful visual style.

Date
5 November
Malmaison

Time
10:00-12:00
Invite Only

CINESITE (VR & IMMERSIVE)

Cinesite has been a cornerstone of VFX and animation since 1991, consistently bringing stories to life. Its talented team crafts visuals that captivate audiences worldwide, with recent credits including *The Witcher, Warfare, Kaos, Michael, Black Panther: Wakanda Forever* and *Spiderman: No Way Home.*

Date
5 November
Malmaison

Time
11:00-13:00
Invite Only

BBC COMEDY (WRITING FOR COMEDY)

BBC Comedy is the home of British humour, commissioning fresh shows across BBC platforms. The team champions new creative voices and works with household names. Recent releases include *Death Valley* with Timothy Spall, *Smoggie Queens,* and animated comedy series *The Golden Cobra.*

Date
6 November
Malmaison

Time
11:00-13:30
Invite Only

UBISOFT (GAMES)

Ubisoft Reflections has over 40 years of experience making video games; it is the longest-lasting studio of its kind in the UK. Its team has contributed to many of Ubisoft's iconic IPs, both leading and co-leading projects such as *The Division, Assassin's Creed Nexus VR* and *Avatar: Frontiers of Pandora.*

Date
6 November
Spark

Time
15:00-17:00
Invite Only

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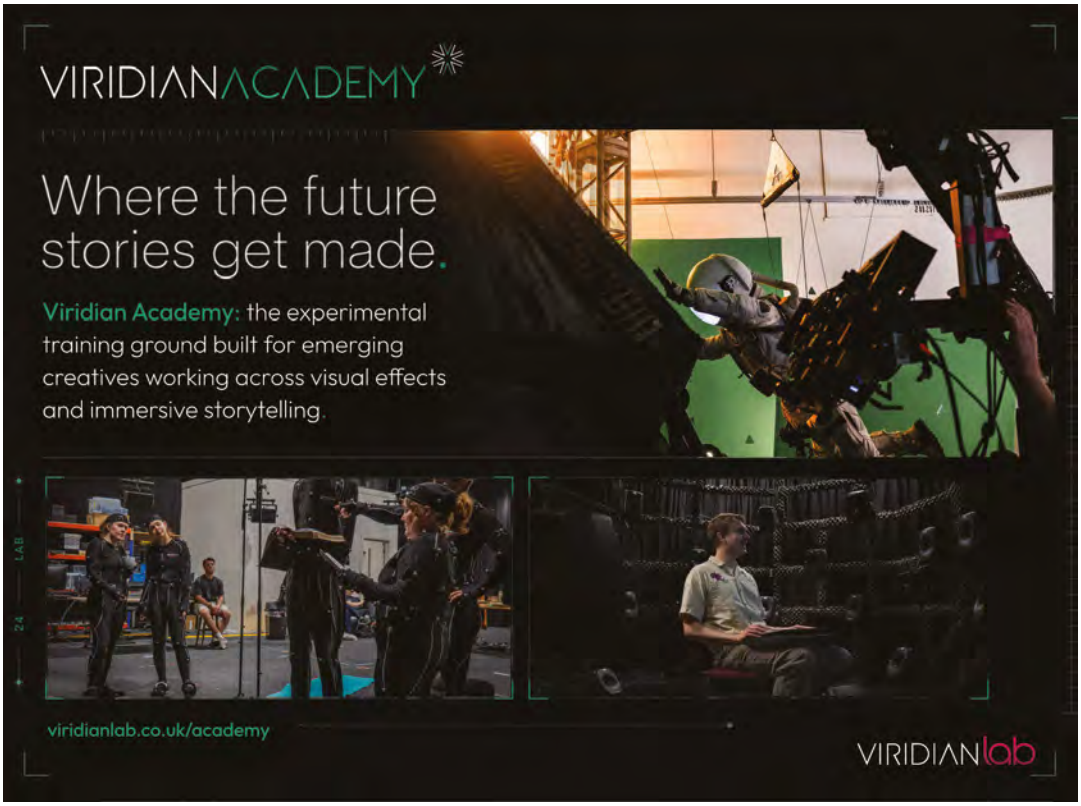
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Sir Gary Oldman, Dame Joan Collins, Jenna Ortega, Dame Emma Thompson, and Ralph Fiennes are just a few of the illustrious guests who have chosen to dine at The Ivy St Helen's Square York – so it makes perfect sense that a restaurant so synonymous with the film and theatre industry has chosen to support this year's Aesthetica Film Festival.

Among the festival's numerous events is an exclusive celebration of Women in Film hosted at The Ivy St Helen's Square, inside it's private dining space - The Etty Room. Top female directors, producers and screenwriters from across the world's film industry will enjoy an incredible evening with ITV News Anchor Nina Hossain in conversation with Suzanne Mackie, Executive Producer of The Crown and Founder of Orchid Pictures.

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